

Caput Mortuum

The Hebdomadal Machine, the Triple Capital, and the Ethics of the Eighth Day in David Fincher and Andrew Kevin Walker's Se7en *(1995)*

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GULA
1
INVIDIA
6
LUXURIA
4
AVARITIA
2
IRA
7
SUPERBIA
5
ACEDIA
3

Abstract

This dissertation advances a comprehensive reinterpretation of *Se7en* (dir. David Fincher; screenplay by Andrew Kevin Walker; New Line Cinema, 1995) as a theological-political allegory of totalization whose narrative, visual, and iconographic architecture is organized around a single overdetermined object: the severed head delivered, on the seventh day, in a cardboard box that the film never opens to its spectator. Against the two dispositions that have governed the film's reception—the first reading it as an exercise in fashionable nihilism that vindicates its retiring detective's despair, the second as an unwitting brief for the punitive moralism of the mid-1990s culture wars—I argue that *Se7en* is a rigorous anatomy of what I term the *hebdomadal machine*: a self-completing apparatus of seven days and seven sins through which its author, the self-erased "John Doe," seeks to convert an unnamed, apathetic, and illegible city into a closed scriptural text.

The machine binds together three historically distinct regimes of the capital, each derived from the Latin *caput*. The first is theological: the *vitia capitalia* of patristic and scholastic moral theology, transmitted from Evagrius Ponticus through John Cassian and Gregory the Great to Thomas Aquinas, who derives the adjective explicitly from the head as principle and director of the body. The second is juridical: capital punishment, understood as the sovereign's prerogative over the head of the subject, traced through Hobbes, Schmitt, Benjamin, Foucault, and Agamben. The third is economic: capital as the abstract dominion of value over the bodies of the city, read through Marx, Brecht and Weill, Debord, and Benjamin's fragment on capitalism as religion. The three capitals converge upon the head of Tracy Mills, which I theorize as the *caput mortuum* of Doe's opus: the alchemists' "dead head," the residue that the Great Work must produce in order to complete itself and which simultaneously exceeds, indicts, and survives it.

Methodologically, the dissertation develops a hybrid hermeneutic, *theo-forensic exegesis*, which reads the crime scene as scripture and scripture as crime scene by bringing the medieval fourfold sense into structured confrontation with the evidential paradigm reconstructed by Carlo Ginzburg. Its seven chapters, each organized under one capital vice in the order of Doe's sequence, trace the film's genealogy through Dante, Milton, Chaucer, Spenser, Marlowe, Bosch, Shakespeare, Middleton, Hogg, Kafka, Dostoevsky, Chesterton, Borges, Eco, and Dürrenmatt; through scriptural and mythic archetypes from Pandora's jar and the *Oresteia* to the Akedah, the

Book of Job, and the writing on Belshazzar's wall; through the theoretical corpora of Nietzsche, Freud, Bataille, Girard, Kristeva, Levinas, Derrida, Barthes, Camus, and Arendt; and across a comparative field encompassing Lang, Powell, Bergman, Tarkovsky, Scorsese, Hardy, Alan Moore, Bowie's
1. Outside
, *Silent Hill*, *Fullmetal Alchemist*, and *True Detective*. The film is situated within the apocalyptic conjuncture of 1995—the aftermath of Waco and its Seven Seals, Oklahoma City, Aum Shinrikyo, the publication of the Unabomber manifesto three days before the film's release, and the institutionalization of "zero tolerance" policing —and Doe is read as the theologian of zero tolerance.

The central claim is that the film's ethical horizon lies not in the completion of the series but in its remainder. *Se7en* is an apophatic text, a negative theology of the image whose refusals—to show the head, to depict any killing except the one committed by an officer of the law, to grant catharsis—constitute its most affirmative gestures. Against heptadic closure the film proposes, in its senior detective's laconic decision to remain, what I name an *ethics of the eighth day*: an ogdoadic ethics of persistence within the unfinished, which refuses both the apathetic withdrawal of the neutral and the apocalyptic consummation of the sovereign.

Note on Texts, Translations, and Citation

The film is cited from its theatrical release and named throughout as *Se7en*, preserving the typographic substitution of numeral for letter that the first chapter treats as a hermeneutic datum in its own right. Its dialogue is paraphrased rather than transcribed, except where a single phrase is itself the object of analysis; the argument concerns the film's structures, not the reproduction of its script. Dante is cited by canticle, canto, and line from the Petrocchi text; Milton's *Paradise Lost* by book and line from the second edition of 1674; Aquinas's *Summa Theologiae* by part, question, and article; Gregory the Great's *Moralia in Job* by book, chapter, and section; and Scripture from the Authorized (King James) Version unless the Vulgate is specified. Translations from Greek, Latin, Italian, French, and German are my own unless otherwise indicated. Secondary and theoretical works are cited by author and date of first publication, with internal divisions (part, chapter, section, aphorism) preferred to edition-specific pagination, so that the reader may consult any reliable edition; a consolidated bibliography follows the final chapter. Production figures, where given, are approximate.

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THE TRIPLE CAPITAL

three regimes of the head

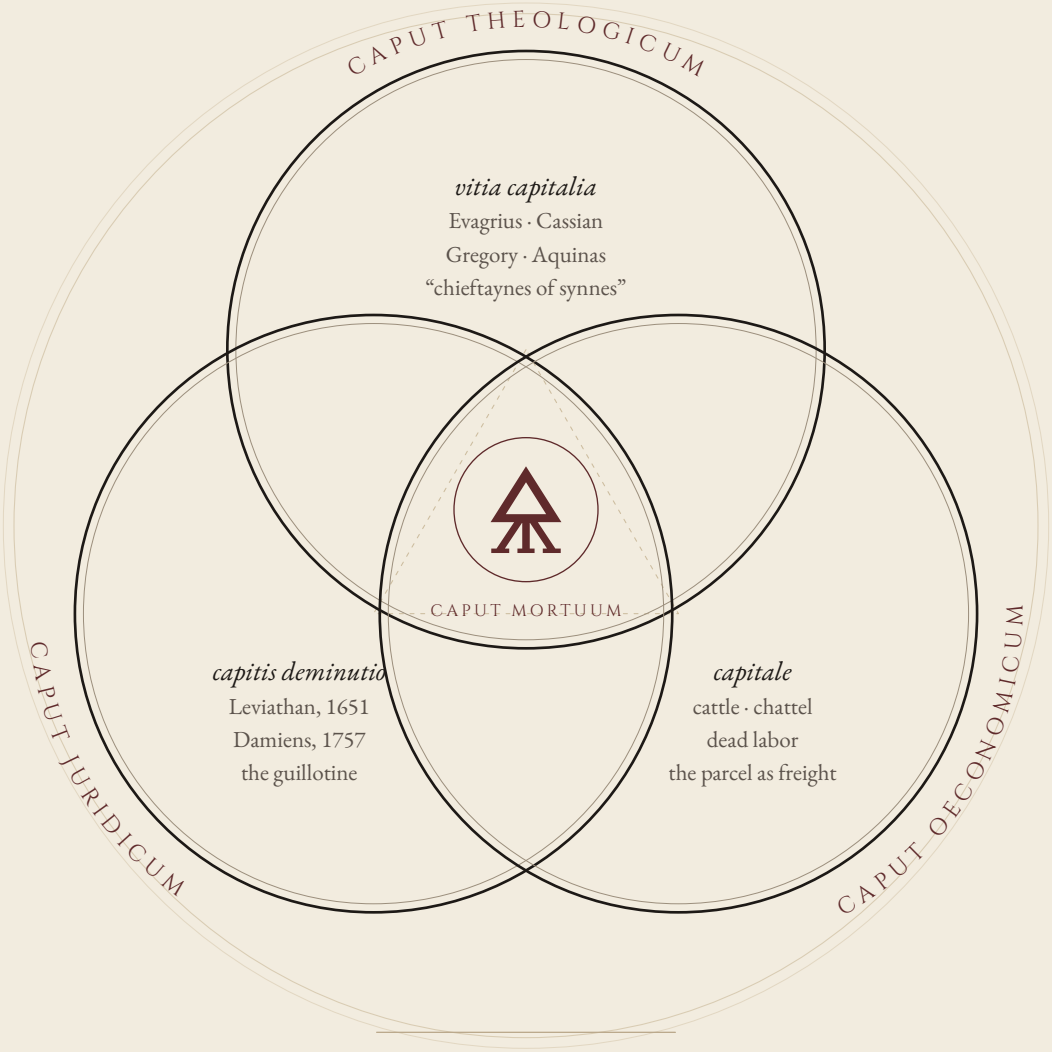


FIG. 01 THE TRIPLE CAPITAL

Three regimes of the caput*—the theological capital vices, the juridical prerogative over the head, and capital as the dominion of value—converge on a single object: the head delivered on the seventh day, which the dissertation reads as the* caput mortuum *of Doe's opus, the residue the Work produces and cannot absorb.*

The First Day

Gula

Gluttony



The Appetite for Meaning

Theo-Forensic Exegesis and the Triple Capital

long is the way / And hard, that out of Hell leads up to light.

— *John Milton, Paradise Lost (1674), II.432–33, spoken by Satan before the infernal council*

Capitale dicitur a capite. [The capital is so called from the head.]

— *Thomas Aquinas, Summa Theologiae I-II, q. 84, a. 3*

1.1

Prolegomenon: The Head and the Series

Se7en ends with a box, and every interpretation of the film is finally an interpretation of that box. Corrugated, taped, addressed by name to a homicide detective, delivered by a commercial courier at an hour fixed in advance into a desolate tract of scrub and high-voltage pylons beneath the only unclouded sky the film permits, it contains the head of Tracy Mills—an object the narrative makes absolutely central and the image track absolutely withholds. The critical tradition has, with few exceptions, treated this box as a terminus: a twist, a shock, a *coup de théâtre* whose function is exhausted in the instant of its disclosure. The present study proceeds from the inverse premise. The head in the box is not the film's conclusion but its *archē*, the principle from which its entire heptadic architecture must be read backward, much as Christian exegesis has always read the six days of Genesis backward from the Sabbath in which they are completed and toward which they tend. To begin with the box is to begin where the film's antagonist begins, for John Doe has composed his seven-day sequence in full knowledge of its final term. It is also to begin where his design fails, since what the box contains is the one element of the series that cannot be assimilated to the rhetoric of deserved punishment in which the other six are framed.

The interpretive key lies in an etymology the film never states and everywhere enacts. The capital vices of Latin moral theology—the *vitia capitalia* that English, through a long vernacular slippage toward the category of mortal sin, has learned to call "deadly"—are capital because they are heads. Thomas Aquinas, systematizing a tradition that runs from the Egyptian desert to the papal chancery, explains that the term derives from *caput*, the member that is the principle and director of the whole animal, and is extended by metaphor to whatever originates and governs a series; a capital vice is one from which other vices spring as from a source and toward whose end they are ordered (*ST* I-II, q. 84, a. 3). *Se7en* literalizes both adjectives its tradition has bequeathed to it. Its sins are deadly in the most banal and therefore most terrible sense, since each one kills; and they are capital in the most literal sense available to cinema, since the series terminates in a severed head from which its final two members, envy confessed and wrath enacted, are directly generated. The culminating object of the film is, in the strictest scholastic sense, the *caput* of its sequence: the head

from which the last members of the series proceed and toward which the whole is ordered.

From this etymological hinge the dissertation develops its governing construct, the *hebdomadal machine*. By this I mean the self-completing apparatus of seven days and seven sins through which Doe seeks to transform an unnamed, rain-sodden, apathetic city into a closed text whose every element signifies, whose sequence is fixed in advance, and whose last word belongs to its author. The machine possesses a theological program (the demonstration of a guilt the city has ceased to perceive), a juridical form (the sovereign punishment of offenses the law has ceased to prosecute), and an economic medium (the circulation of bodies, images, and parcels through a city whose every relation is mediated by exchange). Each of these registers is a regime of the capital, and each converges upon the box. The head that arrives by courier is at once the theological *caput* of the series, the juridical *caput* whose severance is the oldest emblem of capital punishment, and the economic *caput*—the head counted as stock, the parcel delivered on schedule—of a city in which even atrocity must arrive as a commodity. I name this triple convergence the *capital remainder*, and, borrowing from an alchemical tradition whose vocabulary of the Work and its stages Doe's project grimly parodies, the *caput mortuum*: the "dead head" that the adepts identified as the inert residue left in the vessel after the volatile spirit had been drawn off, the worthless precipitate the Great Work must produce in order to be complete and which nevertheless remains, unredeemed, at the bottom of the alembic.

The argument may be compressed into eight propositions, the eighth of which exceeds and reframes the seven that precede it. First, *Se7en* is formally a closed serial machine whose closure is authored by its antagonist but can be completed only by its protagonists: the detectives are not outside the series they investigate but are its final terms, so that the hermeneutic circle closes, quite literally, upon the hermeneuts. Second, the series is organized by three regimes of the capital—theological, juridical, economic—that converge on a literal head. Third, the film stages a conflict between two hermeneutic paradigms, the exegetical and the evidential, and its crime scenes are hybrid texts that must be read in both modes at once; the method appropriate to them is what I call theo-forensic exegesis. Fourth, Doe is a figure of sovereign decision in Carl Schmitt's sense, possessed of meaning without legal force, who confronts a police apparatus possessed of force without meaning; the climax fuses the two in a single gunshot that constitutes the purest image of sovereign violence in the American cinema of its decade. Fifth, the hinge of the series is not wrath but envy, the mimetic sin *par excellence*, and the series completes itself through the contagion of imitation that René Girard located at the origin of sacrificial violence. Sixth, the film is the document of a precise historical conjuncture, the apocalyptic year of

1995, and its antagonist is best understood as the theologian of the "zero tolerance" doctrine then being installed as the governing philosophy of American urban order. Seventh, the film is apophatic: its refusals—to show the head, to depict any killing but the one committed by a police officer, to permit the purgation its Dantean source promises and its Aristotelian form implies—are not evasions but its most affirmative ethical acts. Eighth, the ethical horizon of the film lies not within the series but in its remainder, in what the heptad produces but cannot absorb: the unseen face, the unborn child, the day after the seventh, and the decision of an aging detective to stay. This last proposition I name the *ethics of the eighth day*, after the patristic doctrine of the *dies octavus*, the day beyond the Sabbath on which the closed week of creation is opened onto what exceeds it.

The stakes of this reading are not merely interpretive. *Se7en* has been among the most imitated American films of the past three decades; its visual grammar—the desaturated palette, the flashlight beam cutting through domestic squalor, the forensic tableau composed as aesthetic object, the killer as author of a legible program—has become the default idiom of the prestige crime narrative across film, television, and interactive media. To understand what the film actually argues is therefore to understand what an entire representational regime has inherited, frequently without reading it: a theory of evil as seriality, a theory of interpretation as complicity, and a theory of ethics as remainder. The film's imitators have, with few exceptions, taken over its machine and discarded its remainder. They reproduce the series; they forget the box.

1.2

The First Corpse as Methodological Allegory

The series opens with gluttony, and the choice is neither arbitrary nor merely expedient. Doe's first victim is discovered by flashlight in a squalid apartment, his enormous body bound and slumped face-down in a plate of spaghetti; he has been fed at gunpoint until the body could take no more and then, by the coroner's reconstruction, struck so that the distended stomach ruptured. Outside, the rain falls as it will fall almost without remission until the last day. The scene is staged with the meticulous squalor that would become the film's signature, but its deeper logic is citational. Dante's third circle, the circle of the gluttons, is a place of rain: "*Io sono al terzo cerchio, de la piova / etterna, maladetta, fredda e greve; / regola e qualità mai non l'è nova*"—"I am in the third circle, of the rain eternal, accursed, cold, and heavy;

its measure and its quality are never new" (*Inf.* VI.7–9). The shades lie prostrate in the muck beneath that rain while Cerberus, the beast with three throats, barks over them and flays them. The climate of *Se7en*, which criticism has routinely attributed to the influence of *Blade Runner* (1982) and the urban noir, is in the first instance the climate of the third circle. Before Doe's sequence has even been named, the film has placed its entire city in the weather Dante reserved for those who made their belly their god.

The citation runs deeper, for the third circle contains a prophecy. It is there that the pilgrim meets Ciacco—the nickname means "hog"—a Florentine glutton who, asked about the fate of his city, replies that it is so full of envy that the sack already overflows (*Inf.* VI.49–51), and that "*superbia, invidia e avarizia sono / le tre faville c'hanno i cuori accesi*"—pride, envy, and avarice are the three sparks that have set all hearts aflame (VI.74–75). The circle of the gluttons thus houses an oracle concerning a city's ruin by precisely the three vices that will organize the remainder of Doe's design: avarice in the second murder, pride in the fifth, and envy in the sixth, the single sin the killer will claim as his own. Read against its Dantean template, the first corpse of *Se7en* is not merely the first term of the series but its augury, an overture in which the city's subsequent destruction is announced from beneath the rain.

The position of gluttony at the head of the sequence also recapitulates the ascetic origins of the doctrine. In the earliest systematic catalogue of the "thoughts" (*logismoi*) that assail the monk, composed by Evagrius Ponticus in the Egyptian desert toward the end of the fourth century, the list begins with *gastrimargia*, the madness of the belly, and proceeds through fornication, avarice, sadness, anger, *akēdia*, and vainglory to pride (*Praktikos* 6). John Cassian, who carried the scheme into the Latin West, devotes the first of his books on the vices to gluttony and insists that the monk cannot enter the higher spiritual combats until the belly has been subdued (*De institutis coenobiorum* V). The belly is the gate. Gregory the Great would later reorganize the scheme from the summit downward, crowning pride as queen and relegating gluttony to the sixth place among her generals, and it is Gregory's order that Dante's mountain of Purgatory follows. Doe begins, however, where the desert begins. His first victim is chosen for the most elementary, least spiritual, most bodily of the sins, and the sequence will climb from the flesh toward the spirit, culminating in the triad of pride, envy, and wrath that Gregory and Dante place at the summit of gravity. The structural significance of this ascent occupies the final section of this chapter; it suffices for now to observe that the series opens in the monastery's refectory and closes before a throne.

The first corpse also furnishes the dissertation's methodological allegory. Somerset's investigation turns on a detail the autopsy nearly passes over: fragments of

plastic recovered from the dead man's stomach, which lead the detective back to the apartment, to the floor before the refrigerator, and thence to the word GLUTTONY written in grease on the wall behind it, together with the first of Doe's epigraphs. Interpretation begins, in other words, with the indigestible—with what the body swallowed but could not assimilate, the residue that passed through the organs of consumption without being consumed. This is the first appearance in the film of the structure I have called the remainder, and its placement is exact. The glutton is the man who assimilates everything; his corpse yields up the one thing he could not assimilate; and that unassimilable fragment is the clue that opens the series to reading. The method of this dissertation rests on the same wager: that the meaning of the hebdomadal machine is to be sought not in what it digests but in what it cannot.

The relation between eating and reading is not a figure imposed on the film from without; it belongs to the deepest stratum of the scriptural tradition on which Doe draws. The prophet Ezekiel is commanded to eat a scroll "written within and without" with lamentations, and reports that "it was in my mouth as honey for sweetness" (Ezek. 2:10; 3:3); the seer of Patmos, similarly commanded, records that the little book was "in my mouth sweet as honey: and as soon as I had eaten it, my belly was bitter" (Rev. 10:10). Prophecy, in this tradition, is ingestion: the word is not heard but swallowed, and its sweetness in the mouth gives way to bitterness in the belly. Doe's first murder stages a grotesque literalization of the scene of prophetic eating. He force-feeds a man until the belly bursts, and leaves at the site a text—a line of Milton—that the detectives must in their turn consume. The pattern of sweetness turning to bitterness describes, moreover, the film's relation to its own audience with uncanny precision. *Se7en* offers itself in the mouth as a genre film, with the familiar savors of the mismatched partnership, the procedural puzzle, and the ingenious killer, and it turns in the belly into something the genre cannot digest.

The film elaborates this alimentary hermeneutic through its contrast between two regimes of reading. Somerset passes a night in the public library, amid the guards' card game and a portable stereo playing the *Air* from Bach's Third Orchestral Suite, consulting Dante, Chaucer, and Aquinas; Mills, at home, labors with audible exasperation through a commercial study guide to the *Divine Comedy*. The contrast is easily, and usually, read as a matter of temperament or class. Francis Bacon supplies a more exact lexicon: "Some books are to be tasted, others to be swallowed, and some few to be chewed and digested" ("Of Studies," 1625). The study guide is a digest in the most literal sense, a text pre-chewed for rapid swallowing, culture in the form of fast food. Mills reads as the glutton eats, quickly and without assimilation; Somerset reads as the ascetic eats, slowly and with attention to what resists. Neither mode, as the film will demonstrate, is adequate to Doe's text, which has been composed precisely

to be digested by the one and swallowed by the other, so that both readers end by being consumed.

Baudelaire's prefatory poem to *Les Fleurs du mal* (1857) offers a final figure for the appetite that the film's first sin inaugurates. Among the vices that yelp and crawl in the menagerie of the soul, the poet singles out one as uglier and fouler than all the rest: Ennui, who "*ferait volontiers de la terre un débris / Et dans un bâillement avalerait le monde*"—who would gladly reduce the earth to rubble and swallow the world in a yawn—and who "*rêve d'échafauds en fumant son houka*," dreams of scaffolds while smoking his hookah. In Baudelaire's monster, gluttony and sloth are fused: boredom is an appetite, and its object is the world. The city of *Se7en*, as Somerset diagnoses it, is governed by exactly this compound vice—an apathy that consumes everything and digests nothing, a bored voracity that dreams, like Baudelaire's Ennui, of scaffolds. Doe's program may be understood as the attempt to give that dream a body. The poem ends by turning upon its own audience, the "*hypocrite lecteur*," the reader who is the poet's likeness and brother; and the film, as subsequent chapters will show, performs the same turn. Its spectator, who has come to the cinema to consume a spectacle of murder, is from the first sequence placed in the third circle among the gluttons, beneath the rain.

1.3

Three Capitals: *Caput Theologicum*, *Caput Juridicum*, *Caput Oeconomicum*

The doctrine of the capital vices is, from its first Latin formulation, a doctrine of heads and of rule. Gregory the Great's decisive reorganization of the Evagrian scheme in the *Moralia in Job* is cast as a political and military allegory: "*Ipsa namque vitiorum regina superbia cum devictum plene cor ceperit, mox illud septem principalibus vitiis, quasi quibusdam suis ducibus devastandum tradit*"—"for pride, the queen of the vices, once she has wholly captured the conquered heart, straightway hands it over to the seven principal vices, as to certain of her generals, to be laid waste" (XXXI.45.87). Gregory then names the generals—vainglory, envy, anger, melancholy, avarice, gluttony of the belly, and lust—and assigns to each an army of "daughters," the derivative sins that follow in its train. The structure is at once genealogical and sovereign: a queen at the head, seven commanders beneath her, and beneath them the host. When Aquinas formalizes the doctrine he renders the political metaphor anatomical without abandoning it. *Capitale dicitur a capite*: the capital is named from the head,

which is properly that member of the animal which is the principle and director of the whole, so that by extension every principle is called a head; a capital vice is therefore one from which others arise as from their origin, chiefly by way of final causality, inasmuch as its end is so desirable that the will commits many further sins in its pursuit (*ST* I-II, q. 84, aa. 3–4). The Middle English tradition preserved the sense. Chaucer's Parson, about to enumerate the seven deadly sins, glosses them at once as "chieftaynes of synnes," the captains or heads of sin. "Deadly" and "capital" are two vernacular translations of a single structure, and *Se7en* activates both: its sins kill, and they culminate in a head. This is the *caput theologicum*.

The second capital is the prerogative of the sovereign over the life of the subject, historically figured as dominion over the head. Roman law already identified civil personhood with the *caput*: the *capitis deminutio*, the "diminution of the head," denoted the loss of status—freedom, citizenship, membership in a family—by which a person ceased, in whole or in part, to be a legal subject. Capital punishment in the European tradition was for centuries a hierarchy of heads, the noble beheaded by the sword while the commoner was hanged, and the guillotine's revolutionary innovation, as Daniel Arasse showed in his study of the machine and the imaginary of the Terror (1987), was to extend the aristocratic privilege of decapitation to every citizen alike. The frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) remains the emblem of the entire juridical-political imaginary: a crowned head surmounting a body composed of innumerable tiny subjects, sovereignty pictured literally as the head of a body politic. Against this background the killer's name acquires its full juridical resonance. "John Doe" is the law's placeholder for a person whose identity is unknown or withheld: a fictive litigant, a corpse without a name, a subject reduced to a juridical *caput* without a proper noun. Doe has reduced himself to this condition deliberately, razoring away the papillary ridges of his fingertips and withholding every datum of biography, so that he confronts the law as the pure form of its own legal fiction. At the same time he arrogates the sovereign's prerogative over the heads of others, pronouncing and executing sentence upon offenses the law has ceased to prosecute. Michel Foucault's genealogy of punishment opens with the dismemberment of the regicide Damiens in 1757, the paradigm of a "spectacle of the scaffold" that the modern disciplinary order would replace with the timetable, the examination, and the cell (*Surveiller et punir*, 1975, Part I). Doe reinstalls the scaffold within the disciplinary city. His punishments are public, legible, and analogical, each designed to resemble the crime it chastises and to be read by an audience—exactly what Foucault, describing the penal reformers of the late eighteenth century, called a "semio-technique" of punishment, the penalty conceived as a sign. The film completes the juridical capital by staging, in an empty

field and without trial, the summary execution of the self-declared sovereign by an officer of the law. This is the *caput juridicum*.

The third capital is the most etymologically humble and the most historically consequential. *Capitale*, in medieval Latin, denoted the principal of a loan as distinct from its interest, and derives ultimately from *caput* in the sense of a head of livestock; English "cattle" and "chattel" are its cognates, and wealth was once reckoned, literally, by heads. Marx, who knew this philology, described capital as dead labor that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labor (*Das Kapital* I, ch. 10), and as coming into the world dripping from head to foot, from every pore, with blood and dirt (I, ch. 31). The city of *Se7en* is a city of capital in this sense: an unnamed metropolis of decaying tenements, all-night diners, massage parlors, law offices, and fashion studios, in which every human relation appears mediated by money and every body by its exchange value. Doe's victims are figures of that economy's excess. The glutton embodies consumption without end; the defense attorney, the conversion of justice into a fee; Victor, the drug dealer, the commodification of intoxication; the sex worker, the commodification of the body; the model, the commodification of the face. Even the investigation is subject to the market. Somerset obtains the decisive library records by paying a contact in the Federal Bureau of Investigation, so that the path to Doe runs through a cash transaction for illegally gathered information. And the final sin arrives as a commodity in the most literal sense: a parcel in the circulation of goods, delivered by a courier whose driver has been paid to arrive at an exact place and time. This is the *caput oeconomicum*.

The three capitals are not independent registers that happen to coincide; they are historically and conceptually entangled, and *Se7en* is the film in which their entanglement becomes visible. Walter Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921) proposed that capitalism is not merely conditioned by religion but is itself a religion —a pure cult without dogma, of permanent duration, that produces not expiation but guilt, *Schuld*, a word that in German signifies both guilt and debt. The theological doctrine of sin, the juridical punishment of guilt, and the economic regime of debt appear, in this light, as three faces of a single structure. Doe's project is to render that structure legible by forcing all three capitals into a single object. Tracy Mills's head is the theological *caput* from which the final sins proceed, the juridical *caput* whose severance precipitates a capital execution, and the economic *caput* delivered as freight.

Julia Kristeva, curating the exhibition *Visions capitales* at the Louvre in 1998, traced the severed head through the history of Western representation—from Neolithic skull cults through Medusa, John the Baptist, and the guillotine—as the privileged figure of the sacred and of the threshold at which representation confronts its own collapse; the title of her accompanying study turns on the very pun this

dissertation exploits. The severed head is a capital vision because it stands at the head of the iconographic order and marks the point at which the image meets what it cannot contain. *Se7en* is the capital vision of the American 1990s, with one decisive difference from the tradition Kristeva surveys: it refuses to show its head at all. That refusal is the subject of the seventh chapter. It must be named here because it governs the logic of the whole: the three capitals converge on an object the film declines to convert into an image, and the declining is the first and most important of the film's acts of resistance to the economy it depicts.

The convergence may be stated, finally, in the idiom of the vernacular. To "lose one's head" is to surrender to passion, to cease to govern oneself by reason—classically, to yield to wrath. In the last scene of *Se7en* one character has lost her head literally and another loses his figuratively, and the series is completed in the exchange between them. The head that Doe has severed is converted, through Somerset's stricken face and Doe's quiet narration, into the head that Mills loses. The capital passes from the box to the man.

1.4

Theo-Forensic Exegesis: The Fourfold Sense and the Evidential Paradigm

A TEXT COMPOSED by a theologian and deposited at crime scenes demands a method adequate to both of its origins. The method developed in this dissertation, theo-forensic exegesis, is constructed by bringing two great Western hermeneutic paradigms into structured confrontation: the medieval doctrine of the fourfold sense of Scripture, and the modern evidential paradigm of the clue.

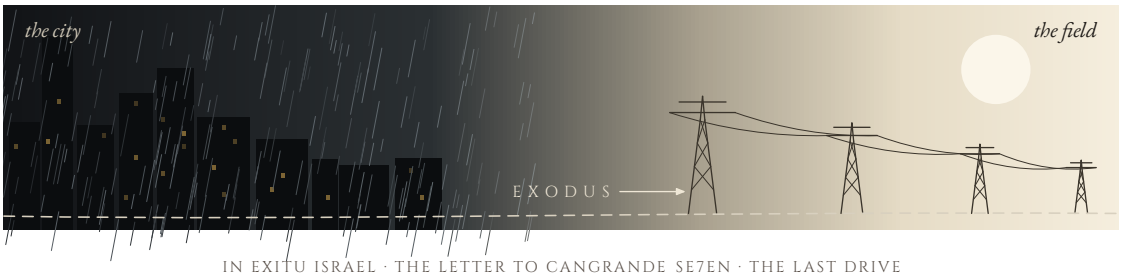
The first is summarized in the thirteenth-century distich attributed to the Dominican Augustine of Dacia: "*Littera gesta docet, quid credas allegoria, / moralis quid agas, quo tendas anagogia*"—the letter teaches what was done, allegory what you are to believe, the moral sense what you are to do, anagogy whither you are tending. Henri de Lubac's monumental *Exégèse médiévale* (1959–64) reconstructed the doctrine's long development and insisted that the four senses are not arbitrary superimpositions but the articulation of a single movement, from history through doctrine and conduct toward the last things. The letter to Cangrande della Scala traditionally attributed to Dante—in any case a faithful witness to his milieu—illustrates the doctrine with the psalm *In exitu Israel de Aegypto*: literally, the departure of the children of Israel from Egypt in the time of Moses; allegorically, our redemption

wrought by Christ; morally, the conversion of the soul from the grief and misery of sin to the state of grace; anagogically, the exodus of the sanctified soul from the bondage of this corruption to the liberty of eternal glory (*Epistola* XIII). It is not accidental that the paradigmatic instance of the fourfold sense is an exodus, a passage out of bondage into light, for this is precisely the figure Doe's first epigraph proposes. Satan's words to the infernal council—"long is the way / And hard, that out of Hell leads up to light"—name an exodus, and the film's own trajectory, from the dark and rain-bound city to the sunlit field in which the series ends, enacts one. Read according to the fourfold sense, that exodus yields four meanings. Literally, three men drive out of a city into open country. Allegorically, the drive is a *via dolorosa* toward a place of execution, its terminus a parodic Golgotha of steel transmission towers. Morally, it is the passage of a soul—Mills's—from law into wrath, a conversion in reverse. Anagogically, it is the movement out of the city of sin into a light that proves to be not the glory of the last day but the merciless exposure of apocalypse in its etymological sense of unveiling. The Miltonic promise is fulfilled to the letter and inverted in its spirit: the way out of hell does lead up to light, and the light is where the damnation is consummated.

The second paradigm is the one Carlo Ginzburg reconstructed in his essay on the roots of the evidential paradigm (1979). In the closing decades of the nineteenth century, Ginzburg observed, three practices converged upon a common method: Giovanni Morelli's technique for attributing paintings by attending to negligible details such as the rendering of earlobes and fingernails; Arthur Conan Doyle's fictional detective, who reads cigar ash and mud; and Sigmund Freud's psychoanalysis, which reads slips and symptoms. All three infer an invisible reality—an author, a criminal, an unconscious—from involuntary traces, and all three, Ginzburg argued, revive an archaic conjectural knowledge rooted in the hunter's reading of tracks and the diviner's reading of entrails. The same decades witnessed the institutionalization of the fingerprint as the paradigmatic trace of individual identity, through Francis Galton's *Finger Prints* (1892) and the identification systems that followed. The evidential paradigm presupposes an authorless text: the trace is involuntary, the clue unintended, and the detective's art consists in reading what was never meant to be read.

Doe's crime scenes are monstrous hybrids of these two paradigms. They present themselves as forensic evidence—corpses, blood, fingerprints, fibers—but they are in fact intentional compositions, authored scriptures disguised as traces. The detectives are therefore compelled to read them in both modes at once, and the film distributes the modes between its protagonists. Somerset, who goes to the library, is an exegete: he presupposes an author, seeks his sources, reconstructs his program, and reads each

Littera gesta docet, quid credas allegoria, / moralis quid agas, quo tendas anagogia.



IN EXITU ISRAEL · THE LETTER TO CANGRANDE SE7EN · THE LAST DRIVE

LITTERA *what was done*	the departure of the children of Israel from Egypt in the time of Moses	three men drive out of a city into open country
ALLEGORIA *what to believe*	our redemption wrought by Christ	a *via dolorosa* toward a parodic Golgotha of steel transmission towers
MORALIS *what to do*	the conversion of the soul from the misery of sin to the state of grace	the passage of a soul, Mills's, from law into wrath: a conversion in reverse
ANAGOGIA *whither you tend*	the exodus of the sanctified soul to the liberty of eternal glory	light not as glory but as apocalypse in its first sense: unveiling

FIG. 02 THE FOURFOLD EXODUS *The thirteenth-century distich on the four senses, read as the letter to Cangrande reads the psalm In exitu Israel, and as theo-forensic exegesis reads the last drive out of the rain-bound city into the light.*

scene as a verse in a sacred text. Mills, who wants to know what manner of lunatic they are pursuing, is a forensic psychologist of the profiler's school, reading the scenes as symptoms of a disorder, involuntary expressions of a pathology. The epistemological drama of the film consists in the discovery that both are right and both are insufficient. Doe is an author whose program can be reconstructed from his sources, and he is also a subject whose desire—envy—betrays itself in his text in ways he does not wholly command. Theo-forensic exegesis names the method that holds both readings together without reducing either to the other.

The figure of the fingerprint reveals how deliberately Doe has positioned himself between these paradigms. In his study of Baudelaire's Paris, Walter Benjamin proposed that the original social content of the detective story was the effacement of the individual's traces in the crowd of the great city, and he read Poe's "The Man of the Crowd" (1840) as its X-ray. Poe's narrator pursues an unreadable old man through London by night and concludes that he is "the type and the genius of deep crime," a book of which it must be said, in the story's German tag, that "*er lasst sich nicht lesen*"—it does not permit itself to be read. Doe is the man of the crowd raised



FIG. 03 THE EFFACED TRACE *The evidential paradigm infers an invisible author from involuntary traces. Doe, who has razored away the papillary ridges of his fingertips, stands outside it while composing scenes that only look like traces.*

to the level of method. He has razored away his own fingerprints, the paradigmatic trace of the evidential paradigm, rendering himself illegible to forensic science, while saturating the city with exegetical signs: words on walls, citations from Milton and Shakespeare, tableaux whose meanings are deliberately overdetermined. He makes himself unreadable and the world hyper-readable.

In Roland Barthes's terms, Doe is a *logothete*, a founder of language, of the kind Barthes found in Sade, Fourier, and Loyola (*Sade, Fourier, Loyola*, 1971): one who isolates himself, articulates a new material into discrete units, orders those units into a combinatory system, and theatricalizes the result. Doe's apartment, with its two thousand handwritten notebooks, is at once Sade's château, Fourier's phalanstery, and Loyola's house of retreat, and the comparison with Loyola is especially exact. The *Spiritual Exercises* (1548) instruct the exercitant, in the fifth exercise of the first week, to meditate upon hell with each of the five senses in turn: to see the vast fires, to hear the wailings and blasphemies, to smell the smoke, the sulfur, and the putrefaction, to taste the bitterness of tears and the worm of conscience, to feel the flames that touch and burn the souls. Doe's crime scenes are compositions of place in the Ignatian sense, and the detectives are compelled to perform the exercises: to see, smell, and touch the sins they are meant to recognize. The same logic underlies the most exact

literary prototype of Doe's apparatus, the machine of Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919), which inscribes upon the body of the condemned, over twelve hours, the commandment he has violated, so that he deciphers his sentence with his wounds. For Doe, as for Kafka's officer, the body is the page and punishment is a form of writing.

There is a final, reflexive dimension to the method, and the film makes it unavoidable. Doe is found because of what he reads. Through his contact in the Bureau, Somerset learns that the FBI covertly monitors the borrowing of flagged titles in public libraries, so that a reader of Dante, Aquinas, and works on Catholicism and murder becomes, by virtue of his reading list alone, a suspect. The premise was not fantasy. The Bureau's so-called Library Awareness Program, publicly revealed in 1987, had solicited librarians' cooperation in reporting the reading habits of patrons deemed suspicious, and Section 215 of the USA PATRIOT Act of 2001 would later expose library records to federal investigators. The reader becomes a suspect; reading itself becomes a trace. The implication for any scholarship on *Se7en* is unsettling and must be faced at the outset. To reconstruct Doe's program is to borrow the books he borrowed, to follow the trail he laid, and to read as he read. Baudelaire's hypocrite reader is the critic's patron saint. The theo-forensic exegete must therefore read Doe's text against its grain, attending less to what it proclaims than to what it cannot contain, because a reading that merely reconstructs the program has already been enlisted into it. Like Somerset, the exegete is always in danger of becoming the program's most faithful reader, and therefore its last instrument.

1.5

Production as Palimpsest: Walker's City, Fincher's Return, the Unkillable Ending

The film's textual history is a struggle over closure, and that struggle has left its trace on the finished work. Andrew Kevin Walker, raised in Pennsylvania and trained in film at Penn State, wrote the screenplay at the turn of the 1990s while living in New York and, by his own account, working at a Manhattan branch of Tower Records. He has described the city of those years as a place he found oppressive, and the script transposes that experience into its unnamed metropolis: the grime, the noise, the casual cruelty, the pervasive sense of a population that has learned to look away. The autobiographical charge is legible in Mills, the newcomer from upstate who has requested his transfer and whose wife privately confesses that she hates the city, and in Somerset, the veteran who can no longer bear what he sees and has resolved to

leave. *Se7en* is in this sense a migrant's film, the record of a provincial imagination's collision with the metropolis as moral catastrophe, and it belongs to a lineage of such collisions that runs back through *Taxi Driver* (1976) and Eliot's "Unreal City" to Juvenal's satires on Rome and the prophetic denunciations of Babylon.

David Fincher came to the project from the most bruising experience of his early career. His feature debut, *Alien*^{3} (1992), had been made under heavy studio interference and released in a form he has since disowned; he returned to commercials and music videos and, by most accounts, approached feature filmmaking again with considerable wariness. Production lore, repeated by the film's principals in interviews, holds that during development the script had been revised toward a less devastating conclusion, that Fincher was sent an earlier draft that retained the head in the box, and that he committed to that version; Brad Pitt is widely reported to have made the retention of the ending a condition of his participation. Whatever the precise sequence of events, the essential fact is clear: the ending of *Se7en* was contested, and it survived. Accounts of the production further suggest that the closing voice-over, in which Somerset cites Hemingway and then qualifies the citation, emerged from negotiations over the ending's bleakness. If so, the coda this dissertation will read as the film's ethical center—the remainder that exceeds the series—is itself, in its origin, a negotiated remainder: the scar left on the text by the contest between closure and its refusal.

The film's visual identity was forged by collaborators whose contributions are inseparable from its argument. Darius Khondji, whose cinematography for Jean-Pierre Jeunet and Marc Caro had already defined a baroque grammar of decay, lit the film in pools of sickly incandescence and the restless beams of flashlights, so that illumination itself appears partial, mobile, and inadequate—the *lumen naturale* of the Enlightenment reduced to a battery-powered torch sweeping a fetid room. Release prints were struck using a silver-retention process, Deluxe's CCE, that deepened the blacks and drained the colors; it is not excessive to describe the result as a darkness manufactured, a negative theology executed in silver halide. Arthur Max's production design built a city of interiors without sanctuary, Richard Francis-Bruce's editing lent the procedural a nervous, elliptical pulse, and Howard Shore's score laid a brooding orchestral ground against which the film's few borrowed pieces—above all the Bach heard in the library—register as remnants of a vanished cosmic order. The near-ceaseless rain, reportedly adopted in part as a practical means of unifying exteriors across a compressed schedule, became the film's atmospheric signature and, as argued above, its Dantean climate. Los Angeles stood in for a city whose generically eastern features are never resolved into a proper name. The anonymity is structural. The city of *Se7en* is not New York or any other place; it is the city as such, Augustine's *civitas*

terrena, founded according to *De civitate Dei* by Cain the fratricide and built upon the love of self extended to the contempt of God (XIV.28; XV.1).

Two paratexts extend the film's design beyond the frame. Kyle Cooper's title sequence, cut to a remix of Nine Inch Nails' "Closer," shows hands—Doe's, by implication—razoring the skin from fingertips, binding notebooks, developing photographs, and annotating texts, while the credits judder across the screen in hand-scratched lettering. The film's authorship is thus presented from the first as shared with its antagonist: the credits are inscribed in Doe's hand, and the film's signature is his. The withholding of Kevin Spacey's name from the opening credits, so that the actor playing Doe would remain unknown until his appearance, extends Doe's self-erasure into the paratext; the film conspires with its killer's anonymity. At the other end, the closing titles run to David Bowie's "The Hearts Filthy Lesson," drawn from *1. Outside*, a concept album released within days of the film and organized around the diaries of a detective investigating the "art-ritual murder" of a young victim whose body has been displayed as an installation. The two works were conceived independently, yet they share a premise—murder as art, the detective as critic—and their coincidence is among the clearest signs that *Se7en* crystallized a sensibility already diffused through the culture of its moment.

The film also stands at the intersection of two authorial corpora whose later development illuminates it retrospectively. Walker's subsequent screenplays return with striking constancy to its preoccupations. *8mm* (1999) sends its investigator into the underworld of snuff pornography and confronts him with a killer whose evil has no program whatever, the exact antithesis of Doe: evil as pure contingency rather than total meaning. *Sleepy Hollow* (1999), written for Tim Burton, turns on a headless horseman who reclaims his stolen skull and an investigator who brings the instruments of forensic rationalism to bear on a series of decapitations; Walker's corpus is, with remarkable consistency, a corpus of capital visions. *The Killer* (2023), his second collaboration with Fincher, follows a methodical assassin who recites his procedural maxims like a breviary. Fincher's films, for their part, constitute a sustained inquiry into the authored crime and the archive of obsession: the penal colony of *Alien³*, peopled by shaven-headed millenarian convicts; the ascetic terrorism of *Fight Club* (1999); the ciphers and endless files of *Zodiac* (2007); the murders keyed to verses of Leviticus in *The Girl with the Dragon Tattoo* (2011); the counterfeit diary and staged crime scene of *Gone Girl* (2014); and the genealogy of behavioral profiling in *Mindhunter* (2017–19). Across these works the criminal is repeatedly an author and the investigator repeatedly a reader drawn into the text. *Se7en* is the matrix

of that recurring structure, the point at which Walker's theological imagination and Fincher's forensic one first fused.

1.6

The Conjuncture of 1995 and the State of the Question

Se7en opened in American theaters on 22 September 1995, and the date is not incidental to its meaning. The film belongs to an apocalyptic conjuncture whose density is difficult to overstate. In April 1993 the federal siege of the Branch Davidian compound outside Waco, Texas, had ended in fire; its leader, David Koresh, had presented himself as the Lamb uniquely authorized to open the Seven Seals of the Apocalypse and was reportedly at work on a manuscript expounding them when the compound burned. On 19 April 1995, the second anniversary of Waco's end, a truck bomb destroyed the Alfred P. Murrah Federal Building in Oklahoma City and killed 168 people; its principal perpetrator had steeped himself in a novel of racial apocalypse cast in the form of a diary. On 20 March 1995 the Japanese movement Aum Shinrikyo released sarin on the Tokyo subway in pursuit of its own eschatology. And on 19 September 1995, three days before *Se7en* opened, *The Washington Post*, by arrangement with *The New York Times*, published the manifesto of the anonymous bomber known as the Unabomber, who had promised to cease killing if his text were printed in full.

The convergence with *Se7en* is uncanny in its precision. The Unabomber was an anonymous ascetic, a former academic living as a hermit, who kept voluminous journals and had for nearly two decades used violence as a means of compelling the world to read his indictment of it. Doe is an anonymous ascetic who fills two thousand notebooks and uses murder as a means of compelling the city to hear his sermon. Both understood that attention, in a saturated media environment, could be commanded only by atrocity. Doe's remark during the final drive, that one can no longer reach people with a tap on the shoulder but must strike them with a sledgehammer, formulates a media theory that the Unabomber had already put into practice. Neither work influenced the other; they issued from the same historical pressure, a culture in which meaning, deprived of authority, sought to reconstitute itself through spectacular violence and the coerced publication of a text.

The domestic politics of crime supplies a second and more consequential context. The Violent Crime Control and Law Enforcement Act of 1994 marked the high-

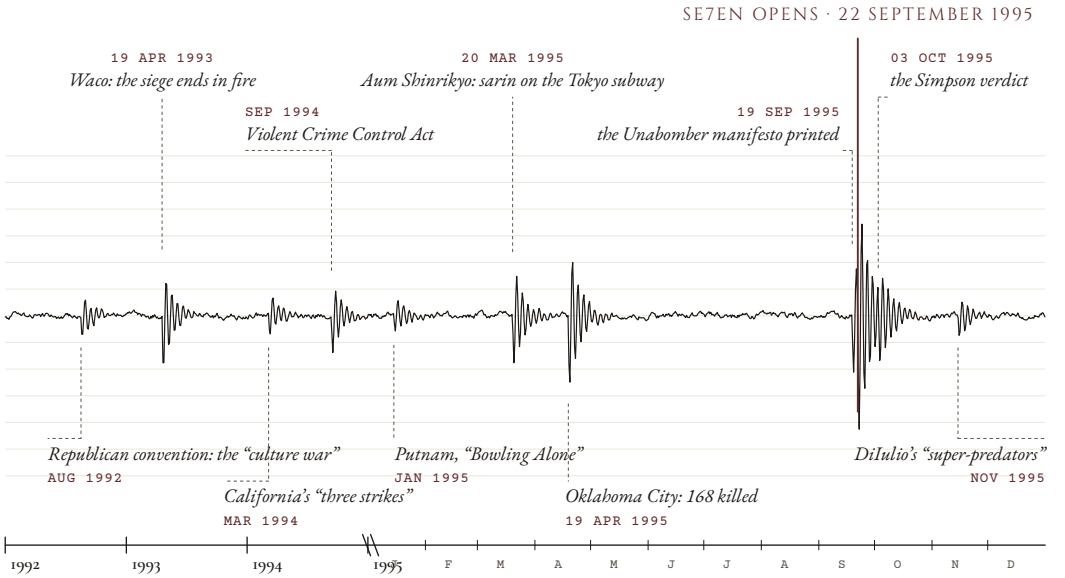


FIG. 04 THE CONJUNCTURE OF 1995 *The apocalyptic conjuncture recorded as a seismogram, from the culture war proclaimed in 1992 to the "super-predator" prophecy two months after the film opened; the scale widens for 1995 itself.*

water mark of federal punitive legislation, and California's "three strikes" statute took effect the same year. In New York, Police Commissioner William Bratton and Mayor Rudolph Giuliani were installing as official doctrine the "broken windows" theory that James Q. Wilson and George Kelling had articulated in 1982: the claim that the toleration of minor disorder—the broken pane left unrepaired, the turnstile jumped, the aggressive panhandler unmolested—signals that no one cares, and thereby invites graver crime. The policy that institutionalized the claim was called zero tolerance. Two months after *Se7en*'s release, John DiIulio published his notorious prophecy of a coming generation of juvenile "super-predators." It is within this conjuncture that Doe's theology must be read. His indictment of the city, delivered in the car on the last day, is precisely that it tolerates deadly sin because sin has become common and trivial, visible on every street corner and in every home. That is broken-windows theory transposed into the key of moral theology. Doe is the theologian of zero tolerance: the man who has drawn from the premise that tolerated minor offenses breed catastrophe the conclusion that every sin must be punished with maximal severity, and who has executed that conclusion with a consistency no police commissioner could permit himself. The film does not endorse Doe; it does something more disturbing. It shows that the logic of zero tolerance, carried to its terminus, requires a sovereign who stands

outside the law in order to enforce a law more total than any statute—and that the last act of such a sovereign is to compel the police to become him.

The same months produced the sociological diagnosis that Somerset's despair dramatizes. Robert Putnam's essay "Bowling Alone," published in January 1995, documented the erosion of what he called social capital: the networks of trust, reciprocity, and civic engagement on which democratic life depends. Putnam's thesis became one of the most debated of the decade, and its subject is exactly the condition of Somerset's city, in which, as he observes to Mills, the victims of assault are advised to cry "fire" rather than "help," because no one will come for help. This is the fourth capital of *Se7en*, the social, and its bankruptcy is the condition of possibility for the other three. The culture wars proclaimed from the podium of the Republican convention in 1992, the moralizing bestsellers of the virtue revival, the trial of O. J. Simpson—whose verdict was announced eleven days after the film opened, and which had made the celebrity defense attorney an object of national fascination and resentment—and an AIDS epidemic interpreted by many as moral judgment complete the picture. *Se7en* condenses this conjuncture into a fable whose killer speaks the language of the culture warrior in the voice of the terrorist.

The critical literature on the film has been more abundant in journalism than in sustained scholarship. Richard Dyer's monograph for the BFI Modern Classics series (1999) remains the most extended single study, and the auteur studies of Fincher by James Swallow (2003), Mark Browning (2010), and Adam Nayman (2021) situate the film within the director's development. The scholarship on serial murder as a cultural formation—Jane Caputi's *The Age of Sex Crime* (1987), Joel Black's *The Aesthetics of Murder* (1991), Philip Jenkins's *Using Murder* (1994), Richard Tithecott's *Of Men and Monsters* (1997), and above all Mark Seltzer's *Serial Killers: Death and Life in America's Wound Culture* (1998)—has supplied the indispensable account of how the serial killer became, in the 1980s and 1990s, a privileged figure through which American culture represented its relation to mass production, mass media, and an anonymous public sphere organized around the spectacle of the wound. The scattered treatments of the film in religion-and-film scholarship have registered its theological vocabulary without, for the most part, reconstructing from within the history of the doctrine it deploys.

Two interpretive dispositions dominate this literature and the film's wider reception. The first reads *Se7en* as nihilist: Somerset's despair is vindicated, the city lies beyond redemption, and the ending confirms that evil prevails. The second reads it as reactionary: whatever its intentions, the film lends the prestige of style to a moralizing critique of urban permissiveness, and its killer's indictment of the city sits uncomfortably close to the indictment the film itself appears to make. These readings

are opposed in their evaluations but share a structural assumption: both take the series as the film's ultimate horizon. For the nihilist reading the series completes itself, and its completion is the triumph of evil; for the reactionary reading the series completes itself, and its completion is a moral demonstration. Neither attends to what the series cannot absorb—the unseen head, the unborn child, the only killing the film consents to show, the eighth day. Nor does either reconstruct the theological tradition from within, as a structure possessing its own history of ordering, its own logic of capitality, and its own resources for thinking a remainder. This dissertation proposes to do both.

1.7

Hebdomad and Ogdoad: The Architecture of the Dissertation

The film's title announces its numerology before its first image. In the typographic form *Se7en*, a numeral displaces a letter, and the word becomes a hybrid of alphabet and number—a graphic instance of the ancient practice, gematria in Hebrew and isopsephy in Greek, by which letters are read as numbers and names as sums. The Apocalypse of John enjoins precisely this operation upon its readers: "Here is wisdom. Let him that hath understanding count the number of the beast: for it is the number of a man" (Rev. 13:18). The title invites a count, and a reading of its typography that is playful in manner but rigorous in method yields an exact result. The letter displaced by the numeral is V, which in Roman notation signifies five; the title therefore figures the conversion of five into seven. That is the arithmetic of the plot. Five sins have been displayed in tableaux—gluttony, avarice, sloth, lust, pride—when Doe walks into the precinct and surrenders, and the series becomes seven only through the two terms the investigators themselves supply, envy and wrath. The V becomes a 7 at the moment the detectives are written into the text.

The number seven arrives freighted with the densest symbolism of the Western traditions. In Genesis, God completes the work of creation in six days, and "on the seventh day God ended his work which he had made; and he rested" (Gen. 2:2), the verb *shabbat* signifying cessation; the Sabbath is the day on which the work is finished by being stopped. The Book of Proverbs enumerates the six things the Lord hates, "yea, seven are an abomination unto him": a proud look, a lying tongue, hands that shed innocent blood, a heart that deviseth wicked imaginations, feet swift in running to mischief, a false witness, and he that soweth discord among brethren (Prov. 6:16–19), furnishing the scriptural precedent for a heptadic catalogue of offense. The

Apocalypse is organized throughout by sevens: seven churches, seven seals, seven trumpets, seven vials of wrath. Philo of Alexandria, commenting on the creation, reports that philosophers likened the hebdomad to the motherless and virgin Victory who sprang from the head of Zeus, because within the decad seven neither begets nor is begotten by any other number (*De opificio mundi* 99–100); the later arithmological tradition named it Athena. The number of completion is thus, in this tradition, a number born from a head and without a mother, a number that does not generate. The seventh day of *Se7en* turns on a severed head and on the destruction of a mother and an unborn child. The virginity of the hebdomad—its sterile perfection, its refusal of generation—is, in Doe's hands, made murderous.

Against the hebdomad the tradition set a further number. In the first treatise of the Hermetic corpus, the *Poimandres*, the soul released from the body ascends through the seven planetary spheres, surrendering at each a vice: at the sphere of the Moon the energy of growth and decay, at Mercury the contrivance of guile, at Venus the illusion of desire, at the Sun the arrogance of rule, at Mars impious daring, at Jupiter the evil striving after wealth, at Saturn the falsehood that lies in ambush; stripped of all seven, it enters the eighth, the Ogdoad, where it hymns the Father among the powers (*Corpus Hermeticum* I.25–26). The planetary ascent is among the remote ancestors of the doctrine of the capital vices, and it already contains the structure this dissertation seeks: the seven are traversed in order to arrive at an eighth that lies beyond them. Christian theology gave the structure its most consequential form in the doctrine of the eighth day. Because Christ rose on the day after the Sabbath, the first day of the week was understood also as the eighth, the day that opens the closed cycle of creation onto the new creation. Justin Martyr read the circumcision performed on the eighth day as its type (*Dialogue with Trypho* 41), and Augustine closed the *City of God* by envisioning the eternal Sabbath that ends not in an evening but in the Lord's day, an eighth and everlasting day, where "*vacabimus et videbimus, videbimus et amabimus, amabimus et laudabimus*"—we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise (XXII.30). The eighth day is not another term in the series. It is the day the series cannot contain.

The heptad has furnished modern literature with some of its most suggestive architectures. G. K. Chesterton's *The Man Who Was Thursday* (1908) concerns a council of seven anarchists named for the days of the week, six of whom are revealed one by one to be policemen in disguise, presided over by the immense and enigmatic Sunday, who is at once the anarchists' president and the chief who recruited the detectives, and who finally declares himself the Sabbath and the peace of God. Umberto Eco's *Il nome della rosa* (1980) unfolds over seven days in an abbey whose murders appear to follow the trumpets of the Apocalypse, investigated by a bookish friar and

CORPUS HERMETICUM I.25–26

the soul ascends through the seven spheres, surrendering a vice at each, and enters the eighth

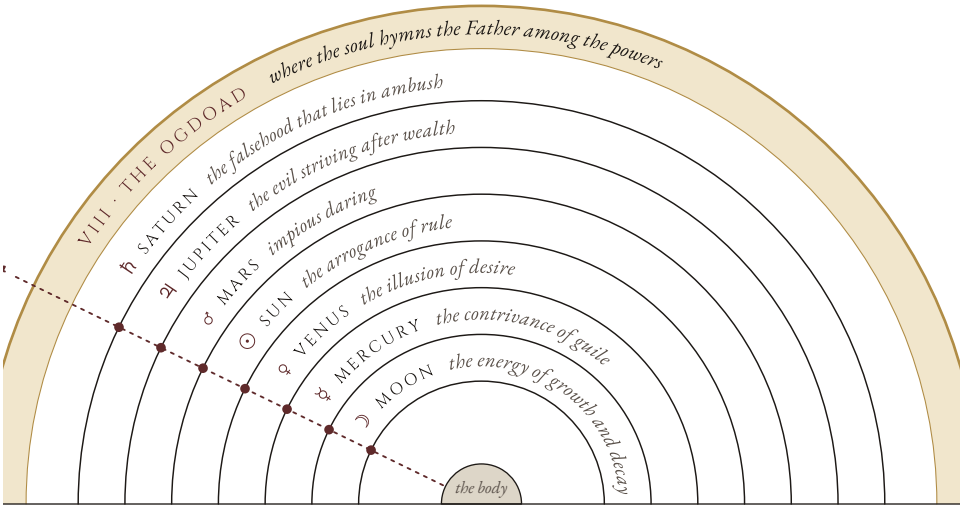


FIG. 05 THE PLANETARY ASCENT *In the Poimandres the seven are traversed in order to arrive at an eighth that lies beyond them: among the remote ancestors of the capital vices, and already the structure of the eighth day.*

his young companion in a library-labyrinth secretly governed by a blind ascetic. Both novels identify the policeman with the criminal, both are organized by the week, and both culminate in a revelation that unsettles the series they construct. *Se7en* belongs to this lineage, but with a decisive inversion. In Eco the apocalyptic pattern proves to be in large part an illusion projected by the detective onto contingency; in *Se7en* the pattern is real, designed in advance by the killer, and the detective's reading of it is not an error but a step in its execution. In Chesterton, Sunday is finally the peace of God; in *Se7en*, the Sunday on which the series ends is a day of wrath.

The structure of this dissertation is designed to enact its argument. It comprises seven chapters, each organized under one of the capital vices in the order of Doe's sequence, and an eighth part, a coda, that refuses the heptad's closure. The order of Doe's sequence repays scrutiny. The tradition has known several: the Evagrian and Cassianic, which begin with gluttony and ascend toward pride; the Gregorian, which descends from vainglory through envy and anger to melancholy, avarice, gluttony,

and lust; and the Dantean, whose seven terraces rise from pride, envy, and wrath through sloth to avarice, gluttony, and lust. Doe's order—gluttony, avarice, sloth, lust, pride, envy, wrath—follows none of these exactly, but its pattern is legible. It opens monastically, with the belly, and closes with the triad of pride, envy, and wrath in precisely the order Gregory and Dante assign to the gravest sins. In Virgil's discourse on love in *Purgatorio* XVII, the canto that stands at the numerical center of the *Commedia*, these three constitute love perverted toward the harm of one's neighbor, as distinguished from love deficient in vigor, which is sloth, and love excessive toward secondary goods, which is avarice, gluttony, and lust (XVII.91–139); Aquinas, for his part, judges spiritual sins graver than carnal ones (*ST* I-II, q. 73, a. 5). Doe's series is therefore a crescendo of gravity, rising from the flesh to the spirit and from strangers to intimates. Its first five terms are inflicted on anonymous citizens; its last two are enacted by the killer and the detective themselves. The series moves inward, from the city toward the investigation, until it closes upon the investigators.

The chapters follow this ascent. The second, under avarice, reads the murder of the defense attorney through *The Merchant of Venice*, Nietzsche's genealogy of guilt as debt, Benjamin's capitalism-as-religion, and the writing on Belshazzar's wall, whose disembodied hand finds its counterpart in the severed hand whose fingerprints spell a plea behind an inverted painting. The third, under sloth, reads the body of Victor through the history of *acedia* from Evagrius's noonday demon to Benjamin's indolence of the heart, through Agamben's bare life and the overcomatose body, and through the year of daily photographs that renders his decay at once a chronophotograph and a Buddhist meditation on the corpse; it reads Somerset's city as Dante's vestibule of the neutrals. The fourth, under lust, examines the bladed instrument, the coerced agent, and the film's pornographic apparatus through Bataille, Mulvey, Powell's *Peeping Tom*, and Dante's Francesca, for whom a book was the go-between. The fifth, under pride, reads the mutilated face of the model through Levinas, Wilde, and Lacan's forced choice, and examines Doe's pride as an author through De Quincey's aesthetics of murder and the art of the 1990s. The sixth, under envy, reads Doe's confession through Milton's Satan watching the first couple in Eden, Girard's mimetic desire, Hogg's justified sinner, and Derrida's gift of death, and reads the box as Pandora's jar with hope sealed inside it. The seventh, under wrath, reads the final scene through Kafka's penal apparatus, Schmitt and Benjamin on sovereign violence, the Akedah without a ram, Middleton's revenger, and the *Oresteia* run in reverse. The coda, under the sign of the eighth day, reads Somerset's decision to remain through Donne and Hemingway, Camus, the theology of the *katechon*, Simone Weil's ethics of attention, and the descendants of *Se7en* in *True Detective* and *No Country for Old Men*, and proposes an apophatic theory of the cinematic image.

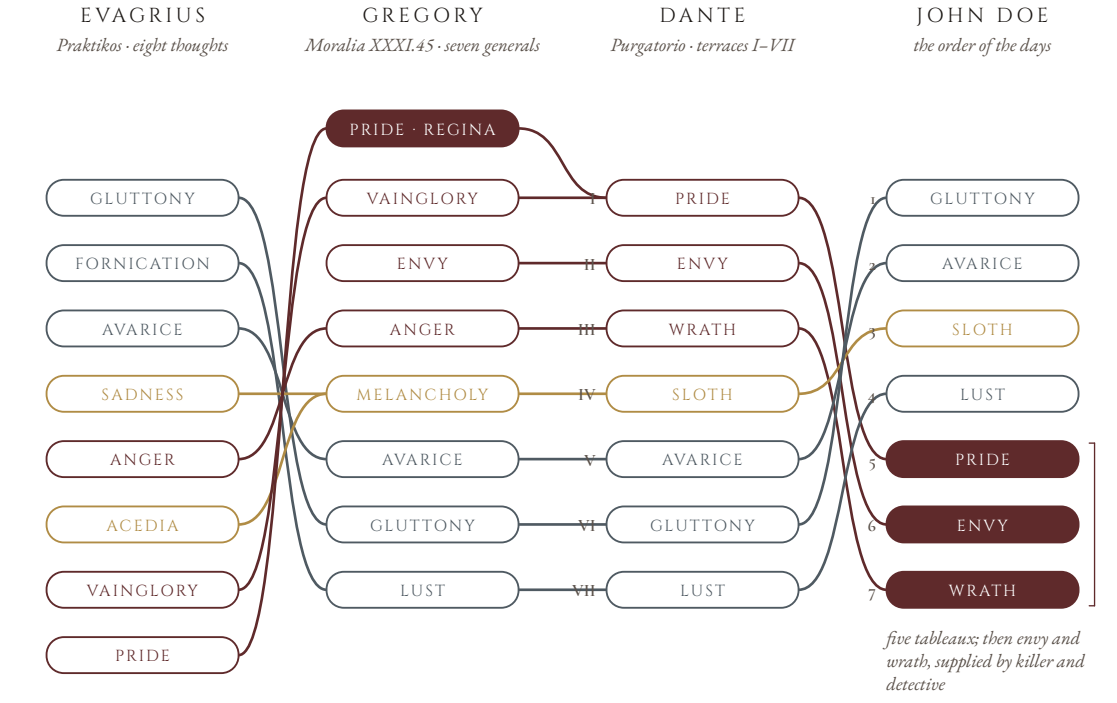


FIG. 06 FOUR ORDERS OF THE SEVEN *Evagrius begins with the belly and ascends toward pride; Gregory sets pride above seven generals; Dante's terraces rise from pride to lust. Doe's order follows none exactly but closes with pride, envy and wrath, the triad of love perverted.*

The dissertation thus begins, as Doe begins, with the belly. It ends, as Doe could not, on the eighth day.

The Second Day

Avaritia

Avarice



The Pound of Flesh

Debt, Law, and the Writing on the Wall

TEKEL; Thou art weighed in the balances, and art found wanting.

— *Daniel 5:27*

PORTIA: Are there balance here to weigh / The flesh? SHYLOCK: I have them ready.

— *William Shakespeare, The Merchant of Venice, IV.i*

2.1

Gould and Gold: The Advocate as Debtor

The second sin is discovered in the office of Eli Gould, a celebrated defense attorney, and its tableau is the most explicitly juridical of the series. Gould has been compelled at gunpoint to excise a pound of his own flesh, which lies upon a balance; he has bled to death on the floor of his office, where the word GREED is written in his blood, beside a note that sets out the terms of the exaction with a pedant's precision—flesh only, neither more nor less, neither cartilage nor bone. Mills reads the scene as the work of a lunatic. Somerset, recognizing in the bond the plot of *The Merchant of Venice*, recognizes also that the two murders are verses of a single text. The second tableau thus performs the first act of serial reading in the film: it is the scene at which a pair of corpses becomes a sequence, and a sequence becomes legible as a program.

The choice of victim is overdetermined by the name. "Gould" is a variant of "Gold," a surname that in its English and Ashkenazi branches alike descends from the metal; the advocate of avarice bears the name of its object. His given name is more resonant still. In the First Book of Samuel, Eli is the priest of Shiloh whose house is condemned because his sons, Hophni and Phinehas, seized for themselves the choicest portions of the sacrifices, and because he, knowing it, did nothing: "I will judge his house for ever for the iniquity which he knoweth; because his sons made themselves vile, and he restrained them not" (1 Sam. 3:13). The oracle against the house of Eli accuses it of making itself "fat with the chiefest of all the offerings" (2:29), and when news of the Ark's capture reaches the old priest he falls backward from his seat beside the gate, "and his neck brake, and he died: for he was an old man, and heavy" (4:18). The biblical Eli is condemned for precisely the sin Doe imputes to the city—the toleration of sin—and the charge is framed in the languages of both gluttony and greed, the two sins that open Doe's sequence. The same name sounds, finally, at the center of the Passion, in the cry of dereliction: "Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani? that is to say, My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?" (Matt. 27:46). The office of Eli Gould contains, concealed behind a painting, a second cry of dereliction, the plea HELP ME spelled out in a stranger's fingerprints. The onomastic overdetermination need not be ascribed to authorial design in order to be hermeneutically operative. It is exactly the density that Doe's own method—a method that reads names, idioms, and texts as

literally binding—invites the exegete to discover, and that the film's archive of sources places within reach.

Doe's indictment of Gould, delivered in the car on the last day, is that he grew rich by lying with every breath in order to return murderers and rapists to the street. The charge locates avarice not in hoarding but in advocacy: the lawyer's sin is to have converted the defense of the accused into a revenue stream. That conversion is the scandal of a long tradition, because in the theology of the heavenly court the advocate is a sacred office. "If any man sin," writes the author of the First Epistle of John, "we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous" (1 John 2:1), and the Fourth Gospel names the Spirit itself the *paraklētos*, the one called to stand beside the accused (John 14:16). Opposite the advocate stands the accuser: *ha-satan* in the prologue to Job, the prosecuting angel who goes to and fro in the earth gathering evidence against the righteous, and in the Apocalypse "the accuser of our brethren," who "accused them before our God day and night" (Rev. 12:10). Late medieval legal theology dramatized the confrontation as litigation. In Jacobus de Teramo's *Processus Belial* (1382), a procurator of hell sues Christ for trespass in the harrowing of Hades, and Moses appears for the defense; in the *Processus Satanae* attributed to Bartolus of Sassoferrato, Satan claims the human race as his property, and the Virgin, the *advocata nostra* of the *Salve Regina*, pleads its cause. In the sacred imagination of the West, the defender of the guilty is the figure of mercy and the prosecutor the figure of the devil.

Doe's murder of the advocate must be read against this background. In the celestial courtroom his tableaux restage, he stands in the place of the accuser; his entire project is a brief for the prosecution, a demonstration that the defendants are guilty beyond any defense. The killing of Gould is the killing of the paraclete: the abolition of the office through which, in the theological imaginary, the guilty might be spared. That Doe chooses avarice as the occasion is precise, for it allows him to discredit advocacy as such by identifying it with its corruption. The defense of the accused becomes, on his reading, nothing but a commerce in lies, and mercy nothing but a fee.

The cultural moment amplified this logic. The decades preceding the film saw the dramatic proliferation of the lawyer joke, which Marc Galanter later documented as a register of popular resentment toward the legal profession (*Lowering the Bar*, 2005); two years before *Se7en*, audiences cheered when the attorney in *Jurassic Park* (1993) was devoured on a toilet, and the Simpson trial was making the celebrity defense counsel a national object of fascination and loathing in the very weeks of the film's release. Doe's second murder is the dark twin of these fantasies: the popular wish for the lawyer's punishment, executed with theological seriousness.

The scene's deepest irony, however, is structural. The legal order of *Se7en* consists of three offices—defense, prosecution, and enforcement—and Doe's series passes

through all of them. He kills the defense in the person of Gould. He corrupts the enforcement in the person of Mills, whom he converts into an executioner. And he employs the prosecution and the defense alike to stage his ending, for it is through his own attorney, and with the reluctant assent of the district attorney, that he negotiates the terms of the final drive, holding an insanity plea in reserve should his conditions be refused. The advocate whose office Doe abolishes in Gould is the advocate whose services he retains for himself. The accuser needs an advocate to bring his case to its conclusion, just as the series needs the detectives. Nothing in the hebdomadal machine lies outside it, including the institutions that would sit in judgment upon it.

2.2

Shylock's Balance: *The Merchant of Venice* and the Literalized Bond

The bond Doe imposes on Gould is a quotation, and the quotation is a trial. In the first act of *The Merchant of Venice*, Shylock proposes, "in a merry sport," that should Antonio default on his loan, "let the forfeit / Be nominated for an equal pound / Of your fair flesh, to be cut off and taken / In what part of your body pleaseth me" (I.iii). The comedy's fourth act stages the enforcement of the bond as a scene of judgment, and at its center stands a balance. "Are there balance here to weigh / The flesh?" asks Portia, disguised as the young doctor of laws Balthazar; "I have them ready," replies Shylock, who has come to court with knife and scales. The balance in Gould's office is the balance of the Venetian court, and Doe has brought it as Shylock did. The creditor arrives equipped for the execution of his bond.

Portia's victory over Shylock is a victory of literalism over literalism. Having failed to move him with her plea for mercy, she turns the letter of the bond against its holder: "This bond doth give thee here no jot of blood; / The words expressly are 'a pound of flesh.'" She then forbids him to cut "less nor more / But just a pound of flesh," on pain of death and the confiscation of his goods, "if the scale do turn / But in the estimation of a hair" (IV.i). Enforced to the letter, the bond becomes unenforceable. Doe's note reproduces this hermeneutic with a decisive alteration. By specifying flesh only, without cartilage or bone, neither more nor less, he writes Portia's restrictions into the bond itself. Shylock's demand and Portia's loophole are composed by a single hand, so that the contract anticipates and neutralizes the interpretation that once defeated it. This is the juridical signature of the hebdomadal machine. Doe is at once creditor and judge, author of the bond and the doctor of laws who construes it, and

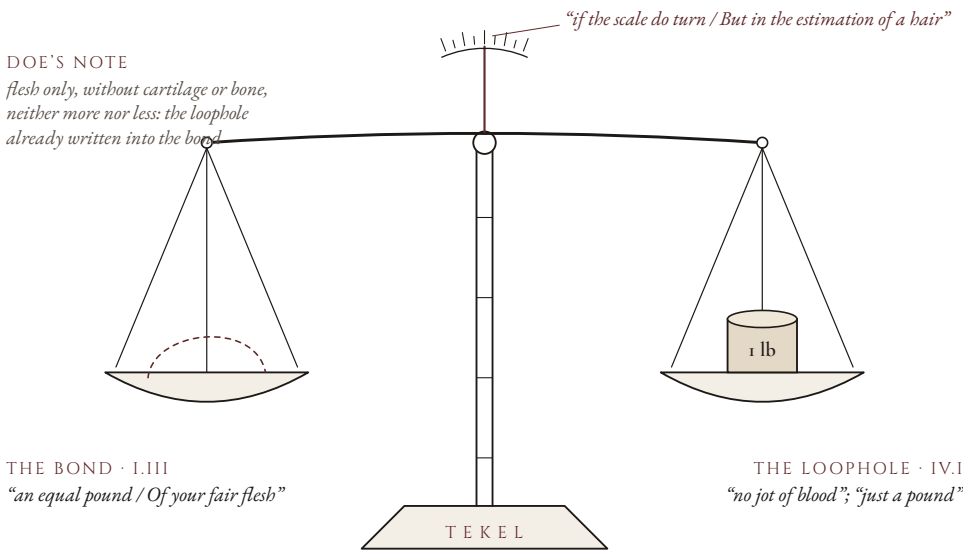


FIG. 07 SHYLOCK'S BALANCE *Portia defeats the bond by its own letter. Doe writes her restrictions into the bond itself, so that creditor and judge are one hand and the loophole is already enforced.*

his law admits no exegetical exit because the exegesis has been incorporated into the letter.

The procedure exemplifies a principle that governs Doe's entire practice, which I shall call the *remotivation of the dead metaphor*. "A pound of flesh" had long since passed into English idiom as a figure for any harsh, legally owed, and pitilessly exacted due. Doe restores it to the literal, returning the idiom to the body from which it was abstracted. The same operation recurs throughout the series. The deadly sins become literally lethal; the capital sin culminates in a literal head; the proud woman, as the fifth chapter will show, has her nose cut off to spite her face; the detective, in the last scene, literally loses his head to wrath. Theodor Adorno, in his "Aufzeichnungen zu Kafka" (1953), insisted that Kafka's fiction must be taken at its word, its figures of speech read literally; and Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" literalizes the prophetic promise of a law written upon the heart (Jer. 31:33) as a machine that writes the law upon the skin. Doe's literalism is Kafka's turned to homicide. He reads the language of the city as a binding contract and executes its clauses upon the bodies of its speakers.

The most consequential difference between the Venetian court and Gould's office lies in what each lacks. Before turning to the letter, Portia offers Shylock the most famous plea for mercy in the language: "The quality of mercy is not strain'd, / It

droppeth as the gentle rain from heaven / Upon the place beneath: it is twice blest; / It blesseth him that gives and him that takes" (IV.i). Mercy is a rain. The image completes, with an exactness the film can hardly have planned and cannot escape, the meteorological theology of the first chapter. The city of *Se7en* is drowned in rain, but its rain is not Portia's. It is the *piova etterna, maladetta, fredda e greve* of the third circle: the rain of punishment, not the rain of mercy. Two rains fall through the Western imagination, the gentle rain that blesses both giver and receiver and the cold, heavy rain that flays the gluttons, and the city of *Se7en* is rained upon only by the second. Doe's courtroom has a balance, a blade, and a bond. It has no Portia, and therefore no mercy, and therefore no rain from heaven.

The flesh-bond has a long prehistory that the play inherits and that Doe, unknowingly, inherits through it. Shakespeare's principal source was the tale of Giannetto in Ser Giovanni Fiorentino's *Il Pecorone* (written in the later fourteenth century, printed in 1558), in which a Jewish moneylender of Mestre demands a pound of flesh and is defeated by a lady disguised as a lawyer. The motif had circulated through medieval exempla and was, from its earliest European forms, entangled with the figuration of the Jew as creditor of Christian flesh, a figuration whose darker kin included the blood libel. James Shapiro's *Shakespeare and the Jews* (1996) traced the anxieties condensed in Shylock's knife, among them the fantasy of a cut that converts as much as it wounds. *Se7en* never marks Eli Gould's identity, and the name is ambiguous. But Doe's bricolage imports, unexamined, a narrative form whose European history is saturated with the scapegoating of a people through the language of debt, and the critic cannot decline to notice that the series' first exaction of flesh is modeled on the bond of the archetypal Jewish creditor. The point is not that the film is antisemitic. It is that Doe's moral archive, like every archive of moral exemplarity, contains the sedimented violence of the cultures that compiled it. The killer who believes himself the instrument of a pure justice is in fact the executor of a tradition's unexamined hatreds—an anticipation of the sacrificial logic, analyzed in the sixth chapter, by which every scapegoat must first be made legible as a debtor.

Shakespeare's play also contains a theory of generation that bears directly on Doe's program. Antonio, defending his refusal to lend at interest, asks when friendship ever took "A breed for barren metal of his friend" (I.iii). The phrase condenses the Aristotelian condemnation of usury: money is barren and cannot naturally breed, and interest—in Greek *tokos*, "offspring"—is therefore the most unnatural of all modes of acquisition, money begotten of money (*Politics* I.10, 1258b). Aquinas inherited the argument and condemned usury as the sale of what does not exist (*ST* II-II, q. 78, a. 1). Dante placed the usurers in the seventh circle among the violent against nature and art, seated on burning sand with purses hanging from their necks, emblazoned

with their family arms, on which their eyes appear to feed (*Inf.* XVII). The city of *Se7en* is a city in which barren metal breeds while human generation is extinguished. Interest compounds; the only pregnancy in the film is terminated by the killer. The hebdomad, which Philo called the virgin number because it neither begets nor is begotten, presides over a city whose only fecundity is financial.

2.3

Schuld and *Schulden*: Nietzsche's Genealogy of the Debtor's Flesh

The genealogical depth of Doe's bond becomes fully visible only in the light of the Second Essay of Nietzsche's *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887). Nietzsche's provocation is philological: the master concept of morality, *Schuld*, guilt, derives from the very material concept *Schulden*, debts (II.4). Before guilt was an inward state it was an outstanding obligation, and before punishment was retribution for a moral fault it was compensation exacted from a defaulting debtor. The creditor who could not recover his loan was granted, in lieu of payment, a right over the debtor's body. Everywhere and from early on, Nietzsche writes, there existed exact and legally sanctioned valuations of the individual limbs and parts of the body according to the debt each could cancel, some of them descending into horrible and minute detail; and he cites, as a mark of comparative liberality, the Roman Twelve Tables, which decreed that it mattered nothing how much or how little the creditors cut in such a case: "*si plus minusve secuerunt, ne fraude esto*"—"if they have cut more or less, let it not be held a fraud" (II.5).

The archaic law, in other words, was indifferent to precision. The Twelve Tables permitted creditors to divide the insolvent debtor's body on the third market day and expressly waived any penalty for cutting more or less than each one's due (Table III). Aulus Gellius, recording a learned conversation on the provision in the second century, has the jurist Sextus Caecilius remark that he had never read or heard of its actually having been carried out (*Noctes Atticae* XX.1). The flesh-bond survived for centuries as a juridical threat whose very indifference to exactitude betrayed that it was never meant to be executed. Shakespeare's Portia and Doe's note introduce what the archaic law lacked: an obsessive exactitude, a demand that the cut be neither more nor less than the debt. This exactitude is the mark of a later and more terrible justice, the justice of proportion—the *lex talionis*, the *contrapasso*, measure for measure—which insists that the punishment be the precise image of the offense. Doe belongs

to this regime. His punishments do not merely compensate; they correspond. The archaic creditor wanted his satisfaction. Doe wants his satisfaction to signify.

Nietzsche's account of what the creditor actually received is the key to Doe's psychology. The compensation, he argues, consisted not in the flesh itself but in a pleasure: the right to vent one's power upon the powerless, the voluptuousness of being permitted to do evil for the pleasure of doing it, the enjoyment of violation (II.5). Cruelty was the great festive joy of older humanity, and punishment was its festival: "without cruelty, no festival" (II.6). The gods themselves were imagined as connoisseurs of cruel spectacles, and the sufferings of the punished were staged for their delectation (II.7). Doe's tableaux are festivals of exactly this kind, mounted before an imagined divine spectator and an actual human audience. His rhetoric presents them as duties. The film, by permitting us to glimpse the contempt of his notebooks and the serenity of his satisfaction, does not entirely believe him.

Two further moments of the Second Essay illuminate the structure of the hebdomadal machine with uncanny precision. The first concerns mercy. As a community grows in power, Nietzsche argues, it takes the trespasses of its members less seriously, because they no longer endanger the whole; its criminal law grows milder, and one can imagine a society so conscious of its power that it permits itself the noblest luxury available to it, that of letting those who harm it go unpunished. Justice, which began with the principle that everything is payable, ends, like every good thing on earth, by overcoming itself, and this self-overcoming of justice has given itself a beautiful name: mercy (II.10). In Nietzsche's genealogy, the toleration that Doe denounces as the city's decadence is the luxury of strength; a society that lets offenses go unpunished does so because it can afford to. Doe's zero tolerance is, by the same reasoning, the symptom of a weakness that cannot afford mercy: the regression of justice to the creditor's cruelty, driven, as Nietzsche argues against Eugen Dühring, by reactive feelings that seek to dignify revenge with the name of justice (II.11). The man of *ressentiment* who appears here will be named in the sixth chapter. His sin is envy.

The second moment is Nietzsche's account of Christianity's stroke of genius. Faced with a debt grown unpayable, Christianity imagined God sacrificing himself for the guilt of humanity—God paying himself, the creditor sacrificing himself for his debtor, out of love (would one believe it?), out of love for his debtor (II.21). Doe's self-inclusion in the series is a parody of this stroke. Having represented the city's debt as unpayable by ordinary means, he offers himself as the sixth victim, the creditor who pays with his own life. But the motive he confesses is not love. It is envy. The creditor sacrifices himself not to cancel the debt of his debtors but to complete its collection, so that the final installment is extracted, through Mills, from the one debtor who had not yet been weighed and found wanting.

Nietzsche's genealogy finds its scriptural counterpoint in the Lord's Prayer, whose Matthean form petitions "forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors" (Matt. 6:12), while the Lucan parallel exchanges sins and debts within a single verse (Luke 11:4). David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) made this convertibility the center of an anthropology of morality, arguing that the vocabulary of sin, redemption, and atonement in the world religions was largely borrowed from the debt economies in which those religions arose. Most decisive for the present argument is the biblical rhythm of release. The Torah institutes the heptad not as the number of exaction but as the number of forgiveness: "At the end of every seven years thou shalt make a release. And this is the manner of the release: Every creditor that lendeth ought unto his neighbour shall release it; he shall not exact it of his neighbour, or of his brother; because it is called the LORD's release" (Deut. 15:1–2). The jubilee, proclaimed after "seven sabbaths of years ... seven times seven years," extends the release to land and persons: "proclaim liberty throughout all the land unto all the inhabitants thereof" (Lev. 25:8–10). In the biblical economy, seven is the rhythm by which debts are cancelled, bondmen freed, and land restored. Doe's heptad inverts it absolutely. His seven days are not a sabbatical but a collection; his series does not release the debtor but calls in the debt to the last ounce of flesh. The hebdomadal machine is the anti-Jubilee.

Kafka's officer in the penal colony supplies the formula of this inversion: "*Der Grundsatz, nach dem ich entscheide, ist: Die Schuld ist immer zweifellos*"—"the principle by which I decide is this: guilt is always beyond doubt." The sentence may be rendered, with equal fidelity to the German, as "debt is always beyond doubt." In the hebdomadal machine, as in the penal colony, the accused is never heard, because his guilt is presupposed by the procedure. Doe says as much in the car, insisting that only in a world as degraded as this one could anyone call his victims innocent and keep a straight face. The release that the Torah built into the rhythm of the week is the very thing his week abolishes.

2.4

Mene, Tekel, Peres: The Severed Hand and the Writing on the Wall

The second tableau is the first in which Doe addresses his readers forward. Behind a painting in Gould's office, hung upside down, the investigators discover fingerprints arranged to spell HELP ME. The prints belong to Victor, a man with a

criminal record, and the third sin will be found in his apartment. From this point the series assumes the form of an epistolary chain, each station enclosing the coordinates of another, until the last delivers a parcel addressed by name to the reader himself. The instrument of this first forwarding is a severed hand, and the scene it composes is among the most ancient in the Western imagination of judgment.

In the fifth chapter of Daniel, Belshazzar the king makes a great feast for a thousand of his lords and commands that the vessels of gold and silver taken from the Temple in Jerusalem be brought, so that he and his princes, his wives and his concubines might drink from them. "They drank wine, and praised the gods of gold, and of silver, of brass, of iron, of wood, and of stone. In the same hour came forth fingers of a man's hand, and wrote over against the candlestick upon the plaister of the wall of the king's palace: and the king saw the part of the hand that wrote" (Dan. 5:4–5). The king's countenance changes and his knees smite one against another; his wise men are summoned, and they cannot read the writing. Daniel, an aged exile in the imperial city, renowned for "shewing of hard sentences, and dissolving of doubts" (5:12), is brought in, and reads: "MENE, MENE, TEKEL, UPHARSIN. ... MENE; God hath numbered thy kingdom, and finished it. TEKEL; Thou art weighed in the balances, and art found wanting. PERES; Thy kingdom is divided, and given to the Medes and Persians" (5:25–28). "In that night was Belshazzar the king of the Chaldeans slain" (5:30).

The correspondence with the second day of *Se7en* is close enough to be structural. A feast of gold and gluttony precedes the judgment, as the murder of the glutton precedes the murder of the man of gold. A disembodied hand writes upon a wall a message the authorities cannot at first read. And the message itself, in Daniel's interpretation, names the three operations of Doe's entire program. *Mene*, numbering: the counting of the days and the sins, the kingdom numbered and finished in a week. *Tekel*, weighing: the balance in Gould's office, on which a man's flesh is weighed and found wanting. *Peres*, division: the severance that ends the series, the head divided from the body, the household divided by death, the detective divided from himself. The writing on the wall is the abstract of the hebdomadal machine, and Doe, who writes on walls at nearly every station, is its literalizer; the vernacular idiom, the writing on the wall as an omen of impending doom, is one more dead metaphor he remotivates. Somerset, the elderly interpreter in the imperial city, is cast in the role of Daniel, the only reader who can make the inscription speak, and the role carries Daniel's burden. The interpreter does not avert the judgment he deciphers. He announces it.

Rembrandt's *Belshazzar's Feast* (c. 1635–38) renders the inscription as Hebrew letters arranged in vertical columns, an arrangement corresponding to the solution

later published by the painter's neighbor, the Amsterdam rabbi Menasseh ben Israel, to the riddle of why the king's sages could not read it: the writing was legible, but its direction was not the expected one. The cry behind Gould's painting is concealed by the same device. It becomes legible only when the orientation of the image is corrected, only when a viewer notices that the picture hangs the wrong way up. The message is hidden not by encryption but by inversion; to read it is to reorient.

The instrument of the writing deserves equal attention. Doe has amputated Victor's hand and used its fingertips as a stamp. The European folk imagination knew such an instrument as the Hand of Glory: the dried and pickled hand of a hanged felon, fitted with a candle, which burglars carried into the houses they robbed in order to keep the sleepers from waking—a criminal's hand converted into a tool for further crimes, popularized for English readers by Richard Barham's *Ingoldsby Legends* (1840). Doe's use of Victor's hand belongs to this lineage of the felon's hand made instrument, but its function is semiotic rather than magical. In Charles Sanders Peirce's terms, a fingerprint is an *index*, a sign that signifies by physical connection with its object, as smoke signifies fire; the alphabet is a system of *symbols*, signs that signify by convention. HELP ME is a symbolic message composed of indexical marks, letters made of traces. The forgery is radical. The prints index a body that was never present at the scene; only its severed member was. The index lies. Doe has discovered the one forgery the evidential paradigm cannot readily detect, because the trace is authentic and its testimony false. He signs his work with another man's hand—the gesture of a man who has razored away his own fingerprints and can therefore write, in the forensic sense, only with the hands of others.

The gesture has a theological double. Early Christian and Byzantine art, constrained by reverence before the invisible Father, represented divine intervention in history by a single hand emerging from a cloud, the *Manus Dei*: the minimal image of a sovereign who acts without appearing. The hand that writes on Belshazzar's wall belongs to this iconography of the unseen judge. Doe, who conceals his face, his name, and his prints while leaving words on the walls of his stations, aspires to the position of the hand without a body—to the sovereignty of a writer who is nowhere and whose writing is everywhere.

The history of real and fictional murder had supplied this gesture with precedents. Conan Doyle's *A Study in Scarlet* (1887), the first Sherlock Holmes novel, presents at its crime scene the word RACHE written in blood upon a wall, which the police misread as an unfinished "Rachel" and Holmes reads correctly as the German for "revenge." At the very origin of the modern detective story, the writing on the wall is a word for the sin with which *Se7en* will end. In Chicago in December 1945, the so-called Lipstick Killer, William Heirens, wrote on the wall of a victim's apartment

MENE, MENE, TEKEL, UPHARSIN

Daniel 5:25



READ ACROSS, IN ROWS

ממתוס ננקפי אאלרן

READ DOWN, IN COLUMNS

מנא מנא תקל ופרסין

MENE
numbered
the days and the sins counted

TEKEL
weighed
the balance in Gould's office

PERES
divided
the severance that ends the series

FIG. 08 THE WRITING ON THE WALL

Daniel's inscription set out in five vertical columns, read downward and from right to left, as in Rembrandt's Belshazzar's Feast *(c. 1635–38) and the solution Menasseh ben Israel later published. Read in rows the letters yield nothing: the writing is legible only to one who reorients, like the cry concealed behind the inverted painting.*

a plea that the police catch him before he killed again, because he could not control himself—an authentic precursor of the ambiguous HELP ME. And in Whitechapel, in the early hours of 30 September 1888, a chalked message found above a fragment of a victim's apron declared that "the Juwes are the men that will not be blamed for nothing," and was erased before dawn on the order of the Metropolitan Police commissioner, Sir Charles Warren, for fear that it would incite violence against the district's Jewish residents. From the beginning, the writing on the wall of the modern city has been a site where the language of judgment and the language of scapegoating meet. Doe inherits both.

2.5

Pandaemonium: Mammon's Architecture and the City as Capital

The city in which these writings appear is built, in the film's Miltonic intertext, by avarice. In the first book of *Paradise Lost* the fallen angels raise their capital from the ore of Hell under the direction of Mammon, "the least erected Spirit that fell / From heav'n, for ev'n in heav'n his looks and thoughts / Were always downward bent, admiring more / The riches of Heav'ns pavement, trod'n Gold, / Then aught divine or holy else enjoy'd / In vision beatific" (I.679–684). His crew rifle the bowels of their mother earth for treasure, and the narrator comments: "Let none admire / That riches grow in Hell; that soyle may best / Deserve the precious bane" (I.690–692). From the gold they extract, the architect Mulciber raises Pandaemonium, which "Rose like an Exhalation, with the sound / Of Dulcet Symphonies and voices sweet" (I.711–712). The infernal city is an edifice of avarice, and the critical tradition has long read it as a prophecy of the industrial metropolis; Humphrey Jennings's anthology of contemporary testimony to the coming of the machine, posthumously published as *Pandaemonium* (1985), opens with Milton's account of its building.

The film's own Miltonic epigraph comes, as the first chapter observed, from the second book, from the infernal council in which the fallen leaders debate how to answer their condition. That council supplies a typology of the responses to evil that *Se7en* distributes among its principals. Moloch, "the strongest and the fiercest Spirit / That fought in Heav'n," speaks first: "My sentence is for open Warr" (II.44–51). Belial, whose words are "cloath'd in reasons garb," counsels "ignoble ease, and peaceful sloath, / Not peace" (II.226–228): endurance, accommodation, the hope that time will soften the torment. Mammon proposes that the fallen make the best

of Hell by founding in it an empire of their own, since "This Desart soile / Wants not her hidden lustre, Gemms and Gold; / Nor want we skill or Art, from whence to raise / Magnificence; and what can Heav'n shew more?" (II.270–273). Beelzebub, voicing Satan's design, proposes instead the corruption of the newly created world, and Satan alone volunteers for the journey, prefacing his offer with the lines Doe will leave behind the refrigerator: "long is the way / And hard, that out of Hell leads up to light" (II.432–433).

Read through this council, the film's principals take their places with disconcerting precision. Mills is Moloch, the counselor of open war, the young fighter whose impatient rage will become the instrument of the series' completion. Somerset is Belial, the eloquent counselor of withdrawal, whose diagnosis of the city's apathy doubles as a counsel of retreat into the peaceful sloth of a retirement in the country; that he is, unlike Belial, too honest to call this retreat peace is what makes him the film's moral center. The city itself is Mammon's empire: a society that has accommodated itself to Hell by building in it, and has learned to find magnificence in its ore. And Doe is Satan, the one who undertakes the hard way out of Hell toward the light, and whose mission is the corruption of the new world's first household. The council is a theater of the possible responses to an infernal condition, and the film stages all four.

The name of the investigator who will end the series as its instrument completes the Miltonic chain. In the preface to his visionary poem *Milton* (c. 1804–10), William Blake asked whether the countenance divine had shone forth upon England's clouded hills, and whether Jerusalem had been builded there, "Among these dark Satanic Mills." The Romantic poet who most profoundly revised Milton identified the infernal architecture of *Paradise Lost* with the mills of industrial England, Pandaemonium with the factory. Detective David Mills, transferred to the city from the provinces, bears the name of that architecture. He bears also the name of the proverbial engine of providential retribution, the mills of God that, in Longfellow's rendering of Friedrich von Logau, "grind slowly, yet they grind exceeding small." The seventh chapter will show how Doe converts the satanic mill into the mill of God, and how the conversion grinds the man who bears the name.

Georg Simmel's "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben" (1903) supplies the sociology of Mammon's city and, unexpectedly, a theory of the film's palette. The money economy, Simmel argued, reduces every qualitative difference between things to the single question of how much; money, which he called the most frightful of levelers, hollows out the core of things, their individuality and their incomparability. Its characteristic psychological product in the metropolis is the blasé attitude, an incapacity to respond to new stimuli with the energy they warrant, in which the

meaning and value of the differences between things, and therefore the things themselves, are experienced as insubstantial. To the blasé person, Simmel wrote, they appear in an evenly flat and gray tone. The desaturated image of *Se7en*—the drained colors of its silver-retained prints, the gray-green of the precinct, the bruised brown of the tenements—is the visual equivalent of Simmel's blasé attitude: the city seen as money sees it, in a uniform matte gray in which nothing differs from anything else. Simmel's metropolitan also cultivates reserve, a protective indifference toward others that shades, he observed, into a slight aversion and a mutual strangeness. It is the sociological name of the apathy Somerset diagnoses and Doe denounces. Doe's tableaux are attempts to break through the gray, to restore by atrocity the differences between things that the money economy has leveled. That his means are themselves commodities—the custom-made instrument of the fourth murder, ordered and paid for like any purchase; the courier of the seventh, hired like any delivery—is the irony that the final section of this chapter pursues.

A minor episode confirms how thoroughly the film's domestic sphere has been penetrated by the market. Mills and Tracy have rented an apartment that shakes violently whenever a train passes, because the agent who showed it to them kept each visit brief enough to avoid the trains. The comedy of the scene, in which Somerset's laughter breaks the tension of a first dinner and the hosts join him, is real, and so is its structure. The home is a commodity sold with a concealed defect, and the defect is the motion of the city itself, which shakes the household at regular intervals. The parcel of the seventh day will be the commodity world's final concealed defect: a box whose surface conceals a human life.

2.6

The Inverted Picture: Image, Veil, and the Cry Behind the Painting

The plea in Gould's office is hidden behind an image, and the image hangs upside down. It is the widow who notices. Shown photographs of the office, Mrs. Gould recognizes that one of its paintings has been inverted, and the investigators, turning it, find the fingerprints behind it. The detail is easily dismissed as a mechanism of plot. It is in fact a compact theory of reading.

Inversion is the conventional sign of distress. The United States Flag Code, which prescribes the etiquette of the national emblem, forbids its display with the union down "except as a signal of dire distress in instances of extreme danger to life or prop-

erty" (4 U.S.C. § 8(a)). The inverted painting functions as such a signal, and the cry behind it completes the semaphore. But inversion conceals as well as signals, and what it conceals is visible only to a viewer who knows the right orientation of the image. An unfamiliar or abstract picture can be inverted without any stranger noticing. The sign is therefore addressed to intimacy: it can be read only by someone who knows the room as a household knows it. Doe has designed a message that a widow will read. The detail anticipates the strategy of the seventh day, when the decisive message will be delivered to a husband by way of a wife, and when the knowledge on which the final sin depends—Tracy's pregnancy—will be a secret she has confided to Somerset rather than to Mills. Doe's semiotics is parasitic upon intimacy. Its messages travel along the channels of domestic knowledge, and their final address is the home.

The topos of the world turned upside down, the *mundus inversus* that Ernst Robert Curtius traced from the classical *adynata* through medieval satire (*Europäische Literatur und lateinisches Mittelalter*, 1948), is among the oldest figures for a moral order gone awry, and its most famous painted instance belongs to the same pictorial tradition as Doe's method. Pieter Bruegel's *Netherlandish Proverbs* (1559) assembles scores of idioms rendered literally—a man beating his head against a wall, another filling in the well after the calf has drowned—and hangs upon a wall at its left an inverted globe, the world turned upside down. Bruegel's panel is an encyclopedia of literalized metaphors presided over by inversion, which is precisely what Doe's series is. The same artist designed the seven engravings of the deadly sins issued in 1556–58, in which each vice presides over a landscape of grotesque literalizations; his *Avaritia* enthrones its miser amid a carnival of extortion. Doe is a Bruegelian moralist working in flesh.

Hegel gave the inverted world its most rigorous philosophical form. In the chapter of the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) devoted to force and the understanding, consciousness discovers a *verkehrte Welt* in which the laws of the first, supersensible world are reversed, and the examples Hegel chooses are juridical. In the first world, revenge upon an enemy is the highest satisfaction of the injured individual; in the inverted world, the punishment that disgraces and destroys a man becomes the pardon that preserves his essence and brings him to honor. Doe's tableaux occupy an unstable position between Hegel's two worlds. They are punishments that destroy and disgrace, but they are also monuments: each victim is preserved, composed, exhibited, and given a place in a work that Doe insists will be studied forever. The punishment is also an apotheosis. The inversion of Gould's painting is the emblem of a series in which destruction and consecration continually exchange places.

The painting that conceals a cry recalls the most celebrated concealed image in Western art. Hans Holbein's *The Ambassadors* (1533) depicts two wealthy and

learned men amid the instruments of worldly knowledge and power—globes, a sundial, a lute with a broken string, a hymnal, a richly patterned carpet—while across the floor between them stretches an unreadable smear that resolves into a skull only when the viewer moves to an oblique position at the picture's edge. Death is concealed in the portrait of wealth, legible only to a viewer who abandons the frontal view. Lacan, in his seminar of 1964, made Holbein's anamorphosis the emblem of the gaze, the point at which the picture looks back at the subject who believed himself its master. The tableau of greed has the same structure. It is a picture of wealth—a lawyer's office, its art, its carpet—in which death and a cry for help are concealed within the visual field and become visible only when the viewer changes position: when the painting is turned, when the widow's intimate knowledge is brought to bear. Doe's hidden messages are anamorphic. They require of their reader a displacement of the body.

Inversion as concealment is also the device of Poe's "The Purloined Letter" (1844), in which a compromising letter is hidden by being turned inside out like a glove, re-addressed, re-sealed, and placed in plain sight in a card rack, where it eludes a police search of microscopic thoroughness and is found by Dupin precisely because it is too obvious to be seen. Lacan's seminar on the story (1956) concluded that a letter always arrives at its destination; Derrida, in "Le facteur de la vérité" (1975), countered that the structure of the letter includes the possibility of its not arriving, of its going astray. *Se7en* stages the dispute between them with a precision that neither could have anticipated. Its letters arrive, but never quite where they are addressed. The plea behind the painting reaches the detectives by way of a widow. The box is delivered, at the appointed place and hour, for Detective David Mills, and it is opened by Somerset; its addressee never sees its contents, which reach him only through Doe's voice and Somerset's stricken face. The letter arrives and does not arrive; it is intercepted, and in being intercepted it is delivered. The courier of the seventh day is, in the most literal sense, the *facteur de la vérité*, the postman of the truth. But what he delivers exceeds what was sent. Doe's message is that the series is complete. What the box contains is a remainder that no message can enclose.

2.7

Capitalism as Religion: Benjamin, Brecht and Weill, and the Moral Economy of the Sins

Benjamin's fragment of 1921, introduced in the first chapter, can now be read in full against the second day. Capitalism, Benjamin argued, is not merely a

formation conditioned by religion, as Max Weber had proposed, but an essentially religious phenomenon, distinguished by three features. It is a purely cultic religion, perhaps the most extreme that has ever existed, without dogma or theology. Its cult is of permanent duration: there is no weekday, no day that is not a feast day in the terrible sense of the unfolding of all sacral pomp, and the cult is celebrated "*sans rêve et sans merci*," without dream and without mercy. And it creates guilt rather than atonement: it is *verschuldend*, indebting, the first instance of a cult that does not expiate guilt but universalizes it, driving it into consciousness until it encompasses God himself, who is not dead but drawn into the fate of humanity. Benjamin adds, in a remarkable aside, that Freud's theory belongs to the priesthood of this cult, for the repressed, the sinful representation, is the capital that pays interest to the hell of the unconscious.

Each feature finds its image in *Se7en*. Benjamin's claim that the capitalist cult knows no weekday bears directly on a film organized by the days of the week. The city has no sabbath; its cult of exchange runs without interruption, every night lit by the neon of commerce, every day a working day. Its two principals embody the formula of the permanent cult with uncanny exactness. Somerset is the man without dream, who cannot sleep without the metronome he sets ticking beside his bed to impose an artificial order on the noise of the street. Doe is the man without mercy. Between them the city's guilt accumulates like interest. Doe's program is, in Benjamin's terms, the attempt to call in the capital of the city's repressed sin, to collect with interest the debt that has been compounding in the hell of its unconscious. And his self-sacrifice at the end of the series literalizes Benjamin's most vertiginous claim, that the guilt of the capitalist cult extends to God himself. The man who has made himself the instrument of divine judgment discovers in himself, and confesses, the sin of envy, and pays for it with his life.

Benjamin's diagnosis was taken up in another key a dozen years later by Bertolt Brecht and Kurt Weill. *Die sieben Todsünden der Kleinbürger*, a *ballet chanté* first performed in Paris in June 1933, months after both authors had fled Germany, follows a single woman divided into two figures, the practical singer Anna I and the impulsive dancer Anna II, through seven American cities over seven years as she earns the money for her family's little house in Louisiana. In each city Anna II is tempted by one of the seven sins, and in each the sin proves to be an inverted virtue. Pride is the artist's refusal to cheapen her dancing for a cabaret audience; Anger is indignation at cruelty; Gluttony is the hunger of a dancer contractually bound to remain thin; Lust is love freely given to a man who cannot pay. What capitalism calls sin is the persistence of the human against its imperatives, and what it calls virtue is self-commodification. The sequence ends, like Doe's confession, with Envy: the

disciplined sister's envy of those who live freely, which she must renounce. Brecht and Weill show capital producing the sins it condemns and condemning the virtues it cannot use. *Se7en* presents the inverse figure: a moralist who punishes the sins capital produces—consumption, litigation, intoxication, the sale of the body, the sale of the face—while himself proceeding by capital's own means, the purchase, the contract, the schedule, the delivery.

The pictorial tradition had long made the connection between avarice and the institutions of law that the murder of Gould enacts. In the *Table of the Seven Deadly Sins* attributed to Hieronymus Bosch and his workshop (c. 1500–25), the seven vices are arranged in a circle around the pupil of a divine eye, within which Christ rises from his tomb above the inscription "*Cave cave deus videt*"—"Beware, beware, God sees." The scene of *Avaritia* shows a judge accepting a bribe from one litigant behind his back while he hears the other. Avarice, for Bosch, is the corruption of judgment. Otto Dix's *Die sieben Todsünden* (1933), painted in the year the National Socialists seized power, depicts Avarice as a withered crone bearing on her back the small, malignant figure of Envy, to whose face the painter added a Hitler moustache after the war. Envy rides on Avarice. Across five centuries of the iconography of the vices, avarice is never alone: it carries envy, and it sits in judgment.

Scholastic theology articulated the double primacy these images intuit. Scripture names two origins of evil: "the love of money is the root of all evil" (1 Tim. 6:10; *radix omnium malorum est cupiditas*), and "pride is the beginning of all sin" (Ecclus. 10:15, Vulgate; *initium omnis peccati superbia*). Aquinas reconciles them by distinguishing the order of execution from the order of intention (*ST* I-II, q. 84, aa. 1–2). Covetousness is the root, because riches are the universal means through which every other sin is carried out; pride is the beginning, because the inordinate desire for one's own excellence is the end toward which every sin is ultimately ordered. Doe's series honors the distinction. It strikes the root early, in the second murder, and the beginning late, in the fifth. The machine digs out the means before it cuts down the end.

Guy Debord, writing at the zenith of postwar consumer capitalism, defined the spectacle as capital accumulated to the point at which it becomes image (*La Société du spectacle*, 1967, §34). Doe's tableaux are spectacles in precisely this sense: compositions in which the accumulated sins of the city are converted into images for public consumption, relayed by the press, and destined, he believes, for perpetual study. The film participates in the spectacle it depicts, and knows that it does. At the decisive moment, however, it refuses the final conversion. The last product of Doe's economy is never made into an image.

That refusal can be read, finally, in the terms of Marx's analysis of the commodity. A commodity, Marx wrote in the first chapter of *Capital*, appears at first sight a

trivial thing, easily understood, while its analysis shows it to be a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties. Its secret, the source of its fetish character, is that it conceals within its thingly form the social relations among the human beings whose labor produced it, so that relations between persons appear as relations between things. Every commodity, on Marx's analysis, hides a human life. The parcel delivered on the seventh day of *Se7en* is the commodity fetish turned inside out: a box that conceals, not metaphorically but literally, a human being. What every package in the circulation of goods secretly contains, this one contains in fact. The film's refusal to open it to the spectator is therefore more than a gesture of taste or restraint. It is the refusal to let the last secret of the commodity become one more image for consumption. The *caput oeconomicum* remains sealed.

The second day thus completes the juridical and economic armature of the hebdomadal machine. The machine is a creditor that forgives nothing, a court that has abolished the advocate, a writing on the wall that numbers, weighs, and divides, and a market whose final delivery is a human head. Its seven days invert the biblical seven of release. And its next station has already been addressed, in another man's stolen fingerprints, behind an inverted image. The hand that spelled the plea belongs to a body that has not moved for a year.

THE THIRD DAY

ACEDIA

Sloth



The Noonday Demon

Sloth, Bare Life, and the Photographic Year

Ab incursu et daemonio meridiano. [From the onslaught, and from the noonday demon.]

— *Psalm 90:6 (Vulgate)*

Questi non hanno speranza di morte. [These have no hope of death.]

— *Dante, Inferno III.46*

3.1

The Noonday Demon: From Evagrius to Benjamin's Sloth of the Heart

Of the seven capital vices, sloth has the most complicated history and the least adequate English name. The word now evokes idleness, reluctance to work, the body's preference for rest; the vice it translates was originally something else entirely. Evagrius Ponticus called it *akēdia*, from the Greek for a lack of care, and judged it the most oppressive of the eight thoughts that assail the solitary. He named its agent the noonday demon, after the Septuagint's rendering of the ninety-first psalm, which promises deliverance from the demon of midday (Ps. 90:6 LXX; Vulgate *daemonio meridiano*; Authorized Version "the destruction that wasteth at noonday"). The demon of acedia, Evagrius writes, attacks the monk about the fourth hour and besieges his soul until the eighth. It makes the sun seem motionless and the day fifty hours long; it compels him to look again and again out of the window, to step outside his cell, to gauge how far the sun still stands from the ninth hour, to glance about lest one of the brethren appear. It instills in him a hatred of the place, a hatred of his very life, a hatred of the work of his hands; it persuades him that charity has vanished from among the brethren and that there is no one to console him; and it urges him to depart for some other place, where life would be easier and his labors more fruitful (*Praktikos* 12).

The portrait is precise enough to serve as a clinical description of William Somerset. The veteran detective hates the place; he has come to believe that the city has abandoned charity; he cannot sleep; and he has resolved, at the film's opening, to leave for the country, where he imagines a life less unbearable. His week is a countdown measured against the sun—seven days until departure—and its hours lengthen under the weight of a case he has tried to decline. His acedia is not idleness. He is diligent, meticulous, tireless; he passes a night in the library while its guards play cards. It is a sorrow that has despaired of the good while continuing to perform the motions of duty, precisely the condition Evagrius distinguished from mere laziness. The monk afflicted by the noonday demon may work furiously. What he cannot do is hope.

The desert fathers prescribed a remedy, and its name is the key to the film's ending. One must not abandon the cell in the time of temptation, Evagrius counsels, fabricating plausible pretexts for departure, but must remain seated within it and persevere

(*Praktikos* 28). The cure for acedia is *stabilitas*, staying; and if the soul endures, Evagrius promises, no other demon follows immediately upon this one, but a state of deep peace and inexpressible joy arises from the struggle (*Praktikos* 12). John Cassian, transmitting the doctrine to the Latin West, defined acedia as a weariness or anxiety of heart, *taedium sive anxietas cordis*, observed that it falls most heavily upon solitaries and assails them like a fever about the sixth hour, and prescribed manual labor and stability of place as its antidote (*De institutis coenobiorum* X.1–2). The film's final exchange, in which Somerset, asked where he will be, answers only that he will be around, is the Evagrian victory over the noonday demon: the refusal to leave the cell. The coda of this dissertation will argue that the ethics of the eighth day is, among other things, the ethics of the monk who stays.

The later tradition reconfigured the vice in ways that bear directly upon the film's distribution of its sins. Gregory the Great folded acedia into *tristitia*, sadness, and listed among the daughters of sadness malice, rancor, faint-heartedness, despair, sluggishness regarding the commandments, and the wandering of the mind among unlawful things (*Moralia* XXXI.45.88). Aquinas, restoring acedia to the list, defined it as sorrow about spiritual good, *tristitia de bono spirituali*, a sorrow at the very good in which charity rejoices, and adopted Gregory's catalogue of its offspring (*ST* II-II, q. 35, aa. 1, 4). The genealogy is startling when held against *Se7en*. Among the daughters of acedia are despair and faint-heartedness, the dispositions of Somerset; among them also are rancor and malice, the dispositions of Doe. The two principal antagonists of the film descend from the same mother. The city's sorrow at the good produces, in one temperament, the melancholic's withdrawal and, in another, the moralist's spite. Read through the scholastic genealogy, *Se7en* is a family romance of the daughters of sloth.

Dante gave this kinship its most haunting image. In the fifth circle of the *Inferno*, the marsh of the Styx, the wrathful strike and rend one another on the surface of the mire, while beneath them, submerged and invisible, lie the sullen, whose sighs make the surface bubble. Their speech reaches the pilgrim as a gurgle: "*Tristi fummo / ne l'aere dolce che dal sol s'allegra, / portando dentro accidioso fummo: / or ci attristiam ne la belletta negra*"—"We were sullen in the sweet air that is gladdened by the sun, bearing within us a sluggish smoke; now we are sullen in the black mire"—a hymn they gurgle in their throats, because they cannot utter it in whole words (*Inf.* VII.121–126). It is here that Dante uses the adjective *accidioso*. Wrath above and sullen acedia below share a single marsh; they are the active and passive faces of one disorder. The partnership at the center of *Se7en* reproduces the Stygian arrangement. Mills is the wrath that fights on the surface; Somerset is the sullenness beneath, bearing within him a sluggish smoke in a city that knows little sweet air. And in Victor, the victim

of the third tableau, the image of the submerged sullen receives a literal body: a man who cannot speak, whose only utterances are choked sounds in the throat.

The most consequential modern reinterpretation of acedia was Walter Benjamin's. In the seventh of his theses "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940), Benjamin traced the historicist's method of empathy to the indolence of the heart, *acedia*, which despairs of seizing the genuine historical image as it flashes up, and which the theologians of the Middle Ages regarded as the root of sadness. With whom, Benjamin asked, does the historicist empathize? The answer is inevitably: with the victor. And since all rulers are the heirs of those who conquered before them, empathy with the victor invariably benefits the rulers of the day. Acedia, on Benjamin's reading, is the melancholy of acquiescence, the sorrow that has given up on redemption and therefore consents to the history of the victors, a history whose every document of civilization is at the same time a document of barbarism. The film's emblem of sloth is a man named Victor. The coincidence, which no reader of Benjamin can easily set aside, discloses the political content of the third tableau. Doe's sloth is not the vice of a single degenerate but the acquiescence of a whole city in the way things are, the sorrow that has despaired of the good and consented to the reign of the strong; and its emblem is a victor reduced to the most vanquished body in the film, a triumph reversed into a year in bed. The Roman triumph, Tertullian records, placed behind the victorious general a slave who reminded him to look behind him and remember that he was a man (*Apologeticum* 33). Victor's bed is that whisper made flesh.

3.2

Victor: Bare Life and the Overcomatose Body

The fingerprints lead a tactical unit to Victor's apartment, and what it finds there is the film's most terrible image and its most exact allegory of power. The room is dark and fetid; scores of cardboard air fresheners hang from the ceiling, a canopy of chemical pine suspended over a stench they cannot mask. On the bed lies a skeletal figure, strapped down, its flesh gray, its sores open, one hand gone; on the wall above it is written SLOTH. Beside it the officers find a photographic record, a picture of the body taken every day, the first dated precisely a year before. The figure is taken for a corpse until, as an officer leans over it, it convulses and gasps. Victor is alive.

The physician who examines him afterwards delivers the film's most chilling clinical verdict. Victor's mind is gone and his body has wasted to the threshold of death; he has suffered, the doctor observes, about as much as any human being he has

ever encountered, and he still has hell to look forward to. The verdict defines Victor's condition as a threshold. He is neither living, in any sense that would include speech, will, or relation, nor dead; he has been held for a year in the zone between the two by the same hand that was destroying him. Even the canopy of air fresheners belongs to this logic. Alain Corbin's history of olfaction, *Le Miasme et la jonquille* (1982), showed how the modern bourgeois order defined itself through deodorization, the suppression of the stench of bodies and of the poor; the Christian imagination had for centuries opposed to the stench of corruption the odor of sanctity that rose from the incorrupt bodies of saints. Victor's room offers neither sanctity nor hygiene, only the commodity's parody of incense, a cheap fragrance hung above a rotting man—the city's apathy rendered as a scent.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer*, published in Italian in the same year as *Se7en*, supplies the concept that names Victor's zone. Agamben distinguishes, following Greek usage, between *zoē*, the simple fact of living common to all animals, and *bios*, the qualified form of life proper to an individual or a group, and argues that Western sovereignty has from its origins been founded on the production of bare life: life stripped of its form and exposed to a power that may take it without committing homicide and without celebrating sacrifice. In the third part of the book Agamben turns to the hospital, to the state that French neurologists described in 1959 as *coma dépassé*, the overcomatose condition in which a body is kept alive by technology after the cessation of brain function, and to the jurisprudence that arose to decide when such a body might be allowed to die. The overcomatose patient, in Agamben's account, is a being whose life is purely vegetative, delivered wholly to the decision of medicine and law; in him the threshold between life and death becomes the object of a sovereign determination. Victor is the overcomatose body produced not by a hospital but by a private sovereign. Doe has kept him alive for a year, as the daily photographs attest—maintained, prevented from dying—so that his life might be reduced to its biological minimum and exhibited as such.

The tableau thus fuses the two forms of power Michel Foucault distinguished in the final part of the first volume of his *Histoire de la sexualité* (1976). Sovereign power, Foucault argued, was the right to take life or let live, symbolized by the sword; modern biopower is the power to make live and let die, exercised through the administration of bodies and populations. Doe exercises both. In the other tableaux he takes life with the blade; in Victor's he makes live, and makes living itself the punishment. Victor's bed is a camp of one, the point at which the sovereign right of death and the biopolitical management of life coincide in a single body—the coincidence that Agamben identified as the hidden paradigm of modern politics.

The tableau resonated, in the years of the film's conception, with a public controversy that had carried the threshold between life and death into American courtrooms and living rooms. In June 1990 the Supreme Court decided *Cruzan v. Director, Missouri Department of Health*, concerning the withdrawal of a feeding tube from a young woman in a persistent vegetative state, a condition named in 1972 by the neurologists Bryan Jennett and Fred Plum. The same month Jack Kevorkian assisted in the first of the deaths that would make him a national figure, and in November 1994 Oregon's voters approved a ballot measure permitting physician-assisted death. The "right to die" was among the defining bioethical controversies of the years in which *Se7en* was written and made. Victor is its nightmare inversion: a body kept alive against every conceivable will, not by medicine's excessive zeal but by a punisher's design, so that the prolongation of life becomes the instrument of torment.

The literary imagination had anticipated the figure. In Poe's "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar" (1845), a mesmerist places a dying man in trance at the very moment of death and holds him there, neither alive nor dead, for nearly seven months, until the lifting of the trance reduces him in an instant to "a nearly liquid mass of loathsome —of detestable putridity." His only utterances in the interval issue from a voice that seems to come from a vast distance, announcing that he has been sleeping and is now dead. The mesmerist, like Doe, is a sovereign of the threshold, and Valdemar, like Victor, a body suspended in the interval that the sovereign controls. The victim's name summons a second Gothic precedent. Mary Shelley's Victor Frankenstein (1818) usurps the divine prerogative over life and death by animating dead matter. Doe performs the inverse usurpation upon a man named Victor, reducing a living body to something that resembles dead matter while forbidding it to die. The name that in Romantic fiction belonged to the creator of life now belongs to its most abject product.

Freud, in his essay on the uncanny (1919), adopted Ernst Jentsch's observation that among the most reliable sources of uncanny feeling is doubt as to whether an apparently animate being is really alive or, conversely, whether a lifeless object might not in fact be animate; and he added that to many people the idea of being buried alive by mistake is the most uncanny thing of all. The convulsion of the body on the bed, the film's most celebrated shock, is the uncanny in Jentsch's and Freud's exact sense: the corpse that moves, the burial that was premature. Its force derives from the collapse of a distinction on which investigators and spectators alike have relied. Everyone in the room has assumed that the series kills. The third tableau reveals that the machine can also preserve, and that what it preserves is worse than what it kills.

3.3

The Photographic Year: Chronophotography, *Kusōzu*, and the Mummy Complex

The daily photographs of Victor are the most important documents in the case, and among the most significant images of the image in the cinema of the 1990s. They establish, first, a chronology that reframes the entire series. The first was taken exactly a year before the discovery, which means that the seven-day week the film depicts is only the visible surface of a design matured over twelve months. Doe's heptad rests upon a solar year. The week is the last movement of a work whose preparation had the duration of a liturgical cycle, the octave of a long novitiate.

They establish, second, Doe's medium. The killer is a photographer. His apartment contains a darkroom; among his prints the investigators will find a photograph of Mills, taken, it emerges, by Doe himself in the guise of a press photographer at one of the scenes; and the film's opening titles show his hands developing negatives. Photography is the instrument of his surveillance, his archive, and his art. The year of photographs of Victor is its masterpiece: a chronophotographic study in the line of Eadweard Muybridge and Étienne-Jules Marey, but inverted in its object. Muybridge and Marey decomposed motion into instants in order to see what the eye could not; Doe decomposes immobility into days in order to render visible what the eye would never notice, the imperceptible advance of decay. Laid end to end and riffled like the

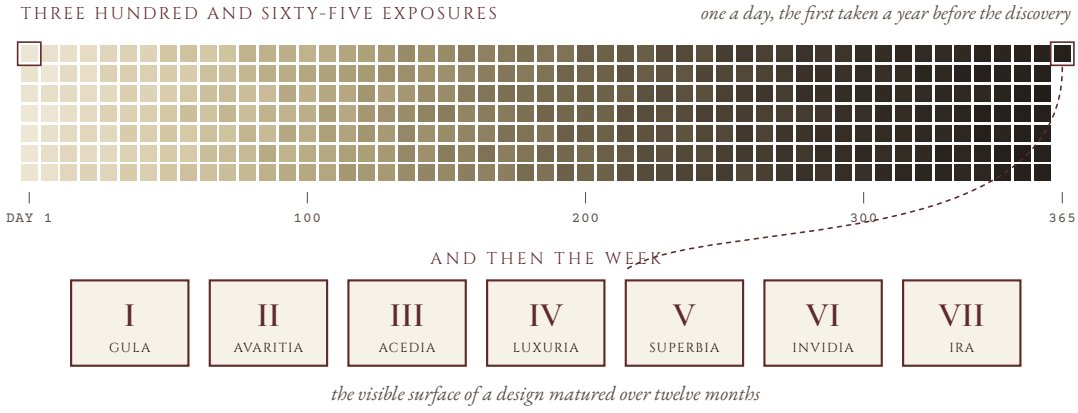


FIG. 09 THE PHOTOGRAPHIC YEAR *Three hundred and sixty-five daily exposures set out as a calendar of decay, the first taken exactly a year before the discovery; beneath them, the seven days the film depicts. Doe's heptad rests upon a solar year.*

pages of a book, his photographs would yield a film of a single year projected at the speed of decomposition. Cinema, in this device, is slowed until it coincides with rot.

André Bazin, in "Ontologie de l'image photographique" (1945), located the origin of the plastic arts in what he called the mummy complex: the impulse, visible in the Egyptian practice of embalming, to preserve being through its likeness and so to defeat time. Photography, Bazin argued, fulfills that impulse by embalming time itself, rescuing it from its proper corruption; and cinema extends the embalming to duration, so that the image of things becomes also the image of their change, mummified. Doe's photographs invert Bazin's ontology with diabolical exactness. They do not rescue time from corruption; they preserve corruption as time. And the body they document is itself a mummy in the literal sense, a living man desiccated, bound, and laid out upon his bier. The mummy complex, which Bazin read as the expression of a desire to save, becomes here the instrument of a desire to condemn.

Roland Barthes, in *La Chambre claire* (1980), found the essence of the photograph in its tense, the *ça-a-été*, the that-has-been, and in the punctum of time it inflicts upon the viewer. His exemplary case was Alexander Gardner's 1865 portrait of Lewis Payne, photographed in his cell as he awaited execution for his part in the conspiracy against Lincoln: the photograph, Barthes wrote, tells us at once that he is dead and that he is going to die, "*il est mort et il va mourir*." Every photograph of Victor carries this double tense, and the series multiplies it three hundred and sixty-five times. Each image declares that he was thus on that day and that he would be worse on the next; each is the portrait of a condemned man taken by his executioner in full knowledge of the sentence. Susan Sontag's dictum in *On Photography* (1977) that "all photographs are memento mori" finds here its most literal realization: to photograph Victor every day is to participate in his mortality as its administrator.

The comparative field is wide. The Buddhist meditation on the foulness of the body prescribes, in the charnel-ground contemplations of the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, that the monk regard a corpse one, two, three days dead, swollen, livid, festering, and reflect that his own body is of the same nature and will not escape that fate. Japanese painters from the Kamakura period onward rendered these stages in the scrolls known as *kusōzu*, the nine stages of the decaying corpse, usually that of a once-beautiful woman, as aids to detachment. The Christian Middle Ages produced the legend of the Three Living and the Three Dead, in which three young nobles meet three corpses who tell them that what the nobles are, the dead once were, and what the dead are, the nobles will be; and it produced the transi tombs of the fifteenth century, such as Archbishop Henry Chichele's at Canterbury, on which the effigy of the prelate in his vestments lies above the effigy of his emaciated cadaver. These are images of decay made for the conversion of their viewers, meditations on impermanence directed

toward liberation from attachment or preparation for death. Doe's photographs borrow their form and reverse their end. They are a *kusōzu* of a living man, made not to free the viewer from attachment but to bind the viewer to a verdict.

The art world of Walker's New York had produced still closer analogues. Between 1978 and 1986 the Taiwanese-born artist Tehching Hsieh performed in Manhattan a series of One Year Performances. In the first he confined himself for a year in a cage in his studio, without speaking, reading, or writing; in the second, the *Time Clock Piece* of 1980–81, he punched a worker's time clock every hour on the hour for a year and photographed himself at each punch, his shaven head slowly growing out to mark the passage of time, so that the year could be compressed into a few minutes of film. In California in 1972 Chris Burden had lain for twenty-two days in a bed installed in a gallery, without speaking. Peter Greenaway's film *A Zed & Two Noughts* (1985) follows twin zoologists who, after the deaths of their wives, become obsessed with the time-lapse photography of decomposition and end by attempting to film their own. Doe's photographic year belongs to this lineage of durational art, art whose medium is the year and whose subject is the body's subjection to time. It differs in one absolute respect. Hsieh and Burden consented to their confinement; Greenaway's twins chose their end. Victor chose nothing. The durational work has been made with another man's body.

Benjamin's theses supply, finally, the historical-philosophical meaning of Doe's archive. The chronicler who recounts events without distinguishing between great and small, Benjamin wrote in the third thesis, acts in accordance with the truth that nothing that has ever happened should be regarded as lost to history—though only a redeemed humanity receives the fullness of its past. Doe's archive is the chronicler's completeness placed in the service of damnation rather than redemption: a total record, a photograph for every day, two thousand notebooks of observation, compiled not to save the past but to convict it. It is the purest instance in the modern cinema of the document of civilization that is at the same time a document of barbarism.

3.4

The Vestibule of the Neutrals: Dante's *Ignavi* and the Apathetic City

Before Dante enters Hell proper, before he crosses the Acheron, he passes through a vestibule whose inhabitants Hell itself refuses. Here run the souls of those

who lived "*sanza 'nfamia e sanza lodo*," without infamy and without praise (*Inf.* III.36), mingled with the angels who were neither rebels against God nor faithful to him, but were for themselves. Heaven expels them lest its beauty be diminished; deep Hell will not receive them, lest the damned derive some glory from their company. They chase forever after a whirling banner, naked, stung by hornets and wasps, their blood mingling with their tears and feeding the loathsome worms at their feet. Virgil's judgment upon them is the most contemptuous in the poem: "*Questi non hanno speranza di morte*"—these have no hope of death—and their blind life is so abject "that they are envious of every other lot." The world suffers no report of them to survive; mercy and justice alike disdain them; "let us not speak of them, but look, and pass on" (*Inf.* III.46–51).

The vestibule of the neutrals is the moral topography of Somerset's city. Its inhabitants are those who have refused to choose—the apathetic, the indifferent, the uncommitted—and their punishment is not fire but futility, the endless pursuit of a banner that signifies nothing under the torment of small stings. The details of Virgil's verdict converge upon *Se7en* with uncanny precision. The neutrals have no hope of death: this is the literal condition of Victor, kept alive beyond any hope of release, as it is the metaphorical condition of a city that can neither die nor live. They are envious of every other lot: envy, the sin Doe will confess, is the passion of the uncommitted, the resentment of those who have chosen nothing toward those whose lives have shape. And the instruction Virgil gives his charge, *guarda e passa*, look and pass on, is the formula of the bystander. The ethic the city practices, and that Somerset has come to recommend, is the ethic Virgil prescribes for the contemplation of those who deserve no attention.

Among the neutrals Dante recognizes "the shade of him who made through cowardice the great refusal" (*Inf.* III.59–60), identified by most of the early commentators as Pope Celestine V, the hermit elected to the papacy in 1294 who abdicated after some five months and opened the way to Boniface VIII. The great refusal is an abdication—a retirement. Somerset's planned departure is, in this light, a *gran rifiuto*, the renunciation of an office at the moment of its gravest demand, and his reversal at the end of the film is the refusal of the refusal. The popular maxim that the hottest places in hell are reserved for those who maintain their neutrality in times of moral crisis, widely attributed to Dante and repeated by John F. Kennedy, misreads the poem in an instructive way. Dante's neutrals are not in the hottest place; they are in no place at all. Their punishment is exclusion from the moral order altogether, an eternity of insignificance. That is the fate Somerset fears and the fate Doe's series is designed to abolish. Doe will permit no one to remain neutral, least of all the detectives.

THE VESTIBULE OF THE NEUTRALS

Hell in section, after the topography of the Inferno

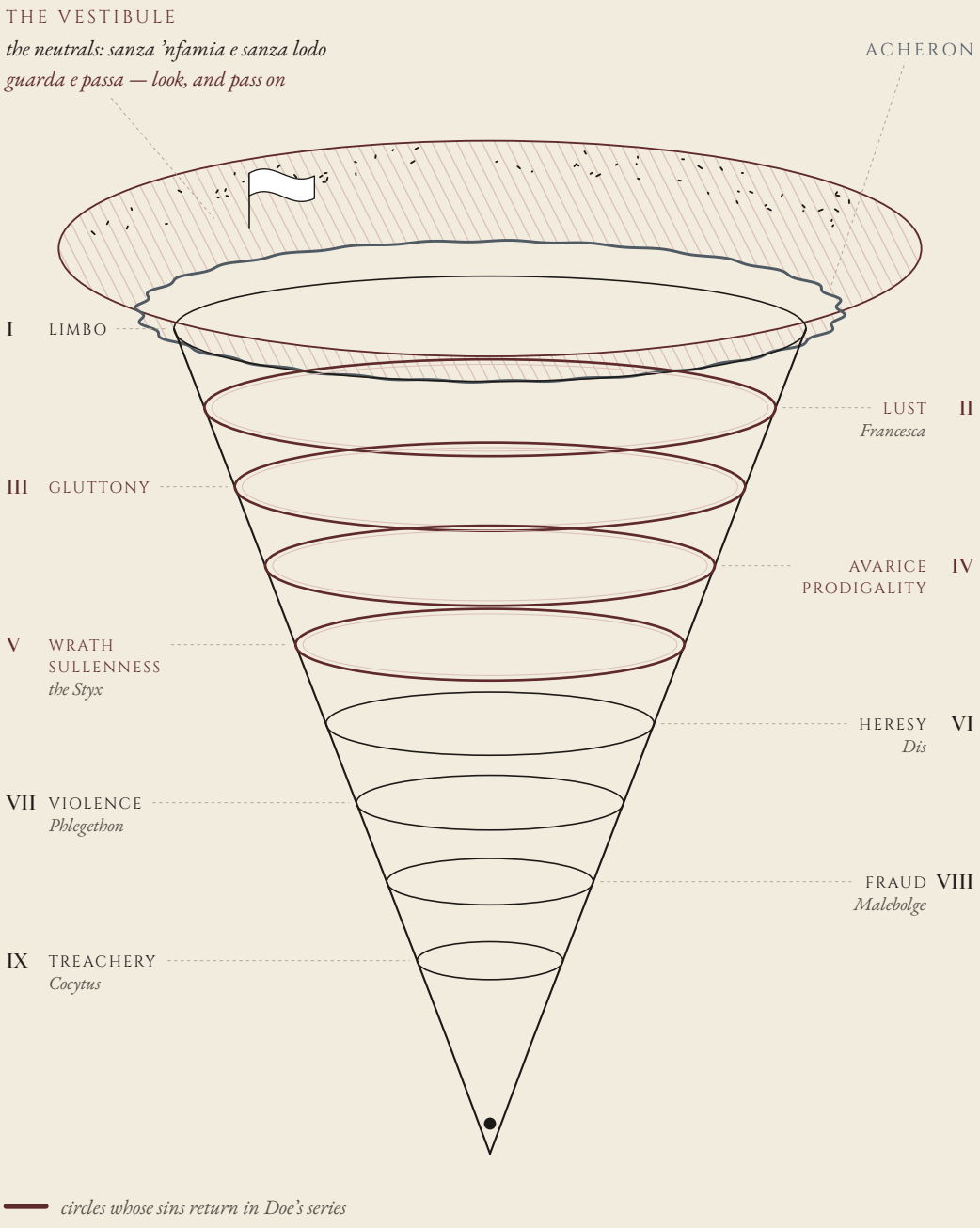


FIG. 10 THE VESTIBULE OF THE NEUTRALS

Outside Hell proper, before the Acheron, the neutrals chase a whirling banner, stung by hornets and wasps: souls Heaven expels and deep Hell refuses. Virgil's instruction to his charge, guarda e passa*, is the formula of the bystander, and the moral topography of Somerset's city.*

T. S. Eliot, in *The Waste Land* (1922), transposed the vestibule into the modern metropolis: "Unreal City, / Under the brown fog of a winter dawn, / A crowd flowed over London Bridge, so many, / I had not thought death had undone so many" (ll. 60–63). The last line translates Dante's astonishment at the length of the train of neutrals, "*ch'i' non averei creduto / che morte tanta n'avesse disfatta*" (*Inf.* III.56–57), and Eliot's note identifies the source. The commuters of the City of London are the neutrals of the antechamber, the living who are already undone. Eliot's note to "Unreal City" cites a second source that bears still more directly on *Se7en*: Baudelaire's "Les Sept Vieillards" (1859), which opens with an apostrophe to the "*Fourmillante cité, cité pleine de rêves, / Où le spectre en plein jour raccroche le passant*"—swarming city, city full of dreams, where the specter in broad daylight accosts the passer-by. The poem narrates the apparition, on a foggy morning in a Paris street, of a decrepit old man followed by another identical to him, and another, until seven identical figures have passed, a procession of doubles issuing from the same hell. The narrator, shaken, asks whether he could have looked upon an eighth without dying—"*Aurais-je, sans mourir, contemplé le huitième, / Sosie inexorable, ironique et fatal, / Dégoûtant Phénix, fils et père de lui-même?*"—could he, without dying, have contemplated the eighth, inexorable double, ironic and fatal, loathsome Phoenix, son and father of himself? And he turns his back on the infernal procession.

Baudelaire's poem is the first great text of serial horror in the modern city, and it poses, avant la lettre, the question this dissertation has placed at its center. In the patristic tradition the eighth day is resurrection, the opening of the closed cycle onto what exceeds it. In Baudelaire the eighth is death: the self-begetting double that would prolong the series to infinity, the Phoenix that is its own father and its own son. Two eighths confront each other across the history of the West, the eighth that breaks the series and the eighth that perpetuates it, and *Se7en* is suspended between them. Doe's design aims at the Baudelairean eighth, a series so complete that it will reproduce itself in the studies and imitations he expects it to inspire. Somerset's decision to remain gestures, faintly, toward the Augustinian one.

The vestibule defines, finally, the position of the film's own spectator. The spectator of a crime film is the professional bystander, the one who looks and passes on, consuming one atrocity and proceeding to the next. *Se7en* is constructed to make that passage impossible. It ends not with an image that can be looked at and left behind but with an image that cannot be looked at at all, and therefore cannot be passed. The withheld head is the film's refusal of the bystander's ethic: what we are not permitted to see, we are not permitted to leave.

3.5

Fire, Not Help: Genovese, the Bystander, and the Bankruptcy of Social Capital

Somerset's diagnosis of the city rests upon a parable the city tells about itself. In the conversation in which he explains to Mills why he is leaving, he argues that apathy has become the city's solution because every form of care demands effort: it is easier to lose oneself in drugs than to cope with life, easier to steal than to earn, easier to beat a child than to raise one, because love costs. It is in this register that he relays the advice given in self-defense classes, that a woman under attack should cry "fire" rather than "help," because no one will answer a cry for help; and he recounts an assault of the previous night in which a man already robbed and lying senseless was stabbed in the eyes—violence in excess of any interest, cruelty without profit, the gratuitous as the signature of a city beyond comprehension.

The definition Somerset gives of apathy is, with startling exactness, Dante's definition of sloth. On the fourth terrace of the mountain, Virgil explains, is purged *lento amore*, slow love: the love that perceives the good but is too sluggish to pursue it (*Purg.* XVII.130–132). Love costs, Somerset says, and the city will not pay. The sloth of *Se7en* is not the idleness of a single body, Victor's, but the slow love of a whole population; and Somerset, who diagnoses it, is himself in flight from the labor that love would require of him.

The parable on which the diagnosis depends has a history. In March 1964 Catherine Genovese was stabbed to death outside her apartment building in Kew Gardens, Queens. Two weeks later *The New York Times* reported, under a headline that would become proverbial, that thirty-seven respectable citizens—thirty-eight in the body of the article—had watched the attack over half an hour without calling the police. The story became the founding myth of urban apathy. It generated A. M. Rosenthal's *Thirty-Eight Witnesses* (1964) and inspired the experiments in which the social psychologists John Darley and Bibb Latané demonstrated the bystander effect, the tendency of individuals to help less readily in the presence of others, through the diffusion of responsibility and the pluralistic ignorance by which each witness takes the inaction of the rest as evidence that nothing is wrong (Darley and Latané 1968; Latané and Darley, *The Unresponsive Bystander*, 1970). The advice to cry "fire" rather than "help," circulated through self-defense manuals and urban folklore, belongs to the same constellation. It encodes a sociology in a single word: the citizen will not intervene to save another, but will respond to a threat to himself and his property.

Later scholarship has shown the founding myth to be largely a myth. Rachel Manning, Mark Levine, and Alan Collins demonstrated in 2007 that the number of witnesses had been greatly exaggerated, that few saw the attack in its entirety, that at least one neighbor did call the police, and that another went down to hold the dying woman in her arms—a story the original account had suppressed in favor of the parable its authors wished to tell. The point is not that the city is not callous. It is that the narrative of the city's callousness had become, by the time of *Se7en*, a story the city told about itself so persuasively that it shaped what its inhabitants believed they could expect from one another, and therefore what they did.

The film registers this with a subtlety that is easily missed. Mills's reply to Somerset's speech is the most penetrating line of social analysis in the screenplay: he suspects, he tells the older man, that Somerset is not leaving because he believes these things, but believes them because he is leaving. The parable of apathy, on Mills's diagnosis, is the rationalization of a withdrawal already decided. The narrative of universal indifference licenses the narrator's own indifference; the bystander's sociology is the bystander's alibi. Mills, who will end the film as wrath, here speaks the truth about acedia: that the despair which presents itself as lucidity is often the despair of one who has already ceased to love.

The archetype of the bystander is older than any city. In the parable Jesus tells in answer to the question "who is my neighbour?", a man going down from Jerusalem to Jericho falls among thieves, who strip and wound him and leave him half dead; "and by chance there came down a certain priest that way: and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side," and likewise a Levite, until a Samaritan, a stranger from a despised people, binds up his wounds (Luke 10:30–37). In 1973 Darley and C. Daniel Batson restaged the parable as an experiment. Seminarians on their way to deliver a short talk, some of them on the Good Samaritan, passed a man slumped in a doorway, and whether they stopped depended less on their piety or their topic than on whether they had been told they were late. The variable that turned priests and Levites into bystanders was hurry. The city of *Se7en* is a city of hurry—a week counted down, a case to be closed, a retirement to be reached—and its acedia is not stillness but a haste that will not stop.

Jane Jacobs, in *The Death and Life of Great American Cities* (1961), located the safety of city streets not in policing but in what she called eyes upon the street: the informal, continuous, unremarkable attention of shopkeepers, residents, and passers-by, the intricate sidewalk ballet through which a neighborhood watches over itself without surveillance. The city of *Se7en* has lost those eyes, and in their place it has installed two other kinds of watching. One is the eye of the state, the Bureau's covert monitoring of library loans; the other is the eye of the killer, who photographs,

observes, and records. The bankruptcy of social capital is the condition of possibility for both. Where neighbors no longer look, the police and the murderer look instead, and the attention that once circulated as care returns as surveillance. The coda will argue that the ethics of the eighth day is, at bottom, the recovery of a third kind of looking, neither the bystander's nor the watcher's: attention.

3.6

The Metronome: Melancholy, Insomnia, and the Discipline of Rhythm

Somerset cannot sleep in the city. In the darkness of his apartment, as sirens and shouting rise from the street, he sets a metronome ticking beside his bed, and its regular beat carries him toward sleep through the noise. The instrument is a small and exact emblem of his condition. The metronome, patented by Johann Nepomuk Maelzel in 1815 and made famous by Beethoven's adoption of its markings, is a machine for the production of regular time; it imposes a measured pulse upon whatever surrounds it. Somerset uses it as a monk uses the bell. It is his private horarium, a liturgy of the hours reduced to its mechanical skeleton, an order of time set against the disorder of the city.

The association is historically exact. Lewis Mumford argued in *Technics and Civilization* (1934) that the clock, not the steam engine, is the key machine of the modern industrial age, and that its origin lies in the Benedictine monastery, whose regulation of the day by the canonical hours gave European life its first collective rhythm of regular time. The Rule of Benedict declared that idleness is the enemy of the soul, "*otiositas inimica est animae*" (*Regula* 48), and divided the monk's day into alternating hours of prayer, reading, and labor precisely so as to leave no interval in which the noonday demon might find a foothold. E. P. Thompson's "Time, Work-Discipline, and Industrial Capitalism" (1967) traced the secularization of that discipline into the factory clock. Somerset's metronome belongs to this genealogy. It is the last monastic bell in a city that has converted the monk's horarium into the time clock, and it summons him no longer to prayer but only to unconsciousness. His other nocturnal discipline is darker. Alone at night, he throws a switchblade again and again into a dartboard. The rhythm of the metronome and the rhythm of the blade are two ways of mastering an energy that has nowhere to go, the one by measure, the other by aggression sublimated into a game. Somerset's melancholy is not without its wrath.

The iconography of learned melancholy supplies Somerset's ancestry. Albrecht Dürer's engraving *Melencolia I* (1514) shows a winged and heavy figure seated amid the instruments of measurement and making—compass, plane, saw, ruler, scales, an hourglass, a bell, a magic square—her head propped upon her hand, her eyes open and unseeing, unable to use the knowledge spread about her. Raymond Klibansky, Erwin Panofsky, and Fritz Saxl, in *Saturn and Melancholy* (1964), read the engraving as the portrait of a genius condemned by Saturn to an intellect that can measure the world but cannot transcend it: the melancholy of the gifted mind in the Ficinian tradition, for which melancholy was the temperament of scholars and the price of insight. Somerset is a Saturnine figure in exactly this sense, a reader and measurer of traces, surrounded by the instruments of knowledge, whose learning yields understanding without remedy. Saturn, the planet of melancholy, is also the god of time, the Kronos whom the Renaissance conflated with Chronos, and the father who devours his children for fear of being supplanted. Somerset's confession to Tracy, in the diner where she tells him that she is pregnant and afraid to bring a child into the city, places him, with a delicacy the film never violates, within this iconography. Years before, he tells her, he persuaded a woman he loved not to have their child, and the certainty with which he made that decision has not, he admits, survived the years since. The melancholic's dread of the future has already, once, foreclosed his own posterity.

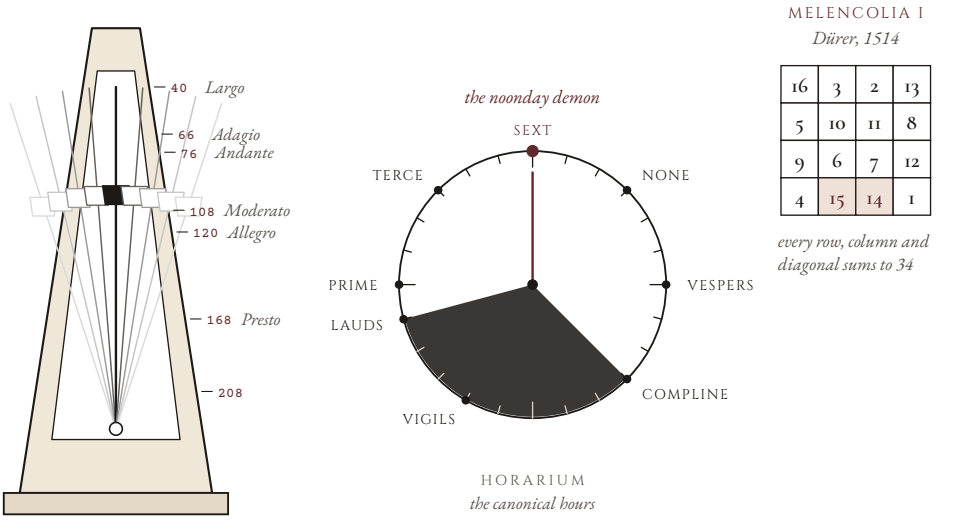


FIG. 11 INSTRUMENTS OF REGULAR TIME *Maelzel's metronome, patented in 1815; the canonical hours of the monastic day, with Sext, the noonday hour, at the zenith; and the magic square of Dürer's Melencolia I, whose bottom row holds the year 1514.*

The Renaissance and early modern literature of melancholy supplies Somerset's most articulate precursors. Petrarch, in the *Secretum* (composed c. 1347–53), has Augustine diagnose in the poet's soul a deadly plague that the moderns call *accidia* and the ancients *aegritudo*, and the poet confesses that he feeds upon his tears and sorrows with a kind of dark pleasure. Robert Burton's *The Anatomy of Melancholy* (1621), written, as its author explains, by being busy to avoid melancholy, identifies idleness as a principal cause of the disease and occupation as its best cure, and closes with the counsel "Be not solitary, be not idle." Kierkegaard's aesthete in *Either/Or* (1843) declares boredom the root of all evil and recounts, in a mock genealogy, how the gods were bored and so created human beings, how Adam was bored alone and so Eve was created, and how the peoples of the earth, bored *en masse*, built a tower to reach the heavens. Babel, in this genealogy, is the architecture of boredom; the city itself is the work of acedia. Somerset is solitary and about to become idle. His retirement would complete the melancholic's program, and Burton's closing counsel is the coda's prescription in advance.

Walter Benjamin's study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928) gives the melancholic a political dimension that prepares the confrontation of the seventh chapter. The sovereign of the baroque mourning-play, Benjamin argued in a deliberate inversion of Carl Schmitt, is defined not by his capacity for decision but by his incapacity for it: the melancholic prince, of whom Hamlet is the supreme instance, is paralyzed among possibilities, and his court is governed by the acedia of the courtier, faithless because he has despaired of the good. The confrontation between Somerset and Doe is the confrontation between Benjamin's prince and Schmitt's sovereign. Somerset weighs, delays, doubts, and plans his withdrawal; Doe decides. The film's terrible wager is that, in a city sunk in acedia, the capacity for decision has passed to the murderer. The question its ending poses is whether the melancholic can recover the power to decide without becoming the sovereign—whether there exists a decision that is not a verdict. Somerset's last words are the first answer.

3.7

Sabbath and Sloth: Cessation, Rest, and the Theology of Inactivity

The deepest theological meaning of sloth lies in its relation to the Sabbath, and Aquinas states the relation with perfect clarity. Asked whether acedia is a mortal sin, he answers that it is so in its genus, because it is contrary to charity; and to the

objection that no commandment forbids it, he replies that acedia is opposed to the precept of hallowing the Sabbath, for that precept, insofar as it is moral, implicitly commands the mind's rest in God, and sorrow of the mind about the divine good is contrary to that rest (*ST* II-II, q. 35, a. 3, ad 1). Acedia is the anti-Sabbath. It is not the absence of work but the incapacity for rest: the sorrow that cannot repose in the good because it has despaired of it. Josef Pieper, recovering the scholastic doctrine in *Muße und Kult* (1948), drew the consequence that the opposite of acedia is not industriousness but leisure, the festive and contemplative affirmation of the world, and that the frantic activity of the modern world of total work is itself a form of acedia, a restlessness fleeing the self it cannot affirm. Abraham Joshua Heschel's *The Sabbath* (1951) described the seventh day as a palace in time, a sanctuary built not of space but of hours, in which the human being ceases from the domination of things and is attuned to holiness.

Between the medieval doctrine and the modern city stands the transformation that Max Weber traced in *Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus* (1904–05). In the Puritan ethic of vocation, Weber argued, the waste of time became the first and in principle the gravest of all sins—"*Zeitvergeudung ist also die erste und prinzipiell schwerste aller Sünden*"—and idleness, the refusal of productive labor, displaced spiritual sorrow as the meaning of sloth. The monk's despair of the divine good became the worker's failure to be useful. Paul Lafargue's *Le Droit à la paresse* (1880), written against what he called the dogma of work, inverted the inversion and claimed laziness as a right of the exploited; the counter-tradition he inaugurated, from the bed-ins of 1969 to the durational art of the following decades, reclaimed idleness as a refusal of capital's demand for perpetual production.

Doe's third tableau belongs unmistakably to Weber's world rather than to Evagrius's. He punishes Victor, whom he describes as a drug dealer and a predator, for sloth in the bourgeois sense: for living without honest work, profiting from vice, consuming without producing. His theology of sloth is the Protestant ethic of productivity carried to its punitive extreme; the sin he punishes is the economic sin of idleness, not the spiritual sin of despair. In this he misreads his own tradition, and the misreading is revealing. The acedia of *Se7en*, in the Evagrian and Thomist sense, does not lie in Victor's bed. It lies in Somerset's insomnia, in the city's slow love, in the bystander's hurry—and in Doe himself, whose rancor and malice are, on Gregory's genealogy, among the daughters of sloth. The man who punishes sloth is its child.

The form of the punishment confirms the misreading. Dante's *contrapasso* operates in two registers. In the *Inferno* the punishment frequently resembles the sin: the lustful are blown about by winds as they were driven by passion, and the sower of discord is himself cut asunder. In the *Purgatorio* purgation proceeds by the contrary:

the proud bend beneath enormous stones to learn humility, and the slothful, on the fourth terrace, run without ceasing, crying out examples of zeal—"*Ratto, ratto, che 'l tempo non si perda / per poco amor*," quick, quick, lest time be lost through too little love (*Purg.* XVIII.103–104)—so that the habit of sluggishness is replaced by the habit of haste in love. Doe takes his catalogue of sins from the canticle Somerset consults in the library, the *Purgatorio*, but his punishments follow the logic of the *Inferno*. Victor, who would not move, is bound so that he cannot move; his punishment is his sin made permanent. Nowhere in the series does Doe punish by the contrary, because punishment by the contrary aims at conversion, and Doe does not believe in conversion. The hebdomadal machine is a Purgatory administered on infernal principles, a ladder of ascent converted into a pit. This is the precise sense in which the film is, as the first chapter proposed, a purgatory without purgation.

Scripture knew a punitive Sabbath. The Levitical law commanded that the land itself keep a Sabbath every seventh year, lying fallow in rest, and warned that if the people refused the land its Sabbaths they would be scattered among the nations: "Then shall the land enjoy her sabbaths, as long as it lieth desolate, and ye be in your enemies' land; even then shall the land rest, and enjoy her sabbaths" (Lev. 26:34). The Chronicler interpreted the Babylonian exile in exactly these terms: the land lay waste "until the land had enjoyed her sabbaths: for as long as she lay desolate she kept sabbath, to fulfil threescore and ten years" (2 Chron. 36:21). The rest refused is exacted as desolation. Victor's year is a Sabbath of desolation in this terrible sense. The rest he is imagined to have stolen from labor is imposed upon him as a sentence and extended until rest becomes indistinguishable from ruin. Doe grants him, while he still lives, the *requiem aeternam* of the liturgy of the dead.

Psalm 95 binds rest and wrath in a single oath: "Unto whom I sware in my wrath that they should not enter into my rest" (Ps. 95:11), the verse the Epistle to the Hebrews makes the text of its meditation on the Sabbath rest that "remaineth … to the people of God" (Heb. 3:11; 4:9). Wrath is the power that excludes from rest. In *Se7en* no one rests. Somerset cannot sleep without a machine; Victor is denied both rest and death; the Sunday on which the series ends is a day of wrath rather than repose; and Mills's wrath will exclude him, at the last, from any rest whatever. The third tableau thus discloses the theological structure of the whole film: a week without a Sabbath, a city in which the seventh day has been converted from the day of rest into the day of judgment.

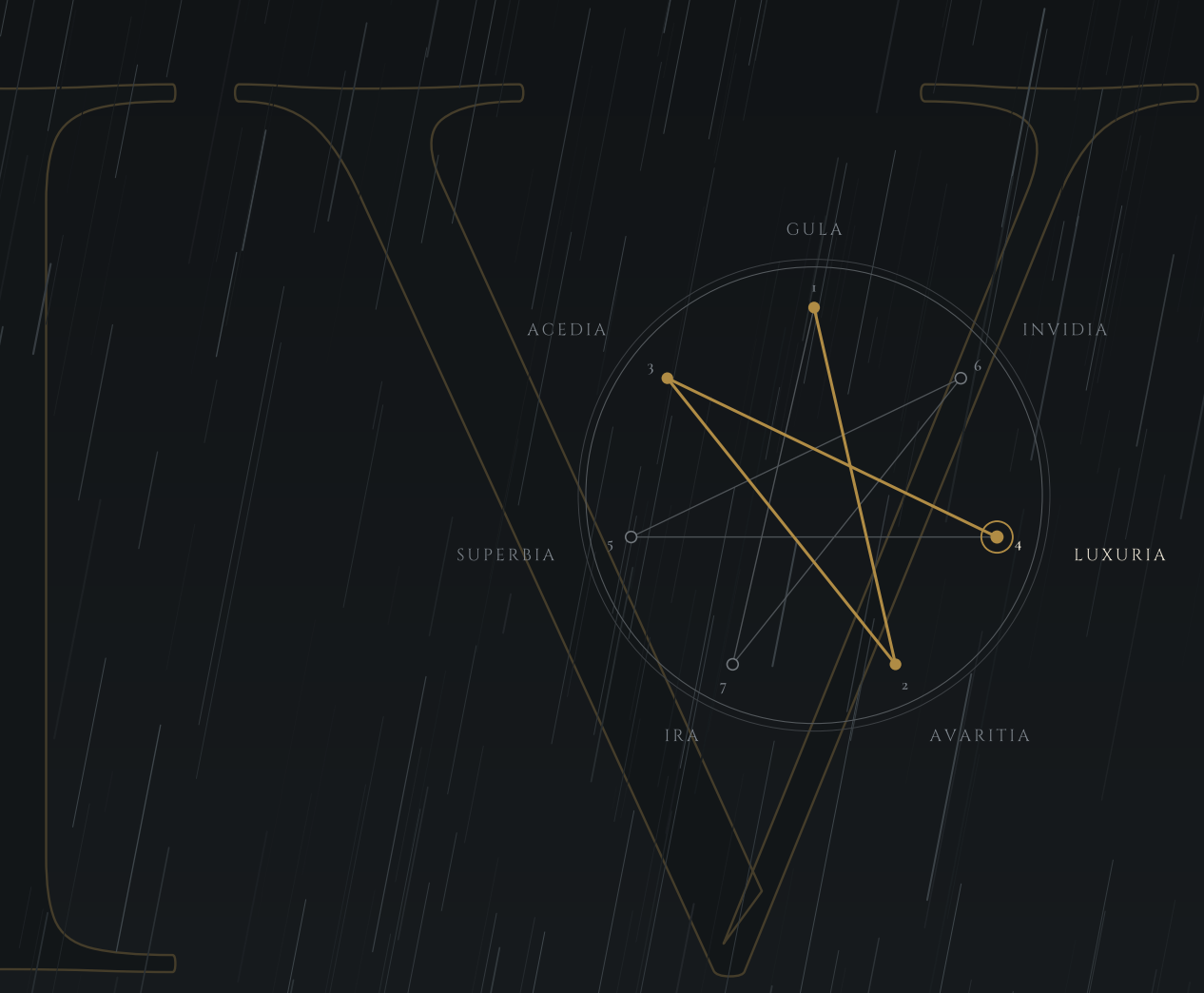
Against this structure the patristic tradition held out a rest beyond the seventh day, the eighth, on which, in Augustine's words, we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise. It is a rest that is not idleness but vision, not sloth but contemplation, not the absence of love but its fulfillment. The third day of Doe's series shows what

the hebdomad does with rest when it cannot imagine the eighth: it makes rest a punishment and immobility a sentence. From the body that cannot move, the series now turns to a body compelled to move against its will.

The Fourth Day

Luxuria

Lust



The Blade and the Gaze

Lust, Scopophilia, and the Pornographic Apparatus

Amor condusse noi ad una morte. [Love led us to one death.]

— *Dante, Inferno V.106*

Quid enim voluptatis habet videre in laniato cadavere quod exhorreas? [For what pleasure is there in seeing, in a mangled corpse, what makes you shudder?]

— *Augustine, Confessiones X.35.55*

4.1

The Hot House: Sex, Disease, and the Moral Epidemiology of the 1990s

The fourth sin is found in a sex club whose sign announces it as the Hot House, and its tableau is the one the film is most careful not to show. Somerset and Mills move through the red-lit corridors of an establishment the camera renders as a circle of the damned to a room in which a sex worker lies dead. The word LUST is written at the scene. She has been killed by a man whom Doe compelled at gunpoint to put on a bladed device, made to order in a fetish-leather shop, and to use it upon her. The man survives, in a state of shock from which the film gives no sign that he will recover. Neither the act nor its victim is displayed at any length; the crime reaches the spectator as aftermath and as testimony. Of all Doe's tableaux, the one most explicitly concerned with the flesh is the one the film most rigorously refuses to make into spectacle.

Doe's justification, offered in the car on the last day, dismisses the dead woman as a disease-spreading prostitute. The phrase is at once an epidemiology and a theology, and it belongs to a long history in which the bodies of women who sell sex have been construed as vectors of a contagion both physical and moral. In nineteenth-century Paris the hygienist Alexandre Parent-Duchâtelet, who had made his name with a study of the city's sewers, published in 1836 his monumental survey of prostitution, in which he argued that prostitutes are as inevitable in a concentration of men as sewers, cesspits, and refuse dumps, and must therefore be regulated by the state as it regulates drainage. Britain's Contagious Diseases Acts of the 1860s authorized the forcible medical inspection of women suspected of prostitution in garrison towns and provoked the campaign, led by Josephine Butler, that secured their repeal in 1886. The sewer analogy has a theological genealogy as well. Augustine, in the *De ordine* (386), warned that if prostitutes were removed from human affairs, everything would be thrown into confusion by lust; and the simile of the sewer in the palace, long attributed to Aquinas, appears in the continuation of the *De regimine principum* by his disciple Ptolemy of Lucca. The medieval Church tolerated prostitution as a necessary evil, a drain without which the city would be flooded. Doe's theology admits no such toleration. On this point he is more rigorist than Augustine: the theologian of zero tolerance cannot accept even the patristic logic of the necessary sewer.

The film appeared in the second decade of an epidemic that had given the oldest moral epidemiology a new and terrible currency. Susan Sontag's *AIDS and Its Metaphors* (1989), extending the argument of her *Illness as Metaphor* (1978), anatomized the rhetoric that construed the disease as punishment—the metaphor of plague, the language of invasion and pollution, the conversion of epidemiological "risk groups" into moral categories—and showed how such metaphors deform both the understanding of illness and the treatment of the ill. Camus had dramatized the same theology in *La Peste* (1947), in which the Jesuit Paneloux's first sermon informs the stricken city of Oran that it has deserved its affliction. Doe is Paneloux without the second sermon, the one in which the priest, having watched a child die in agony, can no longer speak of deserved suffering. His tableau of lust is a sermon on deserved contagion, and the dead woman is its text.

The moral epidemiology of the prostitute's body has a scriptural apex in the Apocalypse. The great city Babylon appears to the seer of Patmos as a woman arrayed in purple and scarlet, with a name written upon her forehead—"MYSTERY, BABYLON THE GREAT, THE MOTHER OF HARLOTS AND ABOMINATIONS OF THE EARTH" (Rev. 17:5)—and her destruction is accomplished by those who once desired her: the ten horns "shall hate the whore, and shall make her desolate and naked, and shall eat her flesh, and burn her with fire" (17:16). The prophetic literature of the Hebrew Bible had already figured the faithless city as an adulterous wife exposed and punished by her lovers (Hos. 2; Ezek. 16; 23). Feminist biblical scholarship has read these texts as rhetorics of gendered violence. Tina Pippin's *Death and Desire* (1992) argued that the Apocalypse's fantasy of the destroyed whore is a misogynist ecstasy of punishment, and Renita Weems's *Battered Love* (1995), published in the year of *Se7en*, traced in the prophets a theology that figures divine anger as a husband's violence against an unfaithful wife. Doe's fourth tableau literalizes Revelation 17:16 with uncanny exactness. The woman who sells desire is destroyed by one who desired her; the client is made the instrument of the harlot's desolation.

Against this tradition the Gospels preserve a single counter-scene, and it is a scene of writing. In the pericope of the woman taken in adultery, the scribes and Pharisees bring before Jesus a woman whom the law of Moses commands to be stoned, and he, stooping down, writes with his finger on the ground, "as though he heard them not"; then, lifting himself up, he tells them that he who is without sin among them should cast the first stone, and stoops again to write, until the accusers depart one by one and the woman is left alone with him: "Neither do I condemn thee: go, and sin no more" (John 8:1–11). It is the only occasion in the Gospels on which Jesus is said to write, and what he writes is not recorded. The content of the divine inscription is withheld;

its effect is to suspend the execution. Doe's writing is its exact antithesis. He writes upon walls, the word is legible, and its effect is to consummate the execution. The one gospel scene of writing at the site of a sexual offense is an apophatic inscription that saves; Doe's is a cataphatic inscription that condemns. The film, which withholds what its own final box contains, stands with the first writer rather than the second.

The iconographic tradition Doe inherits is unambiguous in its gendering. Romanesque sculptors carved Luxuria as a naked woman whose breasts are devoured by serpents, as on the porch of Saint-Pierre at Moissac; Spenser's Lechery rides a bearded goat in the procession of Lucifera (*The Faerie Queene* I.iv.24–26). The history of serial murder in the modern city, from the Whitechapel killings of 1888 to the Yorkshire murders of the late 1970s, whose perpetrator claimed to have been sent by God against prostitutes, has made the sex worker its most frequent victim, among those whom the criminologist Steven Egger called the "less-dead," whose killings provoke less outcry because their lives were valued less. In New York, in the years when Walker was writing, Joel Rifkin was killing women from the city's streets; he was arrested on Long Island in June 1993. Doe's choice of victim is thus not an idiosyncrasy but a repetition of the most entrenched pattern in the history of serial violence, and the film, whatever its restraint, inherits that pattern's gendered economy. Its two other female victims, the model of the fifth day and Tracy Mills, complete a distribution in which the sins of the flesh and of the face are assigned to women, and the sins of appetite, money, sloth, envy, and wrath to men. The critic who praises the film's restraint must also register the iconographic conservatism of its casting of sin.

Prudentius's *Psychomachia* (c. 405), the first Christian allegory of the war between virtues and vices, staged the defeat of each vice as a grotesque tableau in which the manner of death allegorizes the nature of the vice. *Se7en* is a psychomachia from which the virtues have withdrawn. Its vices are not slain by Chastity, Patience, or Humility. They are slain by another vice—envy disguised as justice—and the slaughter therefore restores no order, only a different disorder.

4.2

The Instrument: Prosthesis and the Forced Agent

The instrument of the fourth murder is the most overdetermined object in the film before the box. It is a commodity, ordered and paid for in a shop that sells leather goods for sexual role-play, whose proprietor fabricated it to specification without inquiring into its purpose. It is a fetish in Freud's sense, an object invested with the

sexual charge of the part it stands in for; and it is a weapon. In it the two fetishisms of modernity—Marx's fetishism of the commodity, which conceals social relations in things, and Freud's sexual fetish, which conceals a lack in an object—converge upon a blade. The market's indifference to use, the shopkeeper's professional incuriosity, is one more figure of the city's apathy. It is the commercial form of looking and passing on.

The device is also a prosthesis, and it belongs to the modern imagination of a body extended by technology into a weapon. Freud observed in *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930) that man has become, as it were, a kind of prosthetic god: truly magnificent when he puts on all his auxiliary organs, though these have not grown onto him and still give him much trouble. Doe's device is the prosthetic god's instrument in its most degraded form, an auxiliary organ that converts the act of sexual union into the act of killing. The cinema of the following decades made such fusions a signature. David Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983) had already imagined a man whose body is penetrated and programmed by a medium until his hand fuses with a pistol and he kills at the command of others; his *Crash* (1996), adapted from J. G. Ballard's novel of 1973, would eroticize the wreckage of the automobile. Hiromu Arakawa's manga *Fullmetal Alchemist* (2001–10), whose antagonists are homunculi named for the seven deadly sins, gives its Lust fingers that extend into lethal blades. The fusion of desire and blade is among the most persistent images in the iconography of the sin, and Doe's device is its most literal realization.

What distinguishes the fourth tableau from every other in the series is that its killer is not Doe. The man who wields the device is himself a victim, compelled at gunpoint to become the instrument of a death he did not will. He is the purest instance of what I shall call the *forced agent*: a human being whose body is made to perform an act that his will refuses. Aristotle had already isolated the difficulty in the third book of the *Nicomachean Ethics*, where he considers acts performed under the threat of a tyrant who holds one's parents and children hostage, and calls them mixed—voluntary in the moment, since the agent chooses them, yet involuntary in themselves, since no one would choose them for their own sake (*EN* III.1, 1110a). Augustine, defending the Christian women violated in the sack of Rome, insisted that the body is not defiled without the consent of the will, and that the sanctity of the body is not lost so long as the sanctity of the mind remains (*De civitate Dei* I.16–18). The forced agent of *Se7en* is guilty of nothing; his body has been used. The film registers the enormity of that use in the testimony that follows, in which the man, sweating and incoherent, can only repeat that he was made to do it.

The structure is not unique to the fourth day; it is Doe's signature, here made visible in its most extreme form. In most of the tableaux Doe arranges for the fatal

act to be performed by the victim or by another. The glutton is made to eat himself to death; the lawyer cuts his own flesh; Victor's body consumes itself over a year; the model, as the next chapter will show, swallows the pills; the man in the Hot House kills the woman; and at the end Mills will kill Doe and, in doing so, destroy himself. Elaine Scarry, in *The Body in Pain* (1985), showed that torture works by making the victim's body the agent of its own suffering, so that pain is experienced as a betrayal by one's own flesh and the world of objects is converted into an arsenal. Doe is a torturer in Scarry's exact sense, but his method has a theological source. "You have commanded it, and so it is," Augustine writes in the *Confessions*, "that every disordered mind should be its own punishment"—"*ut poena sua sibi sit omnis inordinatus animus*" (I.12.19). Doe makes Augustine's principle literal. He arranges for each sin to execute itself, and he presents the self-execution as the revelation of the sin's true nature.

The moral philosophy of the film's own moment supplies a precise vocabulary for what Doe does to persons. Kant's formula of humanity forbids treating humanity, in one's own person or in that of another, merely as a means (*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*, 1785), and Kant himself argued in his lectures on ethics that sexual appetite outside the reciprocal bond of marriage makes the other person an object of appetite, to be cast aside once satisfied. Martha Nussbaum's essay "Objectification," published in 1995, the year of *Se7en*, analyzed the concept into seven distinct notions: instrumentality, denial of autonomy, inertness, fungibility, violability, ownership, and denial of subjectivity. The coincidence of number invites a heuristic correspondence that proves startlingly apt when read in the order of Doe's sequence. The glutton, chosen as a type and never as a person, suffers fungibility; the lawyer, whose flesh is cut and weighed, violability; Victor, reduced to an immobile body, inertness; the forced agent of the Hot House, used as a living tool, instrumentality; the model, offered a parody of choice, denial of autonomy; Tracy, whom Doe will claim as a husband claims a wife, ownership; and Mills, whose grief Doe scripts and whose response he foresees, denial of subjectivity. The correspondence is not a key that Walker or Fincher planted. It is a demonstration that the hebdomadal machine is, in its inner logic, a machine for the objectification of persons, and that its seven terms exhaust the principal ways in which a human being can be made into a thing.

The fourth tableau also rehearses the ending. The forced agent of lust is a man whose body is made to kill while his will refuses. The forced agent of wrath, on the seventh day, will be a man whose will is captured by passion and whose body then kills by its own decision. The series moves from the compelled body to the compelled will, from the gun held to the head to the box delivered to the heart. The man in the

Hot House is the prototype of Mills: the first of Doe's instruments to be made to kill, and the image of the instrument Doe has reserved for last.

4.3

John and John Doe: The Name of the Client

THE FOURTH TABLEAU discloses the meaning of the killer's name. In American slang the client of a prostitute is a "john," a usage recorded from the early twentieth century and generally explained as deriving from the anonymous names—John Doe, John Smith—that such men gave or were imagined to give. The john is the man without a name, the customer present only as a generic placeholder, his identity withheld from the transaction he conducts. The killer who has made himself "John Doe" therefore bears the name of the client; and in the fourth tableau the anonymous John compels another anonymous man into the position of the john. The killer's name and the client's name are the same name, and what they share is anonymity, the condition of commercial sex in the city and of serial murder alike.

Walter Benjamin made the prostitute the privileged allegory of the commodity in the modern metropolis. In the exposé of the *Passagen-Werk*, "Paris, die Hauptstadt des XIX. Jahrhunderts" (1935), he wrote that ambiguity is the image of the dialectic at a standstill, and that such an image is provided by the commodity as fetish, by the arcades that are at once house and street, and by the whore, who is seller and commodity in one. In his studies of Baudelaire he traced the poet's fascination with the prostitute as the figure in whom the commodity form appears in human shape, as the flâneur was the figure through whom the crowd appeared as landscape. Baudelaire's "Le Crépuscule du soir" records the hour at which, as evening falls, "*La Prostitution s'allume dans les rues*"—prostitution lights up in the streets, opening its passages like an anthill. In the fourth tableau the anonymous client and the commodity in human form meet in the configuration Benjamin's analysis describes and Doe's theology cannot tolerate. The killer destroys the dialectical image: he kills the woman who is seller and commodity in one, and he does so by making the buyer the instrument.

The gender of anonymity in the film is asymmetrical. The killer takes for himself the male placeholder of the legal fiction, while the women he kills are left nameless in fact: the film scarcely names either its sex worker or its model, who enter its archive as their sins rather than their names. The female counterpart of John Doe, the "Jane Doe" of the morgue and the docket, is the name of the unidentified female corpse. Doe's anonymity is chosen and strategic, a mask of sovereignty; theirs is imposed,

the anonymity of the less-dead. The man who has erased his fingerprints in order to become no one has made himself the author of a series whose female terms are reduced to types.

The name John carries, finally, a scriptural charge the film activates without ever naming it. Two Johns preside over the Christian imagination of judgment. The first is John of Patmos, the seer of the Apocalypse, the book of sevens: seven churches, seven seals, seven trumpets, seven vials of the wrath of God. The second is John the Baptist, the prophet of repentance who preached in the wilderness the wrath to come —"O generation of vipers, who hath warned you to flee from the wrath to come?" (Matt. 3:7)—announced that the axe was already laid to the root of the trees, and was beheaded at the instigation of a woman whose unlawful marriage he had condemned, his head carried on a charger to a dancer at a royal feast (Matt. 14:3–11). The killer's given name condenses the two poles of the film: the heptadic apocalypse of John of Patmos and the severed head of John the Baptist. Doe, who preaches the wrath to come, who stages his final scene in a wilderness, and whose series ends in a head delivered as a gift, is a Baptist of the apocalypse, a voice crying in the desert that the axe has been laid to the root.

The surname completes the pattern. A doe is a female deer, the hunted animal, the quarry. Ovid tells of the hunter Actaeon who, wandering in the forest, came upon Diana bathing and was transformed by the goddess into a stag and torn apart by his own hounds (*Metamorphoses* III.138–252)—the punishment of the man who saw what he should not have seen. The killer named for the quarry is the hunter of the city's sins, and he ends, by design, as quarry, run to ground by the detectives he has summoned and brought down by the passion of the younger of his pursuers. The name inscribes the reversal of hunter and hunted that the plot performs. It also prepares the question of the next sections, which is the question of Actaeon: what is the punishment for seeing, and who in this film is guilty of the gaze?

4.4

Galeotto fu 'l libro: Francesca, Reading, and Mediated Desire

In the second circle of the *Inferno* the lustful are borne forever upon "*la bufera infernal, che mai non resta*," the infernal hurricane that never rests (*Inf.* V.31), and among them the pilgrim speaks with Francesca da Rimini, murdered together with her lover Paolo, her husband's brother, by the husband who discovered them.

Francesca's account of their fall is the most celebrated speech in the poem, and its climax is a scene of reading. One day, for pleasure, they were reading of Lancelot and how love constrained him; many times the reading drew their eyes together and drained the color from their faces, but one point alone overcame them, when they read how the longed-for smile was kissed by such a lover, and Paolo, trembling, kissed her mouth. "*Galeotto fu 'l libro e chi lo scrisse: / quel giorno più non vi leggemmo avante*"—a Galehaut was the book and he who wrote it; that day we read no further (V.127–138). Galehaut, in the Arthurian romance, was the go-between who brought Lancelot and Guinevere together. The book was the pander. Desire passed from the page to its readers, and the readers enacted what they read.

René Girard made this passage a paradigm of what he called mimetic or mediated desire. In *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961) and in his essay on the mimetic desire of Paolo and Francesca (1978), Girard argued that desire is never spontaneous but always borrowed from a model—a rival, a hero, a book—and that the lovers of Rimini, believing their passion the most personal of experiences, were in fact imitating Lancelot and Guinevere, their desire mediated by a text. The archetype of the mediated subject in the novel is Cervantes's hidalgo, whose brain, his narrator reports, dried up from too much reading of chivalric romance—"*se le secó el celebro*" (*Don Quijote* I.1)—and who rode out to imitate Amadis of Gaul in a world that no longer contained knights. Emma Bovary, poisoned at last by arsenic, had first been poisoned by the novels of her convent girlhood. The great modern novel, on Girard's account, is the slow discovery that the hero's desires are copies.

Doe is a reader whose desire is mediated by books, and his reading is a homicidal Quixotism. His two thousand notebooks, his library loans, his citations of Milton and Shakespeare, his tableaux composed after Dante and Aquinas testify to a self constituted by texts: a man who has read the literature of judgment until his brain dried up and who has ridden out to imitate the justice of God in a city that no longer believes in it. Quixote's imitation of Amadis produces comedy because the world refuses to become a romance; Doe's imitation of Dante produces horror because he forces the world to become a *Commedia*, at the price of its inhabitants' lives. The Bureau's surveillance of library loans, which leads the detectives to his door, rests on the same presupposition as Girard's theory: that desire is mediated by books, and that a man's reading may be the map of what he will do.

The mid-1990s were preoccupied with exactly this presupposition, transposed from the book to the image. On 31 May 1995, less than four months before *Se7en* opened, the Senate majority leader Robert Dole denounced the entertainment industry in a speech in Los Angeles for marketing what he called nightmares of depravity, singling out among other works *Natural Born Killers* (1994) and *True Romance*

(1993); reports of crimes allegedly imitating Oliver Stone's film had become a staple of the press. The controversy repeated, in a new medium, the anxiety Fredric Wertham's *Seduction of the Innocent* (1954) had directed at comic books, and that every age has directed at its Galehauts. *Se7en* intervenes in the debate with a self-awareness that is easily overlooked. In the car on the last day, Mills taunts Doe that he will be forgotten, a television movie of the week, at best a slogan on a T-shirt; Doe replies, in substance, that his work will be studied and followed forever. The exchange is a dispute about the afterlife of the series as image, and both disputants are partly right. The film knows that it is itself a potential Galehaut: that its depiction of Doe's program may become, for some viewer, a model, and that its success may nourish precisely the cult of the ingenious killer that Doe anticipates.

The film's response to this knowledge is, once again, structural rather than rhetorical. A Galehaut transmits desire by completing the scene: the book shows the kiss, and its readers kiss. *Se7en* refuses to complete its scenes. It shows no murder in the act; it gives the tableau of lust only as aftermath and testimony; it ends with a box it will not open. A film that withholds the consummation cannot easily serve as a pander, because the desire it transmits is a desire to see what it has refused to show, and that desire, frustrated, turns back upon the one who feels it. In Francesca's story, the reading stopped at the kiss because the kiss was enacted: *quel giorno più non vi leggemmo avante*. In *Se7en*, the viewing stops before the head because the head must not be seen.

The Christian tradition preserves a second scene of reading that answers Francesca's, and it bears upon the ethics of the film's ending. In the garden at Milan, tormented by a lust he could neither indulge without shame nor renounce without anguish, Augustine heard a child's voice chanting *tolle, lege*, take up and read; he opened the epistles of Paul at random and read the command to walk not in chambering and wantonness but to put on Christ and make no provision for the flesh, and, in the words of the nineteenth-century translation, "all the darkness of doubt vanished away" (*Confessiones* VIII.12.29; Rom. 13:13–14). Francesca's book was a pander; Augustine's was a liberator. Reading, in the Christian imagination, holds both powers: it can mediate the desire that damns or the conversion that saves. Doe reads as Francesca read, toward enactment. Somerset reads as Augustine read, in torment and in search of a word that might release him from the city's darkness. That the film grants him no such word—only a qualified sentence of Hemingway's —is the measure of its honesty about what reading can still accomplish.

4.5

Scopophilia and the Withheld: Mulvey, Powell, and the Spectator's Appetite

Of the three concupiscences named in the First Epistle of John—"the lust of the flesh, and the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life" (1 John 2:16)—the second is the one that concerns the cinema. Augustine devoted to it some of the most penetrating pages of the *Confessions*, naming it *curiositas*, the appetite of the eyes for experience as such, and distinguishing it from the lust of the flesh by its objects: the flesh seeks the beautiful and the pleasant, but curiosity seeks their contraries too, not in order to suffer them but in order to know them. What pleasure is there, he asks, in seeing a mangled corpse that makes one shudder? And yet if one lies nearby, people flock to it, to be saddened and to turn pale (X.35.54–55). Plato had told the story of Leontius, son of Aglaion, who, walking up from the Piraeus, saw corpses lying beside the public executioner, desired to look, struggled with himself and covered his face, and at last, overcome, ran toward them with eyes wide open, crying to them to take their fill, wretches that they were, of the lovely sight (*Republic* IV, 439e–440a). The appetite to look upon the dead is among the oldest objects of moral philosophy's suspicion, and the crime film is its modern institution.



FIG. 12 THE THREE CONCUPISCENCES *The lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life (1 John 2:16). Augustine named the second curiositas, the appetite of the eyes for experience as such: the concupiscence that concerns the cinema.*

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) gave that appetite its cinematic theory. Drawing on Freud's account of *Schaulust*, the pleasure in looking, Mulvey argued that classical cinema organizes vision according to a sexual asymmetry in which woman is image and man the bearer of the look, and that the anxiety the female image provokes is managed by two strategies: fetishistic scopophilia, which overvalues the image and freezes it into spectacle, and voyeurism, which investigates the woman, ascertains her guilt, and punishes or forgives her. Voyeurism, Mulvey observed, has associations with sadism, and "sadism demands a story." The crime film is the narrative form of voyeurism; its investigation is a looking that establishes guilt and administers punishment. Doe's series is voyeurism in Mulvey's exact sense, a sadistic narrative of investigation, judgment, and punishment that requires an audience, and the detective story through which the film presents it is the genre in which voyeurism is most fully institutionalized.

The most lucid cinematic analysis of this structure before *Se7en* was Michael Powell's *Peeping Tom* (1960), whose protagonist, a focus puller at a film studio, murders women with a blade concealed in the leg of his camera's tripod while filming their terror, a mirror mounted on the camera so that they see their own deaths as they die. His father, a scientist of fear, had filmed him as a child in order to study terror, and the son has become the archive's continuation. The camera is a weapon and the gaze a blade. The critical outrage that greeted the film all but ended Powell's career in Britain, as though its audience had recognized in it an accusation. Doe, photographer and archivist, belongs to Powell's lineage: he too fuses camera and blade, and his archive of Victor's decline is the counterpart of the father's films of his son's fear. The fourth tableau literalizes the fusion more brutally still. Its instrument is a blade attached to the organ of desire, as Mark Lewis's was attached to the instrument of vision.

The cinema of the decade before *Se7en* had developed the figure of the investigator as voyeur with particular intensity. In David Lynch's *Blue Velvet* (1986) the young amateur detective hides in a closet and watches through its slats a scene of sexual violence he has no power to stop and no right to see; the scene's enduring discomfort derives from its alignment of the spectator's position with his. Konami's *Silent Hill 2* (2001) would later quote the closet directly, placing its player behind slats to watch an executioner figure assault faceless, mannequin-like creatures, and building its entire narrative of guilt upon what its protagonist's gaze has refused to acknowledge. Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) distinguished in the horror film between an assaultive gaze, identified with the killer, and a reactive gaze, identified with the victim, and argued that the genre invites its male audience, through the figure of the surviving "Final Girl," into a masochistic identification with suffering. *Se7en*

has no Final Girl. The only woman in it who comes to know the full extent of the series is the one whose head is in the box.

Linda Williams, analyzing pornography in *Hard Core* (1989) and the "body genres" of pornography, horror, and melodrama in an essay of 1991, identified in pornography a "frenzy of the visible," a drive toward the maximal visibility of bodily truth. The fourth tableau is the point at which *Se7en*'s relation to that frenzy is decided, and the film decides against it. The act in the Hot House is never shown. The spectator, who has followed the detectives through the red-lit corridors into the room, receives the crime only as aftermath and as the broken testimony of a man in shock. The film supplies the scene's knowledge and withholds its image. In doing so it refuses the pornographic logic of the series itself, which is a logic of display: Doe's tableaux are made to be seen. The film shows Doe's exhibitions, but never the acts that composed them, and at the end it will refuse to show his last exhibit altogether.

The refusal does not absolve the film or its audience. Doe has composed his tableaux for spectators, the film's spectators among them, and the very persistence of the film's reputation testifies to the appetite Augustine described. Michael Haneke's *Funny Games* (1997) would make the spectator's complicity in screen violence its explicit theme, its killers addressing the camera and rewinding the film when their victims gain an advantage. *Se7en* delivers no lecture of that kind. Its strategy is subtler: it feeds the lust of the eyes up to the threshold of the decisive image and then stops, leaving the spectator in the position of Leontius—having run toward the corpses with eyes wide open—only to find that the film has covered them. The punishment for the gaze in *Se7en* is not Actaeon's dismemberment. It is the frustration of the gaze, the compulsion to imagine what one has been forbidden to see, and the discovery, in the act of imagining, that one has become, like Mills, a collaborator in the completion of Doe's work.

4.6

Erotism and Death: Bataille, Sade, and the Logic of Transgression

Georges Bataille opened *L'Érotisme* (1957) with a sentence that became the axiom of a whole tradition: "*De l'érotisme, il est possible de dire qu'il est l'approbation de la vie jusque dans la mort*"—of eroticism it may be said that it is the affirmation of life even unto death. For Bataille, human beings are discontinuous creatures, each enclosed in the solitude of an individual existence, and eroticism, like death and like

religious sacrifice, is the experience of a momentary rupture of that discontinuity, a violence that dissolves the boundaries of the self into a continuity it can neither endure nor renounce. Taboo and transgression belong together: the prohibition exists to be transgressed, and transgression does not abolish the taboo but completes it, so that the sacred is experienced precisely in its violation. The lover, Bataille wrote, dissolves the identity of the beloved no less than the bloody sacrificer that of the human or animal victim. Eroticism and sacrifice share a single structure.

The fourth tableau is a Bataillean scene stripped of every element of Bataille's mysticism. In it the conjunction of eros and death that Bataille regarded as the summit of sovereign experience is converted into a mechanism of punishment, administered by a man who neither participates in it nor, on his own account, delights in it. The device makes the sexual act literally the act of killing; it fuses the two experiences of continuity in a single object and thereby annihilates both. Bataille had contemplated for decades a set of photographs of a man being executed in Beijing in 1905 by the punishment known as *lingchi*, death by slicing, which his analyst had given him in 1925, and he reproduced them at the close of his last book, *Les Larmes d'Éros* (1961), as the image in which ecstasy and horror become indistinguishable. Timothy Brook, Jérôme Bourgon, and Gregory Blue, in *Death by a Thousand Cuts* (2008), subjected that contemplation to a severe historical critique, showing how much of Bataille's ecstasy depended on an exoticized and partly misunderstood image of a real man's suffering. The critique applies, *mutatis mutandis*, to any spectator who finds in Doe's tableaux an aesthetic sublime. Even within the fiction they are composed from human bodies, and their sublimity is the anesthesia of the gaze.

The more exact precedent for Doe lies not in Bataille but in the author Bataille most revered. The Marquis de Sade's *Les Cent Vingt Journées de Sodome*, written in the Bastille in 1785 on a scroll that survived the Revolution, imagines four libertines who retire for a winter to an isolated château and listen to four storytellers recount six hundred passions in strict sequence—a hundred and fifty simple, a hundred and fifty complex, a hundred and fifty criminal, a hundred and fifty murderous—each narrated passion to be enacted upon the captives according to a schedule fixed in the regulations of the house. The work is a serial machine of escalating transgression, its pleasures numbered and its days counted, and its isolation, articulation, ordering, and theatricalization are exactly the operations Barthes identified in the logothete. Doe's series is a Sadean structure inhabited by an anti-Sadean intention. He shares Sade's numerology, his scheduling, his archive, his seclusion, and his theatricality, and he inverts Sade's purpose, punishing the passions Sade's libertines indulge.

The inversion is less complete than it appears, for Sade's libertines and Doe share a virtue. In *Juliette* (1797–1801) and elsewhere, Sade's masters of crime cultivate

apathie, a studied insensibility that enables them to commit any atrocity coldly, without the weakness of passion; Maurice Blanchot, in *Lautréamont et Sade* (1949), described Sadean apathy as the spirit of negation applied to the man who has chosen to be sovereign. And Kant, whose moral philosophy Lacan would famously read as Sade's secret twin in "Kant avec Sade" (1963), had written in the *Metaphysik der Sitten* (1797) that virtue necessarily presupposes apathy, considered as strength —by which he meant the will's freedom from the pathological influence of feeling. Somerset complains that he can no longer live in a city that nurtures apathy as though it were a virtue. The complaint has a terrible double sense. The city's apathy is the indifference of the bystander; but apathy as virtue, in the strict sense that Kant and Sade share, is the cold disposition of a will that executes its law without pathological inclination. That is Doe. He is the city's apathy elevated into a moral principle: the bystander's indifference transfigured into the executioner's composure.

The nexus of Kant and Sade illuminates the end of the series. Kant was the most uncompromising retributivist in the history of philosophy. In the *Rechtslehre* he insisted that even if a civil society were to dissolve itself by the consent of all its members—if the people of an island resolved to separate and disperse throughout the world—the last murderer remaining in prison would first have to be executed, so that each should receive what his deeds deserve and blood-guilt should not cling to the people for having neglected the punishment. This is retribution in its purest form, the zero tolerance of a reason that will not let a single debt go uncollected even at the end of the world. Sade, by contrast, argued in the pamphlet embedded in *La Philosophie dans le boudoir* (1795), "Français, encore un effort si vous voulez être républicains," against capital punishment, on the ground that the law, cold by its very nature, cannot be moved by the passions that may excuse in a human being the cruel act of murder. Kant demands the cold execution of the last murderer; Sade condemns the law's cold killing and excuses the killing done in passion. *Se7en*'s final scene stages exactly this antinomy. Doe, the apathetic executor of the moral law, provokes his own death; Mills, the officer of the law, kills him in passion. The law's agent commits the crime Sade would excuse, and the sovereign of apathy dies at the hands of the passion he despised. The seventh chapter returns to this antinomy. It is announced here, in the tableau in which sex and death are welded together by an instrument and the will of the man who wields it is absent.

Prudentius, once more, supplies the archetype of the self-destroying passion. In the *Psychomachia*, Wrath hurls her weapons against Patience, who stands unmoved; when her sword shatters upon the virtue's helmet, Ira, maddened by her impotence, seizes a javelin from the ground and drives it into her own body. Wrath dies by its own hand. Pride, in the same poem, charging on horseback, falls into a pit dug by Deceit

and is beheaded. The first Christian epic of the vices had already joined, in its gallery of deaths, the two images with which *Se7en* ends: the passion that destroys its bearer, and the severed head.

4.7

The Interrogation Room as Confessional: *Scientia Sexualis* and the Compelled Avowal

The fourth tableau ends not with a corpse but with a confession. The man who wielded the device is questioned in a state of collapse, sweating, weeping, barely coherent, and made to tell what he was made to do. The scene is short and almost unbearable, and its form is ancient: an avowal extracted under pressure, in a closed room, by men whose institutional office is to obtain the truth from a speaking subject, concerning a sexual act the speaker experiences as unspeakable shame. The interrogation room is a confessional.

Michel Foucault argued in the first volume of the *Histoire de la sexualité* that the modern West did not so much repress sex as incite discourse about it, and that the principal technique of that incitement was confession. From the moment the Fourth Lateran Council imposed annual confession upon every Christian of either sex in 1215 (canon 21, *Omnis utriusque sexus*), the penitential manuals elaborated ever more minute protocols for interrogating the penitent about the circumstances, thoughts, and pleasures of the flesh; the Counter-Reformation intensified the scrutiny; and modern medicine, psychiatry, pedagogy, and law inherited the obligation to make sex speak. The West, Foucault argued, had become a society of confession, and it had produced, in place of the *ars erotica* of other civilizations, a *scientia sexualis* whose instrument was the avowal. The police interrogation is one of that science's secular sacraments. Peter Brooks, in *Troubling Confessions* (2000), traced how the law's dependence upon confession inherits the coercive dynamics of the confessional, and how readily the demand for avowal produces avowals that are false, compelled, or self-destroying.

The man of the Hot House confesses to an act he did not will. His avowal produces no absolution, because there is nothing of which he could be absolved; it produces only the disclosure of his violation. The confessional apparatus, which presupposes a guilty subject who speaks the truth of his desire, here receives a subject made guilty by force, whose desire has been turned into a weapon against him and against another. The scene thus exposes the confessional's founding presupposition: that the truth of

a person lies in what his body has done. Doe has engineered a situation in which that presupposition becomes a lie, and the institution that receives the confession has no means of telling the difference.

Doe himself will confess, and his confession will be the inverse of this one. He will walk into the precinct of his own accord, covered in blood, and surrender; he will speak through his lawyer and then, in the car, at length; and on the last day he will confess the one sin he ascribes to himself. His model is not the penitent but Raskolnikov as Porfiry Petrovich imagined him, the criminal who, unable to bear the weight of what he knows, comes at last to the investigator of his own accord. But Raskolnikov's confession, urged on him by Sonya, is the beginning of repentance; Doe's is the final move of his design. Augustine's *Confessiones* joined two senses of the word, the *confessio peccati*, the confession of sin, and the *confessio laudis*, the confession of praise. Doe's confession is neither. It is an accusation disguised as an avowal, a speech in which he confesses the sins of others and, in confessing his own, completes his indictment of the world. Paul de Man, reading Rousseau's *Confessions* in "Excuses" (1979), showed how a confessional text can produce the guilt it confesses for the sake of the pleasure of exposure and the excuse that exposure supplies. Doe's confession of envy is the purest instance in the cinema of a confession that is also an excuse—the excuse, offered in advance, for the act of wrath it is designed to provoke.

Between the two confessions—the forced agent's, truthful and powerless, and Doe's, powerful and false—the film locates the problem of the chapters that follow. A confession presupposes a self that can avow and a listener who can absolve. Doe's series destroys both: it makes selves into instruments and listeners into executioners. The fourth day thus completes the first half of the series' anatomy of the person. The glutton's body has been made to consume itself, the lawyer's to cut itself, Victor's to rot, and the client's to kill. What remains to Doe is the face—the surface on which, in the ethical tradition from which the next chapter draws, the person is not a body at all but an appeal. From the compelled act, the series turns to the compelled choice.

The Fifth Day

Superbia

Pride



The Effaced Face

Pride, Disfigurement, and the Aesthetics of Murder

Thine heart was lifted up because of thy beauty, thou hast corrupted thy wisdom by reason of thy brightness.

— *Ezekiel 28:17*

Sic enim superbia perverse imitatur Deum. [For thus does pride perversely imitate God.]

— *Augustine, De civitate Dei XIX.12*

5.1

Regina Vitiorum: Pride as Root and Throne

Pride is the only capital vice the tradition placed above the others. For Gregory the Great it is not one of the seven but their queen, *regina vitiorum*, who, having captured the heart, hands it over to her seven generals to be laid waste; it is the root of all evil, *radix cuncti mali*, from which the generals spring (*Moralia* XXXI.45.87). Its scriptural warrant is the sentence of Ecclesiasticus that pride is the beginning of all sin (10:15, Vulgate), and its archetype is the fall of the being who said in his heart, "I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God ... I will be like the most High," and was brought down to hell, to the sides of the pit (Isa. 14:12–15). Aquinas defined pride as the inordinate desire of one's own excellence and judged it, in one respect, the gravest of all sins, because where other sins turn away from God through ignorance, weakness, or the desire of some lesser good, pride turns away from God precisely by refusing to be subject to him (*ST* II-II, q. 162, aa. 1, 6). Augustine gave the vice its most penetrating definition —"*Quid est autem superbia nisi perversae celsitudinis appetitus?*," what is pride but a craving for perverse exaltation? (*De civitate Dei* XIV.13)—and identified its form: pride perversely imitates God, for it hates equality with its companions under him and wishes to impose its own dominion upon them in his place (XIX.12).

The scriptural portraits of pride are, strikingly, portraits of beauty. Ezekiel's lament over the king of Tyre, which the tradition read as a figure of the angel's fall, addresses a being "full of wisdom, and perfect in beauty," who walked in Eden among the stones of fire, and explains his ruin in a single verse: "Thine heart was lifted up because of thy beauty, thou hast corrupted thy wisdom by reason of thy brightness" (Ezek. 28:12, 17). The punishment is a public unmaking of the radiant surface: "I will bring thee to ashes upon the earth in the sight of all them that behold thee" (28:18). The name Lucifer, the light-bearer, names the brightness the fall extinguishes. Ovid's Narcissus, who wasted away gazing at his own reflection, fulfilled the prophecy Tiresias gave his mother, that the boy would live to old age if he never came to know himself (*Metamorphoses* III.346–348)—the Delphic command reversed in the key of beauty. And the iconography of pride assigns it the mirror. Spenser's Lucifera, queen of the House of Pride, sits enthroned holding "a mirrhour bright, / Wherein her face she often vewed fayne, / And in her selfe-lov'd semblance tooke delight" (*The Faerie*

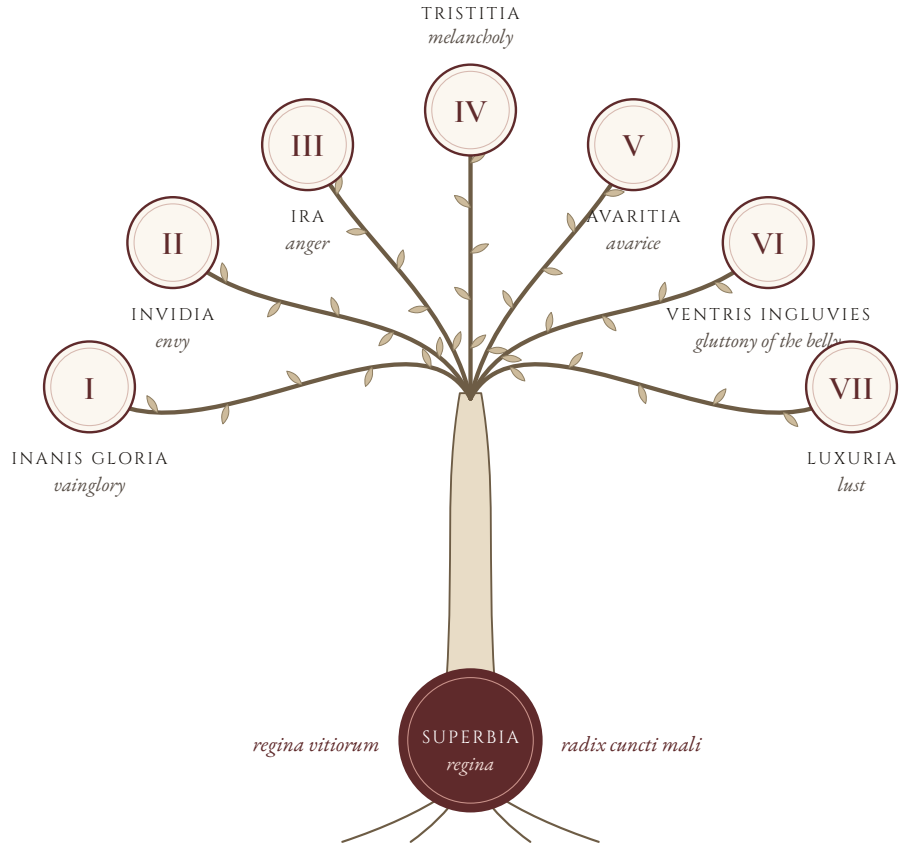


FIG. 13 REGINA VITIORUM *Gregory's ordering in the Moralia (XXXI.45.87): pride, queen and root of all evil, hands the captured heart to seven generals, each followed by an army of daughters.*

Queene I.iv.10); in the tabletop of the sins attributed to Bosch, *Superbia* is a woman admiring herself in a glass held up to her by a demon.

The fifth tableau is staged within this iconographic tradition. Its victim is a young model, a woman whose living was her face. Doe has entered her apartment, cut off her nose, and glued a telephone to one of her hands and a bottle of sleeping pills to the other: she could summon help and live disfigured, or swallow the pills and die. She chose the pills. Doe's verdict, in the car, is that she was so ugly within that she could not bear to go on living if she could not be beautiful without. The tableau thus casts the sin of pride as the pride of the beautiful face, in the line of Ezekiel's Tyre, Ovid's Narcissus, and Spenser's Lucifera: pride figured as a woman before a mirror.

The placement of pride in Doe's sequence repays scrutiny. In Gregory's scheme pride is the root and the first; on Dante's mountain it is purged on the lowest terrace, nearest the gate; in Evagrius and Cassian, who ascend from the belly toward the spirit, it is the last and subtlest, the temptation reserved for those who have overcome all the others. Doe places it fifth, after the sins of the flesh and of possession and before the two sins of the heart that will engulf the detectives and himself. The series climbs from the branches toward the root, and when it reaches the root it finds that the root is not where it has been looking. The pride the fifth tableau punishes is the model's; the pride that composed the tableau is Doe's. The scene in which he punishes pride is the scene in which his own pride is most nakedly displayed—the presumption of a man who arrogates to himself the right to judge the soul behind a face and to rewrite the face accordingly.

Dante's terrace of the proud makes this reflexivity explicit, because it is the terrace of art. The penitents, bent double beneath enormous stones, pass along a cliff carved with examples of humility so lifelike they seem to speak—the Annunciation, David dancing before the Ark, Trajan halting his legions to do justice to a widow—which Dante calls *visibile parlare*, visible speech, the art of God himself (*Purg.* X.95). Beneath their feet the pavement is carved with examples of pride brought low: Lucifer falling like lightning from heaven, Nimrod at the foot of his tower, Niobe among her slaughtered children, Arachne half turned to a spider, and the Assyrians in flight after the death of Holofernes, among the remains of the slaughter (XII.25–63). Among the penitents Dante meets Oderisi da Gubbio, the illuminator of manuscripts, who renounces his pride in his art and meditates on the vanity of fame: Cimabue thought he held the field in painting, and now Giotto has the cry; worldly renown is nothing but a breath of wind (XI.79–102). On the terrace where pride is purged, Dante confronts the pride of the artist, and the only perfect art is God's.

Doe's tableaux are a parody of the *visibile parlare*: human compositions that presume to speak with the authority of divine judgment, exempla carved not in marble but in the flesh of the living. The fifth tableau is the point at which the parody becomes most transparent, because it is the one in which Doe assumes the role not only of judge but of sculptor, reshaping a face according to his conception of the soul behind it. In the tradition, the proud man imitates God perversely. In *Se7en*, the proud man imitates God's art.

5.2

The Effaced Face: Levinas and the Mutilated Visage

Of all the parts of the body, the face is the one in which the person is most present and least possessable. Emmanuel Levinas made this the foundation of his ethics. In *Totalité et Infini* (1961), the face of the other, *le visage*, is not an object among objects, not a plastic form to be perceived, but the way in which the other presents himself, exceeding every idea of him that I might form. It does not offer itself to vision as a thing; it speaks, and its first word, in Levinas's account, is a prohibition: thou shalt not kill. The face is at once the most naked and defenseless of surfaces, exposed to every violence, and the site of a resistance that is not a force but an appeal—a resistance that consists in the fact that murder, which can destroy the face, can never possess it. The other, Levinas wrote, is the only being I can wish to kill, and the face is what forbids it.

The fifth tableau is an assault upon the face in precisely Levinas's sense. Doe does not kill the model directly. He disfigures her, and he does so in the name of a theory of the face that is the antithesis of Levinas's: the face, for Doe, is a surface that lies, an image concealing an ugly interior, whose truth can be restored only by mutilation. He treats the face as what Levinas called plastic form, the countenance as appearance, and he punishes it as an idol. There is a terrible logic in the choice of victim. A fashion model is a woman whose face has already been converted into an image, a commodity reproduced and sold; the economy of the 1990s, in which the faces of the celebrated models of the day were among the most valuable images in circulation, had already performed the operation Levinas warned against, freezing the face into a likeness. Levinas's early essay "La réalité et son ombre" (1948) had accused the artistic image itself of this freezing, of arresting the living face in the immobility of a statue and substituting a shadow for an expression. Doe completes the economy's work by destroying the image—and in destroying the image he reaches the face, the person, who cannot survive it.

The history of punitive disfigurement gives the act its juridical genealogy. Byzantine law made the slitting or amputation of the nose, *rhinokopia*, a penalty for adultery and other offenses in the *Ecloga* promulgated under Leo III in 726, and an instrument of political disqualification. The emperor Justinian II, deposed in 695, had his nose cut off so that his mutilated face would bar him from the throne, the imperial body being required to be whole; he returned to rule a decade later, reportedly wearing a nose of gold, and has been known ever since as *Rhinotmetos*, the slit-nosed. The disfigured face was a public sign of infamy, the loss of honor written upon the organ of honor; in many languages one still loses face. The surgical art

that would become a profession of beauty was born in part from the repair of such punishments: the ancient Indian treatise attributed to Sushruta described the reconstruction of amputated noses with a flap of skin from the forehead, a technique that reached European surgeons at the end of the eighteenth century. Doe's mutilation of the model belongs to the oldest stratum of this history. It is *rhinokopia*, the penal disfigurement that marks a body as infamous, applied to a woman whose crime is her beauty.

Hagiography preserves the inverse case. According to the legend recorded by the thirteenth-century chronicler Roger of Wendover, Æbbe the Younger, abbess of Coldingham, cut off her own nose and upper lip as Viking raiders approached in the later ninth century and persuaded her nuns to do the same, so that their disfigurement would preserve their chastity; the raiders, repelled, burned the convent with the women inside. The saint mutilates her face to protect her soul; Doe mutilates a face to expose the soul he imputes to it. The proverbial phrase for self-defeating spite—to cut off one's nose to spite one's face—is one more dead metaphor in Doe's lexicon, remotivated in flesh.

Cinema had confronted the effaced face before *Se7en*. Georges Franju's *Les Yeux sans visage* (1960) concerns a surgeon who, having disfigured his daughter in an accident he caused, abducts young women and removes their faces in an attempt to graft them onto hers, while she drifts through his house behind an expressionless white mask; the surgeon's pride in his power to remake a face is the engine of the horror, and the film ends with the daughter freeing the animals he has caged and walking out into the night. Hiroshi Teshigahara's *Tanin no kao* (*The Face of Another*, 1966), adapted from Kōbō Abe's novel, follows a man whose face has been burned away and who, behind a perfect mask, becomes a stranger to himself and a danger to others. David Lynch's *The Elephant Man* (1980) turns on the cry of a man whose face had made him an exhibit, protesting before a mob that he is a human being and not an animal. In each, the face that cannot be seen or cannot be borne becomes the test of a community's humanity. *Se7en* reverses the test. It shows the aftermath of a face destroyed and asks whether the destruction has revealed anything at all.

The deepest consequence of the fifth tableau lies at the end of the film. The last face in the series is Tracy's, and it is the one the film refuses to show. Every other victim has been exhibited—as aftermath, as photograph, as tableau—and the exhibition has been, in each case, the completion of Doe's design. The face in the box is the only one withheld. If the face, in Levinas's terms, is what can be destroyed but never possessed, then the film's refusal to show it is a refusal to let Doe possess it as an image. The killer has severed the head; the film will not let him have the face. The box is totality in Levinas's sense—the closed container, the system that would enclose everything—

and the face it holds is infinity, the exteriority no totality can contain. The fifth day prepares the seventh. It shows what Doe does to a face he is permitted to display, so that we may understand what the film is doing when it refuses to display the last one.

5.3

The Forced Choice: Pills, Telephone, and the Lacanian *Vel*

The fifth tableau is constructed as a choice. A telephone in one hand, a bottle of pills in the other: life disfigured, or death. The form is the most consistent device of Doe's series, and the fifth day displays it in its purest state. The lawyer was offered the choice of cutting his flesh or dying; the man of the Hot House, of using the device or being shot; the model, of calling for help or swallowing the pills; and at the end Mills will be offered, in effect, the choice of killing Doe or letting him live. Doe's justice is administered through ultimatums, and his verdicts are pronounced upon the choices he compels.

The most solemn forced choice in the scriptural tradition comes with an injunction. "I call heaven and earth to record this day against you," Moses tells Israel at the close of Deuteronomy, "that I have set before you life and death, blessing and cursing: therefore choose life" (Deut. 30:19). God sets the alternatives before his people and tells them which to choose. Doe sets life and death before the model and attaches no injunction—or rather, his injunction is implicit in the structure of the alternatives, which make life the more terrible option. He has arranged a choice in which life is purchased at the price of the face, and then he reads her choice of death as the revelation of her pride. The test is rigged. Its outcome confirms the verdict because the verdict determined its terms.

Jacques Lacan gave the structure its psychoanalytic formula in his seminar of 1964, under the name of the *vel* of alienation, the "or" of a forced choice. Your money or your life: if I choose the money, I lose both; if I choose life, I have life deprived of money, a life curtailed. Lacan added a second formula with a darker logic. Freedom or death: here, if one chooses freedom, one has only the freedom to die, for the only proof of freedom on offer is the choice of death. The model's alternatives have exactly this structure. If she chooses life, she has a life without the face that was her identity and her livelihood; if she chooses the freedom to refuse that life, she has only the freedom to die. Doe has placed her in the position Lacan described, and he presents

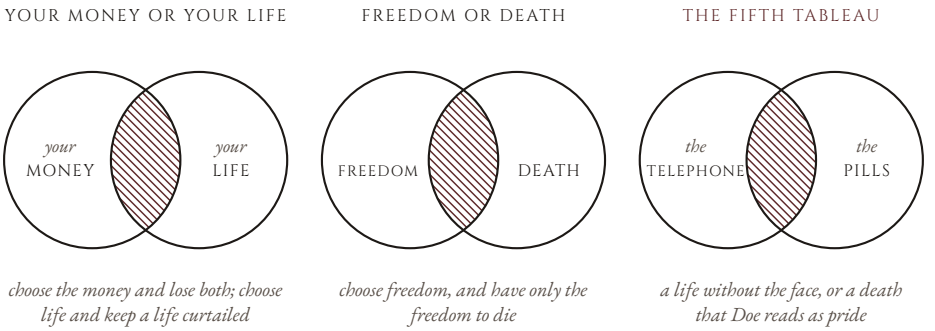


FIG. 14 THE FORCED CHOICE *Lacan's vel of alienation in its two formulas, and the alternative of the fifth day. In each, the structure of the alternatives speaks through the one who chooses.*

her choice of death as the expression of her character, when it is in fact the structure of the alternatives speaking through her.

Hegel's account of the struggle for recognition in the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) supplies the dialectic Doe's test presupposes. Self-consciousness, in Hegel's narrative, proves itself by staking its life in a struggle for recognition; the one who prefers death to the loss of independence becomes master, while the one who clings to life and accepts subjection becomes bondsman. Doe forces the model into this struggle and judges her by its outcome. She chooses as the master chooses, preferring death to a life of disfigured dependence, and Doe calls this pride. But in Hegel's dialectic the master's victory is hollow and the bondsman's subjection the beginning of freedom; the truth of the struggle lies not with the one who risked death but with the one who endured. The film offers, at its end, a figure who endures. Somerset chooses the diminished life of remaining in the city over the clean escape of departure. The forced choice of the fifth day is answered, two days later, by a choice that is not forced.

The model's death recalls one of the founding narratives of Roman virtue and one of the most searching critiques of it. Lucretia, violated by the son of the last king of Rome, killed herself rather than live dishonored, and her death was celebrated as the origin of the Republic. Augustine, writing the *City of God* after the sack of Rome, refused the celebration. Either Lucretia consented to the violation, he argued, in which case she was not innocent; or she did not, in which case her suicide was the killing of an innocent woman. He traced her act to the Roman hunger for glory: a woman too eager for praise feared that her silent endurance might be taken for consent (*De civitate Dei* I.19). Augustine's critique is aimed at the honor culture in

which a disfigured or dishonored life is held to be worse than death. Doe's verdict on the model belongs to that culture; he judges her by its standard while condemning her for having held it. He assumes that she, like Lucretia, would prefer death to disgrace, and then he names that preference pride.

The forced choice is the form in which the hebdomadal machine simulates freedom. Each of Doe's victims is permitted a decision, and the decision is used to transfer the guilt of the act from the executioner to the executed. The glutton ate; the lawyer cut; the model swallowed. The device anticipates its last and most perfect application. On the seventh day Doe will place before Mills an alternative—to kill him or to let him live—in which, unlike all the others, both options are genuinely open. Mills is not held at gunpoint; he holds the gun. His is the only free choice in the series, and that is why it is the gravest. The fifth tableau teaches the spectator how to read the ending: as the moment at which the series, having simulated freedom six times, depends at last upon a freedom it cannot simulate.

5.4

Dorian Inverted: Making the Surface Confess the Soul

Doe's justification of the fifth murder states a theory of the relation between surface and depth: the model's face was beautiful and her soul was ugly, and the mutilation corrected the discrepancy. The theory has a literary archetype. In Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890; revised 1891), a beautiful young man remains unchanged while his portrait, hidden in a locked room, records every cruelty and debauch in the ravages of its painted face. The portrait is the soul made visible, and the young man's beauty is a lie the portrait exposes. When Dorian at last stabs the canvas, his servants find upon the wall a portrait of their master "in all the wonder of his exquisite youth and beauty," and on the floor a dead man, "withered, wrinkled, and loathsome of visage." Surface and depth exchange places; the face becomes, at the moment of death, what the soul has been.

Doe performs Dorian's ending by force. He does not wait for death to make the face confess the soul; he cuts the confession into it. He is, in this sense, the portrait's justice executed by a human hand, the agent who makes the outside match the inside and ensures that no beauty conceals corruption. The doctrine he enforces is physiognomy. Johann Caspar Lavater's *Physiognomische Fragmente* (1775–78) taught Europe to read character in the face; Cesare Lombroso's *L'uomo delinquente* (1876)

claimed to find the born criminal's atavism in the shape of his skull and jaw; Francis Galton superimposed the photographs of convicts to produce composite portraits of a criminal type. The nineteenth century wanted the face to be legible as the record of the soul. Doe is a physiognomist who has discovered that faces do not reliably confess, and who has resolved to make them. His art is a coercive physiognomy: the manufacture of the correspondence between surface and depth that physiognomy had merely presupposed.

The classical tradition knew the opposite discrepancy and honored it. In Plato's *Symposium*, Alcibiades compares Socrates to the figures of Silenus sold in the statuaries' shops, grotesque little satyrs that open to reveal images of the gods within: so Socrates, snub-nosed and ugly, holds within him wisdom and divine beauty (215a–b). Erasmus made the image the subject of one of the most celebrated essays of his *Adagia*, "Sileni Alcibiadis" (1515), in which Christ, the apostles, and the saints are Sileni, lowly without and divine within, while worldly princes and prelates are inverted Sileni, splendid without and corrupt within; and Rabelais opened *Gargantua* (1534) by likening his book to the apothecaries' boxes called sileni, painted outside with frivolous figures but holding precious drugs. Doe's moral theory is the Erasmian critique of the inverted Silenus—the splendid exterior concealing inner corruption—converted into a program of punishment. He sees the model as an inverted Silenus and destroys her surface to expose the corruption he presumes it hides.

The Silenus reaches forward to the end of the film, and its implication there is decisive. The last object of the series is a box, plain and brown, an ordinary parcel delivered by an ordinary courier. Its exterior is as humble as any Silenus; its contents are the head of the one victim in the series whom Doe cannot accuse of any sin. Tracy has done nothing; she is guilty only of being loved. The final box is therefore a true Silenus in Alcibiades's sense: a mean exterior enclosing the one innocence in the film. Doe intended it as the last exhibit in his gallery of guilt. The film, by refusing to open it, preserves it as what it is, the container of a face that no theory of surface and depth can convict.

Two tales by American Romantics anticipate the fate of a woman whose face becomes the canvas of a man's theory. In Nathaniel Hawthorne's "The Birth-Mark" (1843), a scientist becomes obsessed with the small hand-shaped mark on his beautiful wife's cheek, the single flaw in her perfection; he devises a draught that removes it, and she dies as it fades. The husband's pride in his science, his refusal to tolerate imperfection, kills the woman he loves. In Edgar Allan Poe's "The Oval Portrait" (1845), a painter so absorbed in a likeness of his young wife that he does not see her fading as he works completes the portrait, exclaims that it is life itself, and turns to find her dead. In both tales a woman is consumed by the artwork or the theory that

a man's pride makes of her face. Doe stands at the end of this line. The model—the word is exact—is consumed by his artwork, and Tracy, with whom he will claim to have tried to play the husband, will be consumed by the last.

The physiognomic theory has one further implication, which the film turns against its author. If the face must be made to confess the soul, Doe's own face should confess his. It does not. Kevin Spacey's Doe, when he finally appears, has an ordinary, mild, almost gentle face, a face that confesses nothing; he is the true inverted Silenus of the film, the one figure whose surface is most thoroughly at odds with what he has done. The man who mutilated a face to make it tell the truth wears a face that tells nothing. Physiognomy fails at its own author, and the failure is the film's rebuttal of his theory: the soul is not legible on the surface, and the attempt to make it so is itself the corruption it claims to expose.

5.5

Murder as a Fine Art: De Quincey, Hirst, Quinn, Witkin, Serrano

Doe insists that his work will be studied forever, and the claim is an aesthetic one. He regards his tableaux not merely as punishments but as compositions, works whose formal perfection guarantees their survival. The claim places him in a tradition that begins, in its modern form, with Thomas De Quincey's "On Murder Considered as One of the Fine Arts," published in *Blackwood's Magazine* in 1827 and followed by a supplementary paper in 1839 and a postscript in 1854. De Quincey's speaker, addressing a society of connoisseurs in murder, observes that everything in this world has two handles: murder may be laid hold of by its moral handle, as it generally is in the pulpit, or it may be "treated aesthetically, as the Germans call it, that is, in relation to good taste." The essays are satire, but they inaugurated a discourse in which the killer is judged as an artist and the murder as a composition—a discourse that runs through Wilde's essay on the painter and poisoner Thomas Griffiths Wainewright, "Pen, Pencil and Poison" (1889), with its provocation that the fact of a man's being a poisoner is nothing against his prose, and that Joel Black anatomized in *The Aesthetics of Murder* (1991).

De Quincey's second paper contains a joke that bears with uncanny exactness upon the theology of zero tolerance. "For if once a man indulges himself in murder," the speaker warns, "very soon he comes to think little of robbing; and from robbing he comes next to drinking and Sabbath-breaking, and from that to incivility and

procrastination." Once begun upon this downward path, he adds, one never knows where one is to stop. The joke inverts the moralist's slippery slope: it descends from the gravest crime to the smallest lapse, from murder to procrastination—from wrath, as it were, to sloth. Broken-windows theory runs the slope in the other direction, from the jumped turnstile to the homicide, and Doe's theology runs it in both directions at once, treating the smallest sin as the seed of catastrophe and punishing it with the gravest violence. De Quincey's satire exposes the absurdity of a moral imagination incapable of distinguishing scale. Doe's series is that imagination taken at its word.

The art world of the years in which *Se7en* was conceived had made the aestheticization of death its central provocation. In London in 1990 Damien Hirst exhibited *A Thousand Years*, a glass vitrine in which flies hatched, fed upon a rotting cow's head, and died against an electric insect-killer, the cycle of life and death sealed in a box; the following year he suspended a tiger shark in formaldehyde under the title *The Physical Impossibility of Death in the Mind of Someone Living*. In 1991 Marc Quinn made *Self*, a cast of his own head filled with several liters of his own blood and kept frozen in a refrigerated case. A severed head in a box, a head of blood in a refrigerated cabinet: the decisive image of *Se7en* had been, in the years immediately preceding it, among the signature objects of contemporary art. In New York, Andres Serrano photographed corpses in a morgue for the series *The Morgue* (1992), titling each image with its cause of death, while his *Piss Christ* (1987) and the photographs of Robert Mapplethorpe stood at the center of a national controversy, in 1989 and 1990, over the public funding of art held to blaspheme or disgust; the Cincinnati gallery that exhibited Mapplethorpe was prosecuted for obscenity. Joel-Peter Witkin composed baroque photographic tableaux from cadavers and fragments of bodies, among them a severed head divided and arranged so that it kisses itself. The French artist ORLAN, in *The Reincarnation of Saint-ORLAN* (1990–93), submitted her face to a series of surgical operations performed as public art, remodeling it after features drawn from canonical paintings; the seventh, *Omnipresence*, performed in New York in 1993, was transmitted live to galleries abroad. The face cut open as a work of art, the morgue photographed as a gallery, the head sealed in a vitrine: Doe's tableaux are recognizably the work of a contemporary of these artists.

The convergence is not an accident of iconography; it reflects a shared problem. The art of the period sought to recover through the shock of the abject an experience of the real that the image economy had hollowed out—the condition Simmel had diagnosed as the gray of the blasé and Debord as the spectacle. Viennese Actionism had pursued the same end in the 1960s with Hermann Nitsch's ritual dramas of blood and slaughtered animals, and Chris Burden had himself shot in the arm in a gallery in 1971. Doe pursues it with victims. His tableaux are installations whose material is the

human body and whose purpose, like that of the shock art of his moment, is to break through the anesthesia of the spectator. That he is a murderer does not distinguish his aesthetic from theirs; it distinguishes his ethics. The film knows this, and it is careful never to let his compositions be seen as he meant them to be seen. We encounter them in the aftermath of their discovery, partially, often by flashlight, in the clinical light of investigation, never as the finished exhibitions they were designed to be.

The culture wars of the period joined the moralist and the censor of art in a single figure, and the junction sharpens the reading of Doe. The mayor who institutionalized zero tolerance in New York, Rudolph Giuliani, attempted in 1999 to withdraw the city's funding from the Brooklyn Museum over its exhibition *Sensation*, which included a painting of the Virgin Mary adorned with elephant dung. The theologian of zero tolerance and the prosecutor of blasphemous art belong to the same moral economy: both treat images as acts, and both hold that the offense of an image must be punished. Doe unites the two positions in a single person, the moralist who punishes and the artist who shocks, and the union is the source of his power. He is at once the censor who would cleanse the city of its sins and the transgressive artist who turns those sins into spectacle. The fifth tableau, in which he remodels a face as ORLAN remodeled her own and exhibits a body as Serrano photographed the dead, is the point at which the two figures become indistinguishable.

5.6

The Signature: Kyle Cooper's Titles and the Killer as Co-Author

Every work of art bears a signature, and *Se7en* bears two. The first is the director's: the visual grammar of desaturation, darkness, and forensic precision that has made the film one of the most recognizable of its decade. The second is the killer's, and the film places it first. Kyle Cooper's title sequence, cut to a remix of Nine Inch Nails' "Closer" by the group Coil, opens the film not with an establishing shot but with Doe's workshop: hands razoring the skin from fingertips, stitching and binding notebooks, cutting out words and photographs, developing negatives, striking through lines of handwriting, while the credits flicker in letters scratched directly onto the film. The names of the film's makers are inscribed in the killer's hand. Before we have seen a single image of the city, we have been shown the city's author at work, and his work has been presented as the film's own credits.

The sequence was recognized at once as a landmark of title design, and its influence on the graphic culture of the following decade was enormous. It belongs to a moment in which typography itself was being deconstructed: David Carson's work for the magazine *Ray Gun* and his book *The End of Print* (1995) cultivated a jittery, layered, damaged letterform whose disorder signified authenticity. Cooper's titles adapt that idiom to a precise narrative function. The damage to the letters is the damage of Doe's obsession; the stutter of the frames is the tremor of his hand. The film's paratext is thus its first tableau, a portrait of the artist as a murderer, and it establishes from the outset the rivalry of authorship the film will play out.

In the vocabulary of behavioral profiling that the Bureau's investigators were popularizing in the years of the film—John Douglas and Mark Olshaker's *Mindhunter* appeared in 1995—an offender's signature is distinguished from his *modus operandi*. The method changes as the offender learns; the signature, the ritual element that exceeds what the crime requires and expresses the offender's need, remains constant. Doe's signature is the word: the name of the sin written at each scene, the epigraph left for the reader. It is a literary signature, and it identifies him as an author rather than merely as a killer. Jacques Derrida observed in "Signature Événement Contexte" (1972) that a signature, to function at all, must be repeatable—iterable, detachable from the singular occasion of its inscription—and that this iterability is the condition both of its authority and of its forgery. Doe's signature is iterable in exactly this sense, and the second day showed him forging another's: he signed the plea behind the painting with Victor's fingerprints, the most singular of all signatures, detached from the body that produced them. The man without fingerprints writes his name everywhere and leaves his marks nowhere.

The withholding of Kevin Spacey's name from the opening credits extends this rivalry of signatures into the film's own paratext. The actor who plays the author of the series is deprived of his signature on the film, so that his appearance, when it comes, has the force of an anonymous signature suddenly given a face. The film borrows Doe's anonymity to produce its effect. In the opening titles the killer's hand signs the film; in the billing, the killer's name is erased from it. The film is authored by Doe and authored against him, and the tension between these two relations is the tension of its whole design.

The tableau of pride is the point at which the rivalry becomes explicit. Doe's pride is the author's pride: the conviction that his work is a masterpiece whose meaning will outlast him, that his signature will be studied when the names of his victims are forgotten. The film's counter-signature, its refusal to complete his last composition, is its answer to that pride. The killer signs the credits; the director withholds the head.

Each claims the last word, and the film's structure—an author's series interrupted by a refusal—is the record of their contest.

5.7

Perversa Imitatio Dei: The Author's Pride and the Auteur's Control

Augustine's formula—pride perversely imitates God, hating equality with others under him and wishing to impose its own dominion in his place—is the definition of Doe. He does not reject God; he replaces him. He takes upon himself the divine prerogatives of judgment and punishment, the knowledge of hearts, the power of life and death, and the authorship of a cosmos in which every element signifies. His pride is not vanity but usurpation, the claim, in Isaiah's words, to be like the Most High. And because he imitates a God who creates by speaking, his usurpation takes the form of authorship. He writes the city as God wrote the world, in seven days, with a word for each.

Pride's deepest claim, in the tradition, is the denial of origin. The proud being refuses to acknowledge that it is created, indebted, derived. Milton's Satan, challenged by the loyal seraph Abdiel, denies that the angels were made by God at all: "We know no time when we were not as now; / Know none before us, self-begot, self-rais'd / By our own quick'ning power" (*Paradise Lost* V.859–861). In the pageant of the sins in Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus*, Pride introduces himself with the boast that he disdains to have any parents. Doe has made himself self-begotten in exactly this sense. He has no name, no history, no fingerprints, no traceable past; the investigators find no record of his origin. He has erased every mark of derivation and presented himself as the pure source of his work. Baudelaire's eighth old man, the loathsome Phoenix, son and father of himself, is the emblem of this pride: the being that begets itself in an endless series.

The author within the film reflects upon the author of the film. Doe is a director: he chooses his performers, composes his scenes, times their discovery, writes their texts, and, on the seventh day, directs the performance of the detective who will complete them. *Se7en* is in part an allegory of its own mode of production, and of the auteur's pride that its director's later reputation for exacting control would make proverbial. The auteur theory proclaimed by the critics of the *Cahiers du cinéma* in the 1950s, and brought into American criticism by Andrew Sarris's "Notes on the Auteur Theory in 1962," held that a film is the expression of a single directing

intelligence; Doe is the auteur theory's nightmare, an author who controls everything and whose control is indistinguishable from murder. William Blake, reading Milton, remarked that Milton wrote in fetters when he wrote of angels and God and at liberty when he wrote of devils and hell, because he was a true poet and of the Devil's party without knowing it (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, c. 1790–93). Every reader of *Se7en* must ask whether its makers are of Doe's party. The reactionary reading of the film answers that they are. This dissertation argues that the film's refusals, above all its refusal to complete the last tableau, are the marks of authors who know the temptation and resist it.

The structure of the ending gives that resistance its precise form, and the form has a famous theoretical name. Roland Barthes concluded "La mort de l'auteur" (1967) with the claim that the birth of the reader must be at the cost of the death of the Author. In the last scene of *Se7en*, the author of the series dies so that a reader may complete his text. Doe offers himself to Mills's gun because his work requires a reader to supply its final term, and the reader, in supplying it, is born as the last figure of the series—born, that is, as wrath. Barthes's liberation of the reader becomes, in Doe's design, the reader's damnation: the author dies, the reader completes, and the completion destroys him. Somerset is the second reader, the one who refuses to complete; his is the reading of the eighth day, which leaves the text open. Michel Foucault, in "Qu'est-ce qu'un auteur?" (1969), described the author's name as a function that classifies and unifies a body of texts and limits the proliferation of their meanings. "John Doe" is an author-function without an author, a name that unifies a series while designating no one, the purest instance of Foucault's thesis that the author is a function of discourse rather than a person.

Doe's pride has, finally, an object: fame. His confidence that his work will be puzzled over, studied, and followed forever is the artist's pride that Dante's Oderisi renounces on the terrace of the proud. Worldly renown, Oderisi tells the pilgrim, is nothing but a breath of wind that blows now this way and now that and changes its name as it changes its quarter; Cimabue thought he held the field, and now Giotto has the cry. Mills's taunt in the car—that Doe will be a television movie, a slogan on a shirt, and then forgotten—is Oderisi's lesson delivered in the idiom of the 1990s. And yet the critic must confront an uncomfortable fact. Doe was, in one respect, right. His work, which is to say the film's, has been studied for three decades, and this dissertation is among the studies. The scholarship on *Se7en* fulfills Doe's prophecy in the very act of analyzing it. The only defense against that complicity is the one this dissertation adopted from the outset: to read Doe's text against its grain, attending not to what it proclaims but to what it cannot contain.

Pride, in the scholastic genealogy, is the mother of the vices that follow it. Gregory traced the descent: the first offspring of pride is vainglory, and vainglory, once it has corrupted the mind, at once begets envy (*Moralia* XXXI.45.89). Augustine described the devil who tempted Eve as proud and therefore envious (*De civitate Dei* XIV.11). The fifth day has shown the pride of the author who presumes to remake a face. The sixth will show the envy that pride begets: the envy of the self-begotten man for those who possess what he cannot make—a home, a wife, a child, a life that is given rather than authored.

The Sixth Day

Invidia

Envy



The Serpent in the Apartment

Envy, Mimesis, and the Gift of Death

Nevertheless through envy of the devil came death into the world.

— *Wisdom of Solomon 2:24*

And it came to pass, when they were in the field, that Cain rose up against Abel his brother, and slew him.

— *Genesis 4:8*

6.1

In-videre: Envy as the Optical Sin

The sixth sin is the only one Doe claims as his own. On the last day, in the field beneath the pylons, with the box opened and Somerset running back from it, Doe explains himself to Mills. He envied the detective's ordinary life; he visited the apartment that morning and tried to play the husband, to taste the life of a simple man; it did not work out, and so he took a souvenir, her head. Envy, he concludes, is his sin. The confession completes the sixth term of the series and solicits the seventh. It is also the only moment in the film at which Doe names a passion of his own, and the passion he names is the one the tradition regarded as the most purely diabolical.

"Through envy of the devil came death into the world," declares the Wisdom of Solomon (2:24), and the verse made envy, for patristic and scholastic theology, the sin of Satan and the origin of mortality itself. Augustine described the angel who tempted Eve as proud and therefore envious (*De civitate Dei* XIV.11). Aquinas defined envy as sorrow at another's good insofar as that good is reckoned to diminish one's own excellence, judged it a mortal sin in its genus because it is contrary to charity, which rejoices in the neighbor's good, and adopted from Gregory the catalogue of its daughters: hatred, whispering, detraction, exultation at the neighbor's adversity, and affliction at his prosperity (*ST* II-II, q. 36, aa. 1, 3, 4). Of all the vices, envy is the one that takes no pleasure even in its own object. The glutton enjoys his food and the lustful man his pleasure; the envious man enjoys nothing, for his only satisfaction is the destruction of what he cannot have. The Gospels attribute the Passion itself to it: Pilate, Matthew records, "knew that for envy they had delivered him" (Matt. 27:18).

The Latin name of the sin defines it as a mode of vision. *Invidia* derives from *invidere*, to look upon with hostility, to cast the eye against; it is the evil eye, the *fascinum* of Roman superstition and the *baskania* of the Greeks, the malignant gaze believed to wither whatever it rests upon. Plutarch devoted one of his *Table Talks* to those said to cast the evil eye and explained the phenomenon as an emanation of envy through the eyes (*Quaestiones convivales* V.7). Ovid's personification of Envy in the *Metamorphoses* (II.760–832) lives in a sunless valley, feeds on the flesh of vipers, never smiles except at another's grief, never sleeps, and never looks straight—*nusquam recta acies*. Spenser's Envy, riding a ravenous wolf in the procession of the House of Pride,

chews a venomous toad, wears a kirtle "ypainted full of eyes," and hides in his bosom a hateful snake (*The Faerie Queene* I.iv.30–32). Giotto's *Invidia* in the Arena Chapel at Padua (c. 1305) stands in flames clutching a purse, while a serpent issues from her mouth and coils back to strike at her own eyes. The iconography is constant across fifteen centuries: envy is an eye, sleepless and oblique, accompanied by a serpent, and its venom returns upon itself.

Dante made the optical nature of envy the principle of its purgation. On the second terrace of the mountain the envious sit huddled against the rock in haircloth the color of stone, leaning upon one another like blind beggars at a church door, and their eyelids are sewn shut with iron wire, "as is done to the wild sparrowhawk because it will not stay still" (*Purg.* XIII.70–72). Those who looked upon others' good with a malignant eye are deprived of sight altogether. Among them Dante meets Sapìa of Siena, who confesses that she rejoiced more in others' harm than in her own good fortune, and that she prayed for the defeat of her own city's army and exulted when it came (XIII.106–129). The envious soul is the one that wished for the ruin of its own city. Sapìa is Doe's patron saint.

The optical definition of envy illuminates Doe's methods with unexpected precision. He is a watcher. He photographs his victims and his pursuers; he observed Victor every day for a year; he moved among the press at one of the scenes and took Mills's picture; he followed the detective's life closely enough to know where he lived and when his wife would be alone. His surveillance, which the third chapter read through the eye of the state and the eye of the archive, is here revealed in its affective truth. It is the gaze of envy, the evil eye that looks upon another's good in order to destroy it. Ovid's Invidia never sleeps; Spenser's is painted full of eyes. Doe, who watched the city for years and recorded it in two thousand notebooks, is their heir.

Nietzsche supplied the modern psychology of this gaze. The man of *ressentiment*, he wrote in the first essay of the *Genealogie der Moral*, is neither upright nor naïve nor honest and straightforward with himself: his soul squints—*seine Seele schielt* (I.10). The slave revolt in morality begins, Nietzsche argued, when *ressentiment* itself becomes creative and gives birth to values, when the impotent, unable to act, take an imaginary revenge by declaring the strong and the happy to be evil. Doe's moral system is the revenge of a squinting soul. The man who condemns the city's gluttony, greed, sloth, lust, and pride proves to have been moved, in the end, by the sorrow of one who cannot have an ordinary life—a wife, a home, a child—and who has declared the city damned because it possesses what he cannot. Kierkegaard defined envy as admiration that conceals itself, the admiration of one who cannot bear to surrender to what he admires. Doe's confession lifts the concealment. The theologian of the city's sins was, all along, its unacknowledged admirer.

6.2

"Sight Hateful": Satan in Eden and Doe in the Apartment

The archetype of Doe's envy is the archetype of envy itself, and the film's Miltonic intertext supplies it with exactness. In the fourth book of *Paradise Lost*, Satan, having made the hard journey out of Hell that his speech in the council announced, arrives in Eden and sits like a cormorant upon the Tree of Life. From there he sees the human pair for the first time, and his first words are a cry of pain: "O Hell! what doe mine eyes with grief behold" (IV.358). He addresses them, unheard, with an irony that is also a confession. He seeks league with them, he says, and mutual amity so close "That I with you must dwell, or you with me / Henceforth," and Hell shall unfold its widest gates to entertain them (IV.375–382). Later, watching them embrace, he turns aside "For envie, yet with jealous leer maligne / Ey'd them askance" (IV.503–504), and breaks out: "Sight hateful, sight tormenting! thus these two / Imparadis't in one anothers arms / The happier Eden, shall enjoy thir fill / Of bliss on bliss, while I to Hell am thrust, / Where neither joy nor love, but fierce desire, / Among our other torments not the least, / Still unfulfill'd with pain of longing pines" (IV.505–511).

The happier Eden is not the garden but the marriage, the two "imparadised in one another's arms." Satan's envy is not of the place but of the couple, of a conjugal bliss he cannot share and must therefore destroy. His motive for the ruin of humanity, in Milton's dramatization, is the envy of a solitary for a pair. Doe's confession reproduces Satan's with a fidelity that exceeds coincidence. He too has watched a couple from outside; he too has envied not their possessions but their ordinary happiness, the simple life of a husband and wife; and he too has sought to dwell with them. His statement that he tried to play the husband, to taste the life of a simple man, is the literal enactment of Satan's ironic offer of an amity so close that he must dwell with them. His intrusion into the Mills apartment on the morning of the last day is the serpent's entry into the bower. Milton's Satan, in the same book, is discovered "Squat like a Toad, close at the eare of Eve," assaying by his devilish art to reach the organs of her fancy as she sleeps (IV.800–802)—an image of intimate violation, the intruder at the ear of the sleeping wife. In the ninth book he finds her alone, the couple having parted for the morning's labor: "Eve separate he spies" (IX.424). Tracy is alone in the apartment because her husband is at work on the case the intruder has made. The separation the series has imposed upon the couple is the condition of its last violation.

Satan's soliloquy on Mount Niphates, at the opening of the same book, supplies the theology of Doe's self-understanding. Confronting the sun, the fallen angel

acknowledges that his fall was unforced, that he had the freedom and the power to stand, and that he can neither repent nor escape: "Me miserable! which way shall I flie / Infinite wrauth, and infinite despaire? / Which way I flie is Hell; my self am Hell" (IV.73–75). He concludes with the formula of moral inversion: "Evil be thou my Good" (IV.110). Infinite wrath and infinite despair—the two passions of the Stygian marsh that the third chapter identified with Mills and Somerset—are here the twin torments of the envious angel. And the inversion of good and evil is precisely what Doe has accomplished in his own conscience: the murders are his good, the work for which he expects to be remembered. The one point at which his self-understanding breaks is the confession of envy, the moment at which he concedes, like Satan on Niphates, that he carries his hell within him.

Milton's Satan is the most compelling character in his poem, and Doe the most compelling in his film; both are given the best speeches, and both have been admired by readers who mistook eloquence for truth. The critical tradition from Blake and Shelley to William Empson's *Milton's God* (1961) has argued over whether *Paradise Lost* succumbs to its antagonist's grandeur, and Stanley Fish's *Surprised by Sin* (1967) answered that the poem deliberately seduces its readers through Satan's rhetoric in order to make them discover their own fallenness in the very act of being seduced. *Se7en* works upon its audience in the same way. Doe's speeches in the car are lucid, measured, and in part persuasive; the spectator who finds himself agreeing with them has been led, as Fish argued Milton's reader is led, into complicity with the tempter, and the opening of the box is the moment of being surprised by sin. The confession of envy completes the lesson. The voice that indicted the city with such clarity was the voice of the serpent watching the bower.

The Book of Genesis compresses the whole into a few verses. The serpent, "more subtil than any beast of the field" (Gen. 3:1), speaks to the woman when she is alone; the fruit is taken; the eyes of the couple are opened, and they know that they are naked (3:7). The Fall is a catastrophe of vision, and its consequence is death. The final sequence of *Se7en* is a Fall staged in reverse order. The serpent comes to the woman first and kills her; the box is opened, and the eyes of the man who opens it are filled with what cannot be shown; and the knowledge communicated to the husband is not of nakedness but of loss. Envy, which in the Wisdom of Solomon brought death into the world, here brings death into the household. The Eden it destroys was modest—a cramped apartment shaken by trains, a marriage still finding its footing in a city the wife hated—but it was, to the solitary who watched it, the happier Eden, and that was reason enough.

6.3

Triangular Desire: Girard, Sedgwick, and the Mediated Wife

René Girard argued that human desire is not a line drawn from a subject to an object but a triangle: we desire what we desire because another—a model, a mediator, a rival—desires or possesses it, and our desire is an imitation of his. When the model is distant, a hero of romance or a figure of legend, the imitation is benign; when the model is near, a neighbor or a rival in the same world, imitation turns to rivalry, and desire for the object becomes, beneath its surface, desire for the very being of the model. Girard called this metaphysical desire, and he traced through the novels of Cervantes, Stendhal, Flaubert, Proust, and Dostoevsky its characteristic passions: envy, jealousy, impotent hatred (*Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque*, 1961). In *Je vois Satan tomber comme l'éclair* (1999) he read the tenth commandment as the Bible's prohibition of mimetic desire itself: "Thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's house, thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's wife … nor any thing that is thy neighbour's" (Exod. 20:17). The commandment names the neighbor rather than the object, because the neighbor is the model whose possessions are desired because they are his.

Doe's confession is a textbook of metaphysical desire. What he envies is not Tracy as such, whom he scarcely knows, nor the apartment, which is cramped and noisy, but the being of the man who has them: a normal life, the life of a simple man, a husband's life. The object is mediated by the rival. Tracy is desirable because she is Mills's wife, and the apartment because it is Mills's home. Doe's attempt to play the husband is an attempt to become Mills by occupying his place, and its failure—it did not work out, he says—is the failure Girard located at the core of every metaphysical desire, the discovery that possession of the model's objects does not confer the model's being. The response to that failure, in Girard's account, is violence against the model, and here it takes the form of a reversal. Doe, unable to become Mills, will make Mills become Doe. The detective's wrath will make him a killer, and the two will be joined at last as what Girard called monstrous doubles, the rivals of the sacrificial crisis who have become indistinguishable in their violence.

Girard's model was taken up in Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985), which read the erotic triangle of the European novel as a structure of male homosocial desire: the rivalry of two men over a woman is a bond between the men, and the woman is its conduit. Sedgwick drew on Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975), which had reread Claude Lévi-Strauss's account of kinship as the exchange

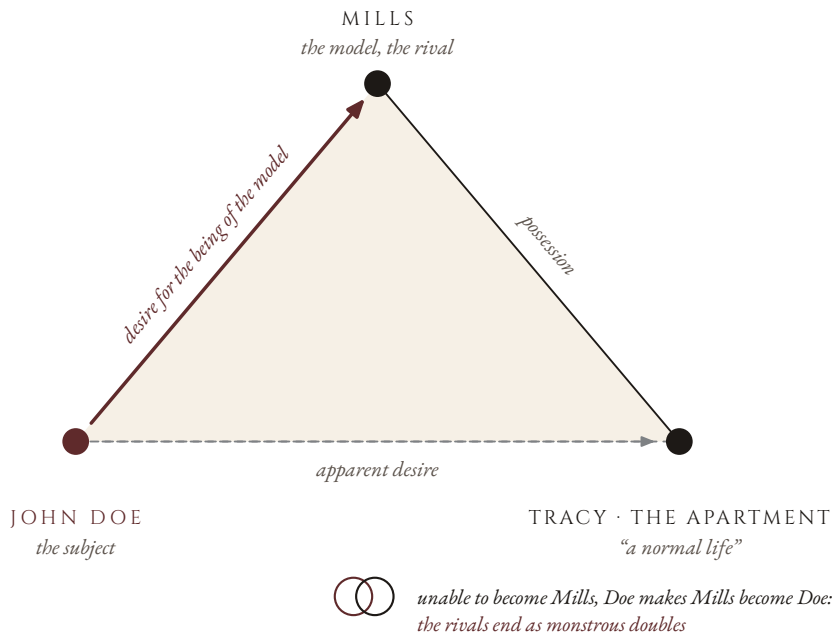


FIG. 15 TRIANGULAR DESIRE *What Doe envies is not the object but the being of the model. Possession of the model's objects does not confer the model's being, and the failure turns into violence against the model.*

of women between men and exposed that exchange as the foundation of a sex-gender system in which women are the objects rather than the subjects of social bonds. *Se7en* is organized by two such triangles. The first binds Mills and Somerset through Tracy. It is Tracy who invites the older man to dinner, who wants the partners to become friends, and whose table, shaken by the passing trains, is the scene of their first shared laughter; and it is to Somerset, not to her husband, that she confides her pregnancy and her fear of raising a child in the city. The woman is the medium through which the men's bond is formed, and she is also the keeper of a secret that passes between her and one of them alone. The second triangle binds Doe and Mills through Tracy, and it ends in the most literal possible enactment of Rubin's thesis: the woman is reduced to an object and conveyed in a parcel from one man to another, with a third as intermediary. The traffic in women becomes the delivery of a head.

The secret of the pregnancy organizes both triangles. Tracy tells Somerset in the diner; she does not tell Mills; Doe, who was in the apartment that morning, knows it, because, as he tells Mills, she begged for her own life and for the life of the baby inside her. On the last day the secret is thus held by two men and withheld from the third, the husband, who learns it from the killer at the moment of its destruction—

and who may read in Somerset's stricken face that his partner already knew. Doe's discovery that Mills did not know is the last turn of the screw. Knowledge of the wife passes between men, and the husband is the last to receive it.

Shakespeare's *Othello* is the great precedent for this configuration, and the closest. Iago, who envies Cassio's promotion and Othello's happiness alike, cannot bear the music of the newlyweds' reunion—"O, you are well tuned now! / But I'll set down the pegs that make this music" (II.i)—and destroys the marriage by means of a token, the handkerchief, a gift converted into evidence. He turns the husband's love into wrath and the wrath into the murder of an innocent wife. Iago is envy; Othello becomes wrath; Desdemona is the innocent victim between them. *Se7en* redistributes the roles of Shakespeare's triangle without altering its logic. The envier kills the innocent wife himself, and the husband's wrath is turned upon the envier; but the mechanism is the same, the conversion of a husband's love into murderous rage by the contrivance of a man who cannot bear his happiness. Iago's last words are a refusal to explain: "Demand me nothing: what you know, you know: / From this time forth I never will speak word" (V.ii). Doe, who has explained everything, is silenced by a bullet. Both leave the stage to the ruin of the man they envied.

Feminist criticism has a name for the role the film assigns to Tracy. In 1999 the comic-book writer Gail Simone compiled a list of female characters killed, maimed, or stripped of their powers in order to motivate the stories of male heroes, and named it after a 1994 issue of *Green Lantern* in which the hero comes home to find his girlfriend murdered and stuffed into a refrigerator: "women in refrigerators." Tracy is the paradigmatic fridged woman of the American cinema of the 1990s, killed offscreen so that her death may become the crisis of a man. The film's first clue, it will be recalled, was found behind a refrigerator. The critique applies to *Se7en* with full force, and the film's only defense against it is the one this dissertation has already identified: its refusal to make her death into an image. It cannot give Tracy a story of her own. It can at least refuse to give Doe her face.

6.4

The Justified Sinner: Election, Antinomianism, and the Double

Doe presents himself, in the car, not as one who chose his work but as one who was chosen for it. The claim belongs to a precise theological lineage, and its most searching literary analysis was written more than a century and a half before

the film. James Hogg's *The Private Memoirs and Confessions of a Justified Sinner* (1824) is the autobiography of Robert Wringhim, raised in early eighteenth-century Scotland by a fanatical Calvinist minister who assures him that he is among the elect, predestined to salvation and therefore beyond the power of any sin to condemn. On the day of this assurance Robert meets a mysterious stranger who resembles him in every feature, who can assume the likeness of anyone, and who persuades him that as one of the justified he may—indeed must—destroy the enemies of God. Robert murders a preacher and then his own brother George, an easy, handsome, popular young man whom he has always envied, and descends into a nightmare of pursuit by his companion, who is the devil, or his double, or both. The novel ends with his suicide and with an editor's discovery of his memoirs in his grave.

Hogg's novel is the classic study of antinomianism, the doctrine, condemned by orthodox Protestant and Catholic theology alike, that the elect are not bound by the moral law. Its theological ground is the double predestination of Calvin's *Institutes*, in which God elects some to salvation and others to damnation by an eternal decree, a decree Calvin himself called dreadful: "*decretum quidem horribile, fateor*" (*Institutio* III.23.7). Robert Wringhim is the man who believes himself the instrument of the dreadful decree, and Doe is his descendant. Both are convinced of their election; both kill those they have judged reprobate; both describe their murders as obedience. And both, at the center of their righteousness, harbor envy of a brother who possesses an ordinary, unreflective happiness. Robert murders George; Doe murders Mills's wife and, through his own death, destroys Mills. The justified sinner kills the brother he envies.

The figure of the double that haunts Hogg's novel organizes the relations of *Se7en*'s principals. Otto Rank's study of the double (*Der Doppelgänger*, 1914; expanded 1925) traced the motif from archaic beliefs in the soul as a second self through the Romantic literature of the *Doppelgänger*, and Freud, in "Das Unheimliche" (1919), adopted Rank's thesis that the double, originally an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an assurance of immortality, becomes in a later phase the uncanny harbinger of death. Doe is the double of both detectives. He is Mills's double in the Girardian sense, the rival who wants his life and who will make him, at the end, a killer like himself. And he is Somerset's double in a deeper sense. Both are solitary, nocturnal, bookish men who live among notebooks and libraries; both are revolted by the city; both have refused posterity, Somerset by persuading a woman not to bear his child, Doe by destroying another man's; both have read their Dante and their Aquinas. Doe is what Somerset's acedia might become were its despair to turn to rancor—the family romance of the daughters of sloth traced in the third chapter, in which the melancholic and the moralist are sisters. The film's design places the young

detective between the two older men, one of whom tries to save him and the other to damn him, and both of whom understand him better than he understands himself.

The literature of the double supplies the logic of the ending. In Poe's "William Wilson" (1839), the narrator is pursued through a dissipated life by a namesake who resembles him exactly and who appears at each of his worst moments to frustrate him; at last, in a fury, he stabs his double at a masquerade, and the dying figure tells him that in killing it he has killed himself: "In me didst thou exist—and, in my death, see by this image, which is thine own, how utterly thou hast murdered thyself." Robert Louis Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) ends with the respectable physician's destruction by the double he has released, and Dostoevsky's *Dvoinik* (*The Double*, 1846) follows a minor official displaced from his own life by a successful replica of himself. In each, the destruction of the double is the destruction of the self. Mills's killing of Doe is a killing of this kind. In shooting the man who made himself his double, Mills destroys the self that might have refused him: the officer of the law, the husband, the man with a future. Doe's death is Mills's self-murder, as the double's death is William Wilson's.

Carl Jung's concept of the shadow, the unacknowledged dark side of the personality that is projected onto others, offers a further perspective on Doe's function. Doe is the shadow of the city, the embodiment of its repressed judgment upon itself, and the shadow of each detective. Jung held that the shadow cannot be destroyed, only integrated, and that to attack it in another is to act it out. Somerset, who recognizes in Doe something of his own disgust with the city, refuses to kill him; Mills, who recognizes nothing of himself in Doe and calls him only a lunatic, becomes him. The detective who refuses to see the double in himself is the one the double captures.

The justified sinner's theology meets, finally, the political theology of the next chapter. Doe's claim to have been chosen is a claim to stand outside the law in order to execute a higher one, the claim of the sovereign who decides on the exception. Hogg's novel shows where that claim leads when a private man holds it: to murder, to madness, and to a grave in which the memoirs of the elect are buried with his body. *Se7en* shows where it leads when the private man succeeds in conscripting the officers of the public law. The justified sinner no longer needs to commit the last murder himself. He can induce the law to commit it for him.

6.5

Cain's City: Envy and the Foundation of the Polis

The first murder in Scripture is a murder of envy, and its story contains the whole of *Se7en* in miniature. Cain and Abel bring offerings to the Lord, who has respect for Abel's and not for Cain's, "and Cain was very wroth, and his countenance fell" (Gen. 4:5). God warns him: "If thou doest well, shalt thou not be accepted? and if thou doest not well, sin lieth at the door" (4:7). Cain speaks with his brother, "and it came to pass, when they were in the field, that Cain rose up against Abel his brother, and slew him" (4:8). Asked where his brother is, he answers with the question that founds the problem of responsibility: "Am I my brother's keeper?" (4:9). The blood of Abel cries out from the ground; Cain is cursed, made a fugitive, and marked—and the mark protects him: "whosoever slayeth Cain, vengeance shall be taken on him sevenfold" (4:15). Then Cain goes out, and "he builded a city" (4:17). Within a few generations his descendant Lamech sings to his wives the first boast of vengeance: "If Cain shall be avenged sevenfold, truly Lamech seventy and sevenfold" (4:24).

Envy issuing in wrath; a countenance fallen; sin crouching at the door; a killing in a field; the bystander's question; vengeance multiplied by seven; the founding of the first city. Genesis 4 is the matrix of the film. The last killing of *Se7en* takes place, like the first killing of Scripture, in a field outside the city, and it is preceded by a fallen countenance—Mills's face, as Doe's words reach him, collapsing from disbelief into grief and from grief into rage. The question "Am I my brother's keeper?" is the question of the bystander, which the third chapter traced through the Good Samaritan and the Genovese case, and which Somerset's apathy has for years answered in the negative. And the multiplication of vengeance by seven, from Cain to Lamech, is the arithmetic of Doe's series, which multiplies punishment until it returns upon the punisher.

The mark of Cain bears upon the ending with a precision that criticism of the film appears not to have registered. In Genesis the mark is protective. God, having punished the murderer, forbids anyone to kill him, and attaches to the prohibition the threat of sevenfold vengeance; the first murderer is placed under the protection of law against the avenger. Doe reverses the mark. Having committed his murders, he marks himself for death—he confesses the sin that will make his killing inevitable—and he places the avenger, Mills, in the position of the one whom Genesis forbade to strike. The mark of Cain withdrew the murderer from the cycle of vengeance; Doe's confession inserts him into it, so that his death will complete the series. The film's ending is Genesis 4 rewritten by Lamech.

The Christian tradition answered Lamech's song by inverting its arithmetic. When Peter asks how often he should forgive a brother who sins against him—"till seven times?"—Jesus replies: "I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven" (Matt. 18:21–22). The number of Lamech's vengeance becomes the number of forgiveness. The biblical history of the number seven thus runs from Cain's protective mark through Lamech's escalating vengeance to the Gospel's limitless forgiveness, and *Se7en* places its heptad on Lamech's side of that history. Its seven is the seven of vengeance multiplied, not of forgiveness without measure. The next chapter will argue that the series' last term, wrath, is Lamech's song performed by a policeman; the coda will ask whether the film leaves any room for the other seven.

Augustine made the story of Cain the foundation of his theory of the city. The earthly city, he wrote, was founded by a fratricide: Cain built a city, while Abel, a pilgrim, built none (*De civitate Dei* XV.1). And the founding murder was a murder of envy: the first founder of the earthly city was a fratricide, who, overcome by envy, slew his own brother, a citizen of the eternal city on pilgrimage in this world—"*invidentia victus occidit*" (XV.5). Rome repeated the pattern when Romulus killed Remus, though there, Augustine observed, both brothers were citizens of the earthly city, rivals for its glory, while in Cain and Abel the earthly city confronted the heavenly. Envy is the founding passion of political community in Augustine's account, and the city is built on a brother's blood. René Girard, in *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978), generalized Augustine's insight into an anthropology of the founding murder: human communities, he argued, are founded upon collective violence against a victim, a violence that myths conceal by declaring the victim guilty and that the Bible, beginning with the blood of Abel crying from the ground, reveals by taking the victim's side.

The city of *Se7en* is Cain's city in Augustine's and Girard's sense. It is unnamed because it is the city as such, the *civitas terrena* founded upon envy and sustained by the violence it conceals. Doe's series is an attempt to expose that founding violence—to show that the city's prosperity rests on sin—and it is at the same time a repetition of it, a new founding murder that declares its victims guilty in the manner of every myth. Girard's distinction is decisive here. Myth speaks for the persecutors and affirms the guilt of the victim; the biblical text speaks for the victim and unmasks the persecutors' violence. Doe speaks the language of myth: he insists in the car that his victims were not innocent. But his series contains one victim whom no myth can convict, and she is in the box. Tracy is Abel. Her blood, unshown, cries from the ground of the field, and it is the cry the film refuses to silence by converting it into an image.

The founding of the city is also the founding of its police. Cain, marked and protected, is the first beneficiary of a law that removes vengeance from private hands.

The officer of the law exists so that no brother need avenge a brother, and the law exists so that the cycle of Lamech may be broken. When Mills fires, the institution born from the mark of Cain collapses back into the vendetta it was established to end. In that moment the city loses the one distinction that separated it from the field where the first brother killed the second.

6.6

The Gift of Death: Mauss, Derrida, and the Poisoned Parcel

The final sin arrives as a gift. A van pulls into the field at the appointed hour; its driver has been hired to deliver a package addressed to Detective David Mills; Somerset intercepts it and opens it. The box is a parcel, a delivery, an object conveyed from one man to another, and it obliges a response. In the anthropology of the gift, that obligation is everything. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) argued that the gift, in archaic societies, is never free: it imposes three obligations—to give, to receive, and to reciprocate—and the force that compels the return is understood, in the Maori conception Mauss made famous, as the *hau*, the spirit of the thing given, which seeks to return to its source and brings misfortune upon the recipient who fails to restore it. In the potlatch of the peoples of the Pacific Northwest the gift becomes agonistic: rivals give or destroy wealth in ever greater quantities to humiliate one another, and the one who cannot answer with a greater gift or a greater destruction loses face.

Doe's box is a potlatch gift in its most extreme form. It destroys the most precious things in the series—a woman, an unborn child, and, by design, the giver himself—in order to impose upon the recipient an obligation he cannot refuse. The return gift it compels is the bullet, and the bullet completes the series. Georges Bataille, who built his theory of a general economy of expenditure upon Mauss's account of the potlatch in *La Part maudite* (1949), observed that the gift of rivalry acquires its power through loss, so that the giver who destroys the most establishes his rank over the receiver. Doe gives everything away, his own life included, and in doing so establishes his mastery over the man who will receive it. Mills's response, which looks like the destruction of Doe, is the acceptance of his gift.

Mauss himself noticed, in a short article of 1924 titled "Gift, Gift," that the Germanic languages preserve the ambiguity of the gift in a single word: in German, *Gift* means both a present, in the older sense that survives in *Mitgift*, a dowry, and a poison. The gift is a poison because it binds; the present is dangerous because it

obligates. The box is the poisoned gift *par excellence*. The classical imagination knew the type. In the second book of the *Aeneid*, Laocoön warns the Trojans against the horse the Greeks have left at their gates—"*timeo Danaos et dona ferentes*," I fear the Greeks even when they bring gifts (II.49)—and the Trojans, accepting the gift, are destroyed from within. Doe's parcel is a Trojan horse whose contents destroy the man who opens his arms to it.

The most terrible gift in ancient drama is the one Atreus gives his brother. In Seneca's *Thyestes*, Atreus, avenging his brother's seduction of his wife and his attempt upon the throne, feigns reconciliation, invites Thyestes to a feast, and serves him the flesh of his own sons; when the meal is done he uncovers the platter that holds their heads and hands and asks his brother whether he recognizes his children—"*natos ecquid agnoscis tuos?*" (1005). The sun, the chorus has already lamented, turned back in its course at the crime. The revenge tragedy of the European stage, from Seneca's Renaissance imitators to *Titus Andronicus*, in which a messenger returns to the mutilated Titus his own severed hand together with the heads of two of his sons (III.i), found in the presentation of heads its climactic image. Doe's box belongs to this tradition, and it closes, in a sense, the circle of the series. The first tableau was a feast of gluttony; the last is a Thyestean revelation, the presentation of a head to a man whose family has been destroyed. Gluttony and the severed head, the first sin and the last gift, are joined in the oldest myth of revenge.

Jacques Derrida's *Donner la mort* (1992) gives the gift of death its philosophical name. The French idiom *donner la mort* means simply to kill, but Derrida reads it literally—to give death, to make a gift of it—and develops from it a meditation on sacrifice, responsibility, and the secret, centered on Abraham's binding of Isaac. Absolute responsibility toward one other, Derrida argues, requires the sacrifice of every other: in answering God's call Abraham sacrifices the ethical, his son, his family, and his speech, for every other is wholly other, *tout autre est tout autre*. And the gift of death includes the giving of one's own death, the death no one else can die in one's place. Doe's box is a *don de la mort* in every sense the phrase can bear. It gives death to Tracy; it gives Mills the death of his wife and child as a present; and it gives Doe his own death, which he has arranged to receive from Mills's hand. Its secret—what is inside, and what Tracy knew—is the secret around which Derrida's reading of Abraham turns, the secret that cannot be shared without destroying the one who keeps it.

In *Donner le temps* (1991), Derrida argued that the pure gift is impossible: the moment a gift is recognized as a gift by giver or recipient, it enters the economy of exchange, incurs a debt, and annuls itself as gift. The pure gift would have to go unrecognized, forgotten in the instant of its giving. Doe's gift is the opposite of the

pure gift. It exists only to be recognized, to impose its debt, to be repaid. Against it the film sets an image that approaches Derrida's impossibility. Tracy's gifts in the film —the dinner, the friendship she makes possible between the two men, the secret she entrusts to Somerset—are given without calculation and without return. She asks nothing of Somerset but counsel, and receives from him the advice to spoil her child at every chance she gets. Hers is the one gift in the film that seeks no reciprocation. It is the gift Doe destroys, in order to substitute for it the gift that demands repayment in blood.

6.7

Pandora's *Elpis*: Hope Inside the Box

The most famous container in Western mythology was not a box. In Hesiod's *Works and Days*, Zeus, angered by Prometheus's theft of fire, has Hephaestus fashion a woman from earth and water, and each of the gods endows her with a gift—beauty, grace, skill, a deceitful mind—so that she is called Pandora, the all-gifted, "because all they who dwelt on Olympus gave each a gift, a plague to men who eat bread" (80–82). She lifts the great lid of a jar, a *pithos*, and scatters its contents among men, countless plagues and diseases that come by day and by night. "Only Hope remained there in an unbreakable home within under the rim of the great jar, and did not fly out at the door; for ere that, the lid of the jar stopped her, by the will of Aegis-holding Zeus who gathers the clouds" (94–99, trans. Evelyn-White, 1914). In the *Theogony* the same woman is the *kalon kakon*, the beautiful evil, first of the race of women, fashioned as a punishment (570–612).

The jar became a box through a Renaissance error. Erasmus, retelling the myth in his *Adagia* (1508), rendered Hesiod's *pithos* as *pyxis*, a small box, conflating Pandora's vessel with the box that Psyche, in Apuleius's *Metamorphoses*, carries back from the underworld holding a portion of Proserpina's beauty—a box she opens from the wish to keep a little of that beauty for herself, and from which a deathlike Stygian sleep pours over her (VI.19–21). Dora and Erwin Panofsky traced the consequences of the conflation in *Pandora's Box: The Changing Aspects of a Mythical Symbol* (1956). The box of the European imagination thus fuses two vessels: the jar from which evils escape while hope remains within, and the box that holds beauty and releases death. The box of *Se7en* is both. It holds a woman's beauty—the face of the one victim the film has presented as wholly lovely and wholly good—and it releases death upon the man who receives it. And it holds, within, something that remains.

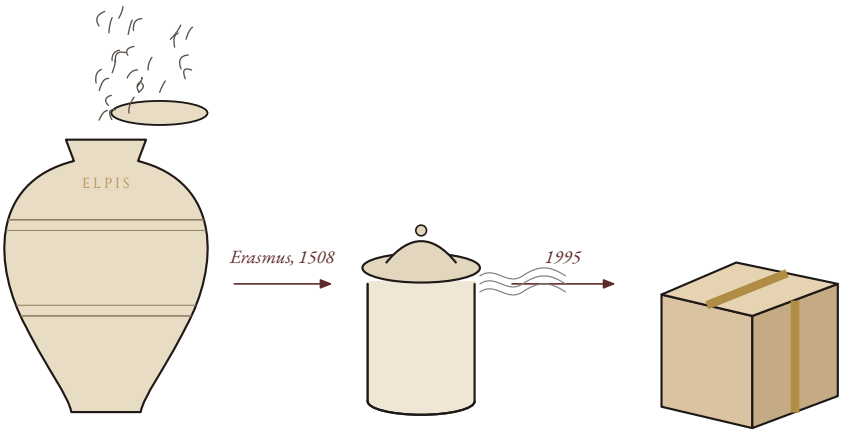


FIG. 16 TWO VESSELS FUSED *Hesiod's jar, from which the evils fly while hope remains, became a box when Erasmus rendered pithos as pyxis, conflating it with the box Psyche carries back from the underworld. The box of Se7en is both.*

What remains is hope. Tracy is pregnant; the box contains not one life destroyed but two. The Greek *elpis* means expectation as much as hope, the anticipation of what is to come, and the English idiom for a pregnant woman is that she is expecting. The figure in Hesiod's jar that remains within, in an unbreakable home beneath the rim, unable to fly out, is given in the box of *Se7en* a terrible literalness: the unborn child, the expectation, the future, held within its mother within the parcel, never to emerge. The cardboard box encloses a womb, and the womb encloses the hope the series has destroyed.

The meaning of the hope that remains in Pandora's jar has been disputed since antiquity. Is it a good withheld from men and kept for them as their one consolation, or an evil that, unlike the others, stays with them always? Nietzsche gave the darker reading its most memorable form in *Menschliches, Allzumenschliches* (1878): Zeus wished that man, though tormented by the other evils, should not throw his life away but go on letting himself be tormented, and to that end he gave him hope, which is in truth the worst of evils because it prolongs man's torment (I.71). *Se7en* gives both readings their due. Hope as the good kept within is the child, Tracy's future, the life Somerset counseled her to cherish. Hope as the worst of evils is the knowledge of that child, which Doe administers to Mills at the precise moment when it can only deepen his torment. Doe's revelation of the pregnancy is the cruelest act of the series, because it converts the good of hope into its evil: the husband learns of his expectation in the

instant of learning that it has been annihilated. The last turn of Doe's design is the weaponization of hope.

The Christian tradition counted hope among the three theological virtues, with faith and charity, and made despair the sin against it; Dante inscribed over the gate of Hell the command to abandon all hope (*Inf.* III.9). Charles Péguy, in *Le Porche du mystère de la deuxième vertu* (1912), figured hope as a little girl walking between her two grown sisters, faith and charity, seemingly led by them but in truth leading them both; nothing, Péguy's God declares, astonishes him so much as hope. The little girl of Péguy's poem is the child in the box. P. D. James's *The Children of Men* (1992), set in a world in which no child has been born for a quarter of a century, made a single pregnancy the hope of the species, and Ira Levin's *Rosemary's Baby* (1967), filmed by Roman Polanski in 1968, placed in a city apartment a pregnancy that a satanic conspiracy had claimed for its own ends. *Se7en* stands between these fictions. Its pregnancy is neither the redemption of the world nor the vessel of its damnation. It is an ordinary hope, a child expected by a frightened woman in a city she hated, and the series destroys it because it is ordinary.

The film's refusal to open the box to its spectator acquires, in this light, its fullest meaning. In Hesiod's narrative, hope remains within the jar because the lid is closed in time, by the will of Zeus. In *Se7en*, the head remains within the box because the film closes its lid against our gaze. The parallel is exact, and it is not ironic. The film cannot save Tracy or her child; within the fiction they are dead and the series is complete. What it can do is refuse to let what remains in the box be scattered among the images of the world. It keeps hope within the vessel, beneath the rim, in the only unbreakable home the cinema can offer: the image it declines to make. Every other term of the series has been exhibited, and every exhibition has been Doe's. The last term is kept. This is the film's answer to the envy that brought death into its world: it does not show what envy has destroyed, and in not showing it, it denies envy its final possession. The head is Doe's crime; the face belongs to the film's silence. And the seventh day, to which the series now turns, is the day on which a man who has not seen what the box contains will be asked to act upon it.

The Seventh Day

Ira

Wrath



The Box and the Sovereign

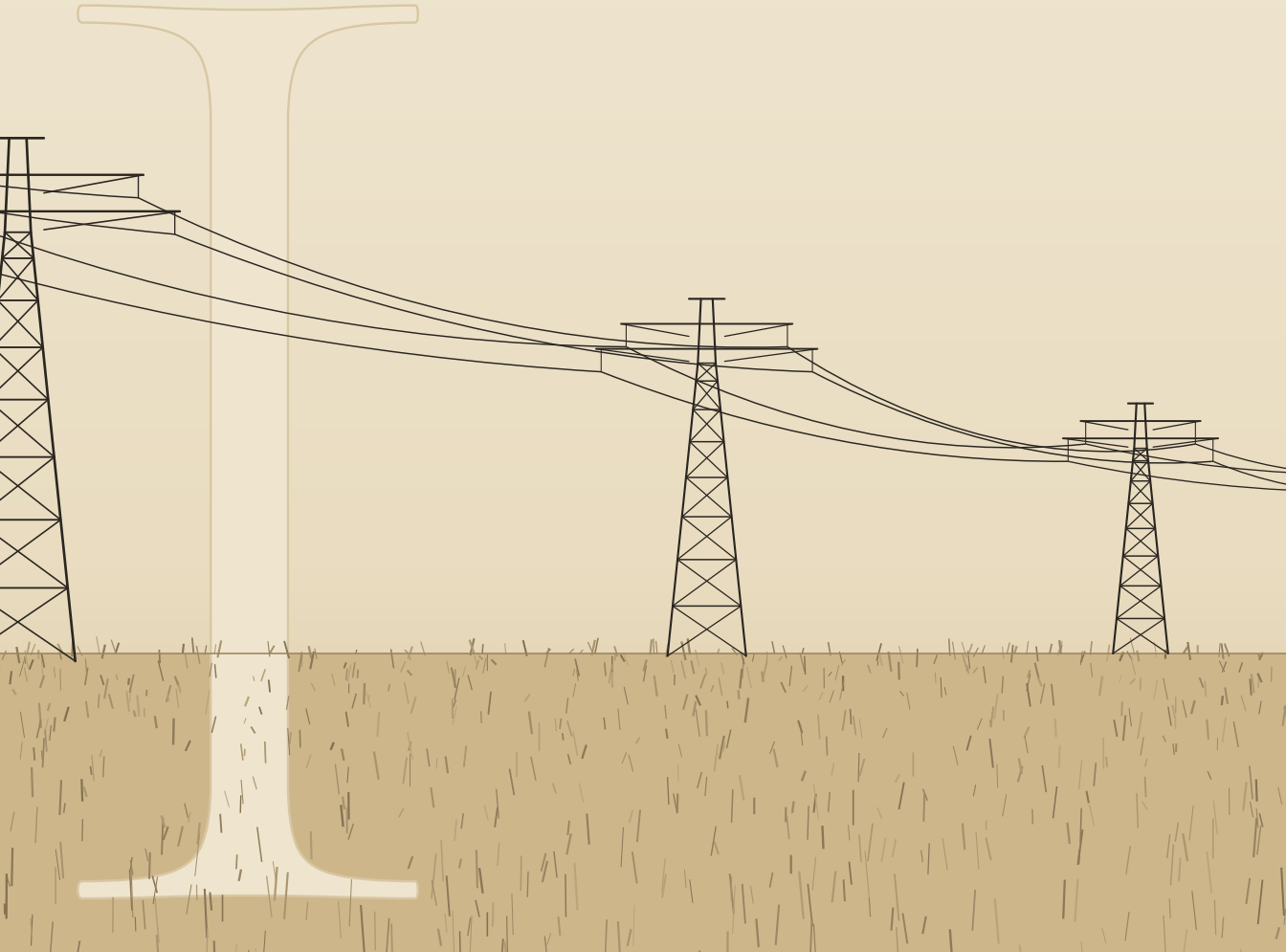
Wrath, Decision, and the Oresteia Reversed

Dies irae, dies illa, / solvet saeclum in favilla, / teste David cum Sibylla. [Day of wrath, that day, which will dissolve the world in ashes, as David and the Sibyl bear witness.]

— *Sequence of the Requiem Mass, thirteenth century*

And when he had opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven about the space of half an hour.

— *Revelation 8:1*



7.1

Noon in the Wasteland: Apocalypse as Unveiling

The series ends in sunlight. Doe, who has surrendered himself at the precinct, covered in blood, has offered through his lawyer to lead the two detectives, and only them, to the last two bodies; refused, he will plead insanity. The district attorney consents. The detectives are wired for sound, a police helicopter tracks the car from above, and Mills and Somerset drive Doe, handcuffed behind the grille of the back seat, out of the city along the roads he names. The landscape changes as they go. The tenements give way to industrial margins and then to open country: a dry, flat expanse of scrub and dust, crossed by the steel towers of high-voltage transmission lines, beneath a cloudless sky. It is the only place in the film where the sun is fully visible, and it is a wasteland.

The passage from the drowned city to the parched field fulfills, as the first chapter proposed, the Miltonic epigraph with which the series began. Satan's words—"long is the way / And hard, that out of Hell leads up to light"—have been enacted to the letter: the way out of the hell of the city does lead up to light. But the light is not salvation. It is exposure. The Greek *apokalypsis* means uncovering, the removal of a veil, and the seventh day of *Se7en* is apocalyptic in that strict sense: it is the day on which everything hidden is uncovered—the last two "bodies," Doe's motive, Tracy's fate, the secret of her pregnancy, the truth about Mills. The rain that veiled the city for six days has been withdrawn, and in the merciless light what remains is revealed. The waste land of Eliot's first section is the place where "the sun beats, / And the dead tree gives no shelter, the cricket no relief, / And the dry stone no sound of water," where the speaker promises to show "fear in a handful of dust" (ll. 22–24, 30). After the rain of the third circle comes the drought of judgment.

The medieval liturgy of the dead named this day. The sequence *Dies irae*, traditionally attributed to the thirteenth-century Franciscan Thomas of Celano and sung for centuries in the Requiem Mass, opens with the day of wrath that will dissolve the world in ashes, *teste David cum Sibylla*, as David and the Sibyl bear witness, and announces that a written book will be brought forth in which everything is contained, by which the world will be judged: "*Liber scriptus proferetur, / in quo totum continetur, / unde mundus iudicetur*." The coincidences are startling. The seventh day of *Se7en* is a day of wrath; the witness upon whom it falls bears the Psalmist's name,

for the detective is called David; and the book in which everything is written, from which the world is to be judged, is Doe's—the two thousand notebooks in which he recorded the city's sins. The liturgy imagined the Last Judgment as the opening of a book and the testimony of David. *Se7en* stages it as the closing of a book and the destruction of a David.

The final setting bears the features of the places of judgment and sacrifice in the scriptural imagination. It is a wilderness, the place to which, on the Day of Atonement, the high priest sent the goat bearing the iniquities of the people "unto a land not inhabited" (Lev. 16:21–22); it is the desert in which Satan tempted Christ, who refused the temptations that Mills will accept (Matt. 4:1–11). The steel pylons that stride across it recall the crosses of Calvary, and the hill of the crucifixion bears a name the film's ending makes terrible: "a place called Golgotha, that is to say, a place of a skull" (Matt. 27:33). Golgotha and Calvary alike name a head. Medieval legend placed the skull of Adam beneath the cross, so that the blood of the second Adam might fall upon the head of the first, and painters of the crucifixion set a skull at the foot of the cross for centuries. *Se7en*'s Golgotha is the place to which a head is delivered: not the skull of the first sinner, redeemed by the blood that falls upon it, but the head of an innocent woman, redeemed by nothing.

The light of the final sequence also recalls the hour the third chapter identified as the hour of acedia. The noonday demon attacks when the sun stands highest and the shadows are shortest, and Nietzsche made the great noon, *der große Mittag*, the hour of decision and transvaluation in *Also sprach Zarathustra*, the hour at which humanity stands midway between beast and overman and must choose. The field beneath the pylons is rendered as a perpetual noon, a place without shade in which the passions the city had diffused into apathy and rain are concentrated into a single decision. It is here, under the noonday glare of the wasteland, that the acedia of the city and the wrath of the detective meet.

The Apocalypse of John marks the opening of its last seal with an unexpected stillness: "And when he had opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven about the space of half an hour" (Rev. 8:1). The verse gave Ingmar Bergman the title of *Det sjunde inseglet* (1957), in which a knight returned from the crusades plays chess with Death to buy time for a meaning that never comes. The seventh seal of *Se7en* is the box, and when it is opened there is silence: the silence of the image the film will not show. The next section turns to that silence.

7.2

The Unshown: Kuleshov, Medusa, and the Apophatic Image

The van arrives at the appointed hour. Somerset walks out alone to meet it, takes the package from the driver, cuts the tape, and looks inside. The camera does not follow his gaze. It shows his face—recoiling, appalled, emptied—and then his body in motion, running back across the field toward Mills, shouting to him to throw down his gun. What the box contains reaches the spectator by three routes only: Somerset's face, Doe's words, and Mills's understanding as it dawns. Whatever the prop department may have fabricated, the film grants the contents of the box no legible image. The most famous image in *Se7en* does not exist.

The technique inverts the most celebrated experiment in the history of film editing. In the years after the Russian Revolution, Lev Kuleshov intercut a single neutral close-up of the actor Ivan Mozzhukhin with shots of a bowl of soup, a child in a coffin, and a woman reclining on a divan, and reported that audiences praised the actor's subtle expression of hunger, grief, and desire, though the face was identical in each case. The meaning of a face, Kuleshov concluded, is produced by its montage with an object. *Se7en* reverses the procedure. It shows the face and withholds the object, and the spectator, reading Somerset's horror and Mills's anguish, produces the object in imagination. The Kuleshov effect becomes, in the final sequence, an engine of complicity. We complete the image as Mills completes the series. Doe's last tableau is composed not on film but in the mind of each spectator, who supplies from his own imagination the head the film refuses to show—and who thereby performs, at the level of perception, the act of completion Doe demands of Mills at the level of action.

The severed head has a long iconography as the object that cannot be looked upon. Medusa's head turned to stone all who saw it, and Perseus could approach it only by watching its reflection in his bronze shield (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* IV.772–786). Freud, in a note of 1922 published posthumously as "Das Medusenhaupt," read decapitation as castration and the terror of Medusa's head as the terror of a sight that the stiffening of the spectator both expresses and consoles. In Greek art the Gorgon's head became the *gorgoneion*, the apotropaic face that wards off evil by its very horror, and the Renaissance made the decapitated head an object of display: Benvenuto Cellini's *Perseus* (1545–54) lifts it high in the Loggia dei Lanzi, and Caravaggio painted it screaming on a convex parade shield. The Book of Judith records that the widow who beheaded Holofernes "gave Holofernes his head to her maid; and she put

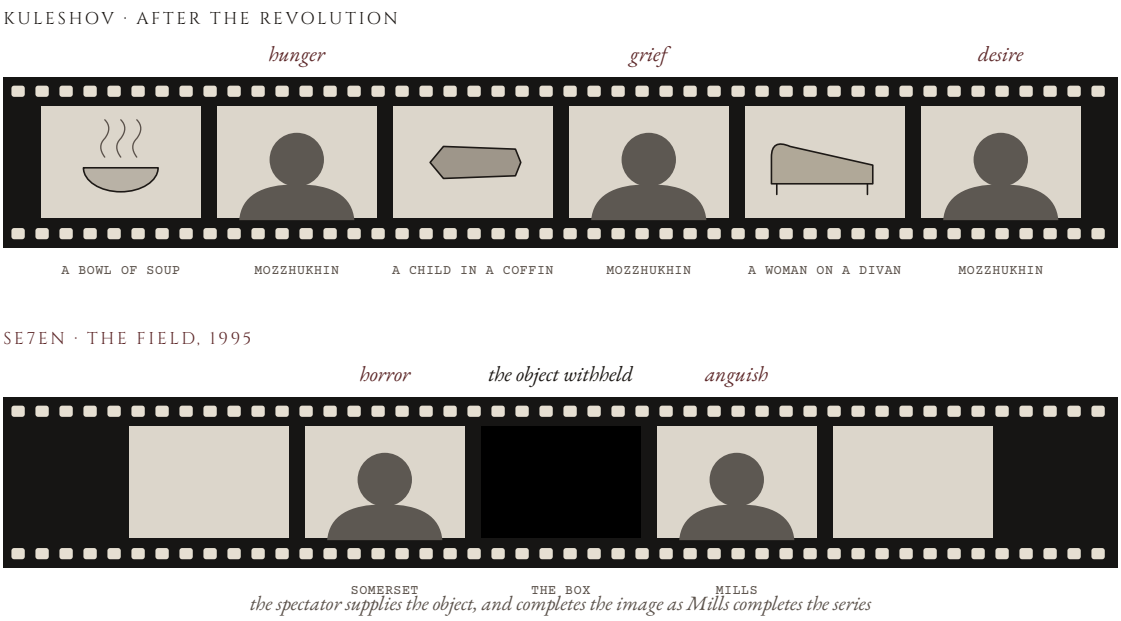


FIG. 17 KULESHOV REVERSED *Kuleshov produced the meaning of a face from the object cut beside it. Se7en shows the faces and withholds the object, and each spectator composes the last tableau in imagination.*

it in her bag of meat" (Jth. 13:10), carried it home, and had it hung upon the walls of Bethulia for all to see. And the fin-de-siècle made the head of John the Baptist, delivered on a charger at the desire of a dancer, the emblem of a decadent erotics of death, from Gustave Moreau's *L'Apparition* (1876) to Oscar Wilde's *Salomé* (1891) and Aubrey Beardsley's illustrations for it, in which Salome kisses the mouth of the dead prophet. The Western tradition of the severed head is a tradition of display. The head is lifted up, painted, hung on walls, kissed, carried in a bag and exhibited.

Se7en breaks with that tradition at its climax. The head arrives in a container, like Holofernes's in Judith's bag, but it is never taken out. It is a woman's head delivered to a man, inverting the gender of Salome's gift, and it is never kissed, never shown, never held up. The Perseus who looks into the box is Somerset, and the paradox of the scene is that the one who sees is not petrified while the one who does not see is. Somerset, who has looked upon the Gorgon, remains capable of speech and action; Mills, who never looks, is turned to stone—first into the rigidity of wrath, then into the catatonic stillness in which he is led away. The unseen head is more terrible than the seen, because it is completed by the imagination of the one who receives it. Mills's Medusa is the image he makes for himself.

The refusal to show belongs to a long theological and philosophical tradition of reticence before the image. The second commandment forbade the making of

any graven image (Exod. 20:4); the apophatic theology of the Pseudo-Dionysius approached God through negation and the divine darkness; Gregory of Nyssa read Moses' entry into the cloud on Sinai as the soul's ascent into a luminous darkness in which God is known by not being seen. Theodor Adorno, in *Negative Dialektik* (1966), invoked the *Bilderverbot* as a principle of materialist thought: only without images could the full object be conceived. The most consequential modern debate over the ethics of the unshown concerned a catastrophe incommensurable with any fiction—Claude Lanzmann's refusal of archival images in *Shoah* (1985), and Georges Didi-Huberman's defense, in *Images malgré tout* (2003), of the four photographs taken in secret at Birkenau in 1944—and its terms must not be borrowed lightly. What that debate established, however, is that the decision whether to show is itself an ethical act, and that the refusal to show can be an act of respect for what exceeds representation. *Se7en*'s refusal is of this kind. It is an apophatic gesture within a cinema of display: the declaration, by negation, that there is one thing in the film that must not become an image.

The refusal is also, as the sixth chapter argued, the closing of Pandora's lid and the preservation of the face Doe sought to possess. Here it must be added that the refusal is not innocent of power. To withhold the image is to exercise the director's sovereignty over what is seen, a sovereignty that rivals Doe's over what is done. But it is sovereignty exercised in the mode of restraint—a decision not to decide what the spectator will see, which leaves the spectator alone with what he imagines. The film's last exhibit is a darkness, and the darkness is its last act of resistance against a series that wanted to end in light.

7.3

Vindice's Name: The Revenger and the Detective as Vengeance

The first word of Western literature is wrath. The *Iliad* opens by invoking the *mēnis* of Achilles—sing, goddess, the wrath of Peleus' son—the ruinous anger that sent the souls of many heroes down to Hades, and its narrative turns upon the conversion of grief into rage: the death of Patroclus transforms Achilles' sullen withdrawal into a fury that kills Hector and drags his body around the walls of Troy. The epic ends, however, not in wrath but in its suspension, when Priam comes by night to Achilles' tent to ransom his son's body and the two enemies weep together

for their dead. *Se7en* is an *Iliad* without its last book. Its final sin is the conversion of grief into wrath, and no Priam comes.

Doe's last words to Mills are an injunction to become wrath, to become vengeance itself. The name the injunction invokes has a dramatic history. The Jacobean stage made revenge its great subject, and its most self-conscious revenger is named for the passion. In *The Revenger's Tragedy* (1606), now generally attributed to Thomas Middleton, the protagonist Vindice—from *vindex*, the avenger—enters holding the skull of his betrothed Gloriana, poisoned years before by a lecherous duke whose advances she refused: "Thou sallow picture of my poisoned love" (I.i). The play's action is his transformation into his name. He disguises himself, dresses the skull, poisons its lips, and lures the duke into kissing it (III.v); he kills and kills again, and at the end, having confessed his crimes in triumph, he is condemned and led away with the reflection that "'Tis time to die, when we are ourselves our foes" (V.iii). The revenger is destroyed by the vengeance he becomes. Mills, holding no skull but standing a few yards from a box that holds his wife's head, is asked by Doe to become Vindice: to make his name his passion and his passion his act.

Thomas Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy* (c. 1587), the first great English revenge tragedy, had already staged the revenger's dilemma as a confrontation between two texts. Hieronimo, whose son has been murdered, enters with a book and reads, *Vindicta mihi*—vengeance is mine—the words Paul cites in the Epistle to the Romans, which continue, "I will repay, saith the Lord." Heaven, he reflects, will be revenged on every ill; he should wait upon its will. Then he turns to Seneca, to the maxim that the safest path for crime is through further crime, and resolves to strike (III.xiii). The Pauline text is the decisive one for *Se7en*: "Dearly beloved, avenge not yourselves, but rather give place unto wrath: for it is written, Vengeance is mine; I will repay, saith the Lord" (Rom. 12:19). Christian ethics did not abolish wrath; it relocated it, reserving vengeance to God and to the authorities ordained as his ministers, "a revenger to execute wrath upon him that doeth evil" (13:4), and forbidding it to the injured individual. Somerset's warning to Mills—if you kill him, he will win—is a secular rendering of the Pauline injunction. It asks Mills to give place to a wrath not his own, to leave vengeance to the law he serves. Mills, like Hieronimo, closes the book and strikes.

The philosophical tradition analyzed the passion with a precision the film honors. Aristotle defined anger as a desire, accompanied by pain, for a conspicuous revenge for a conspicuous slight (*Rhetoric* II.2), and held that the virtuous man is angry at the right things and with the right people, in the right way, at the right time, and for the right length of time (*Nicomachean Ethics* IV.5). Seneca, in *De ira*, rejected even this measure. Anger, he wrote, is what certain wise men have called a brief madness, *brevis*

insania (I.1.2), and it is never useful, not even against wrongdoers, because it is the one passion that cannot be governed once admitted. Gregory the Great distinguished anger born of zeal for justice from anger born of vice, observing that the first troubles the eye of the mind while the second blinds it (*Moralia* V.45). Aquinas allowed that anger may be praiseworthy when it seeks just vengeance according to the order of reason, and sinful when it desires vengeance against that order (*ST* II-II, q. 158, aa. 1–2). Mills's wrath is the paradigm case in which zeal becomes vice. It is provoked by the gravest of wrongs and directed against their author, and by every standard Aristotle could invoke it is the right anger at the right person; yet it is also the anger Doe has scripted, the anger that completes the crime it avenges. It is just, and it is the last term of an injustice.

Dante's terrace of wrath gives this blinding its image. The wrathful purge their sin by walking through a smoke darker than the night of Hell, so harsh that the pilgrim must shut his eyes and lean upon Virgil's shoulder (*Purg.* XVI.1–15). On entering the terrace Dante sees in ecstatic vision examples of meekness, and the last is the stoning of Stephen, the first martyr, who, as the stones fall upon him, prays God to forgive his persecutors (XV.106–114). The counter-image of wrath, at the threshold of its purgation, is a man forgiving his killers as he dies. *Se7en* offers no such vision. Its smoke is the white glare of the wasteland, and its only figure of meekness is Somerset, who pleads and is not heard.

Hamlet, the revenger who cannot revenge, offers a final contrast. Commanded by his father's ghost to avenge a "foul and most unnatural murder" (I.v), he delays for five acts, contemplates a skull in a graveyard, and kills only in the confusion of the last scene; dying, he charges Horatio, the friend who survives him, to absent himself from felicity awhile and in this harsh world draw his breath in pain, to tell his story (V.ii). Mills is a Hamlet without delay, who acts in the instant the ghost speaks. Somerset is Horatio: the survivor who remains in the harsh world to tell the story, and whose voice, in the film's last moments, is the one we hear.

7.4

Force and Significance: Schmitt, Benjamin, and the Fusion in the Gunshot

Carl Schmitt opened his *Politische Theologie* (1922) with a sentence that became the axiom of a century's reflection on sovereignty: "*Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*"—sovereign is he who decides on the exception. The sovereign

is not the one who administers the law but the one who decides when the law applies, who can suspend it in extremity, and whose decision, emerging from no prior norm, founds the order within which norms can operate. The exception, Schmitt wrote, is to jurisprudence what the miracle is to theology, the point at which the sovereign intervenes directly in the order he otherwise underwrites; all the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts.

Doe is a Schmittian sovereign without a state. He decides on the exception—which of the city's sinners have forfeited their lives, and how they will die—and his decisions proceed from no law the city recognizes. He claims to execute a law higher than the city's, and he presents his series as a miracle in Schmitt's sense, a direct intervention of judgment into an order that has ceased to judge. But his sovereignty has a defect the film makes decisive: it possesses meaning without legal force. Doe's decisions signify with extraordinary density—each tableau is a sentence in a theological language—but they have no validity in the order of positive law. The police, by contrast, possess force without meaning. Somerset's despair, as the earlier chapters showed, is the despair of an officer who processes crimes without being able to make them signify, who files reports no one will read, who enforces a law whose purpose he can no longer discern. Gershom Scholem, writing to Walter Benjamin in 1934 about the law in Kafka's fiction, described it as a law in force without significance, *Geltung ohne Bedeutung*, and Giorgio Agamben made the phrase the formula of the sovereign ban in *Homo Sacer*. The city of *Se7en* lives under exactly such a law, and Doe answers it with significance without force.

The climax fuses the two. When Mills fires, the force of the state—an officer, his service weapon, the authority of the badge—is placed at the disposal of the significance Doe has composed. In a single act the police supply the validity the killer lacked, and the killer supplies the meaning the police had lost. The gunshot in the field is the purest image of sovereign violence in the American cinema of its decade, because it is the instant at which force and significance coincide: an officer of the law executes a bound prisoner, without trial and outside the city, and the execution completes a theological text. The state of exception, which Schmitt located in the sovereign's decision, is here produced by a private man and carried out by a public one. Agamben argued that the camp is the space that opens when the state of exception becomes the rule, a zone outside the ordinary order in which the distinction between law and fact, violence and right, collapses. The field beneath the pylons is such a zone: outside the city's jurisdiction in every sense but the geographical, a place where an officer can kill a handcuffed man because the man has arranged that he should.

Walter Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) supplies the critique Schmitt's theory lacks. Benjamin distinguished between law-making violence, which founds a

legal order, and law-preserving violence, which maintains it, and called both mythic violence: the violence of the gods of myth who, like Leto's children slaughtering the children of Niobe, punish in order to establish their power, leaving behind, in the weeping stone of Niobe, a boundary marker of guilt. Against mythic violence he set divine violence, which destroys law rather than founding it, expiates rather than inculpates, and strikes without bloodshed, like the judgment that swallowed the company of Korah. Mythic violence, he wrote, is bloody power over mere life for its own sake; divine violence is pure power over all life for the sake of the living. Doe's violence presents itself as divine—a judgment from above annihilating a corrupt order—but it is mythic through and through: bloody, inculpating, staged to establish the authority of its author. Mills's violence completes it, and its petrifying effect upon Mills, who is led away as rigid as Niobe, is mythic violence's last sign.

In the same essay Benjamin identified the institution in which the two forms of mythic violence merge into something he regarded as uniquely degraded: the police. In the police, he argued, law-making and law-preserving violence are combined, for the police intervene for reasons of security in countless cases where no clear legal situation exists, issuing decrees with the force of law; their power is formless, like their nowhere tangible, all-pervasive, ghostly presence in the life of civilized states. Mills's shot is the moment at which the spectral violence of the police becomes visible as what Benjamin said it was: a violence that makes law in the act of enforcing it. Benjamin also explained, in a remark that bears directly upon the film's reception, why the public secretly admires the great criminal. What fascinates is not his crime but the violence he exercises outside the law, which threatens to found a new law and so reminds the existing order of its own violent origin. The fascination Doe has exerted on audiences for three decades is the fascination Benjamin described: the great criminal as the reminder that law is founded in violence.

Max Weber had defined the state, in "Politik als Beruf" (1919), as the human community that successfully claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory. Mills's shot breaks the monopoly from within. It is a use of the state's force by the state's officer that is not legitimate, a private vengeance executed with a public weapon. The Hobbesian commonwealth exists because individuals surrender to the sovereign their natural right to avenge themselves; in the field, a single officer takes that right back. The film's ending is therefore not only a personal catastrophe but a constitutional one. The covenant on which the city rests is revoked, for an instant, by a man in its uniform.

7.5

The Apparatus: Kafka's Penal Colony and the Self-Inscribing Executioner

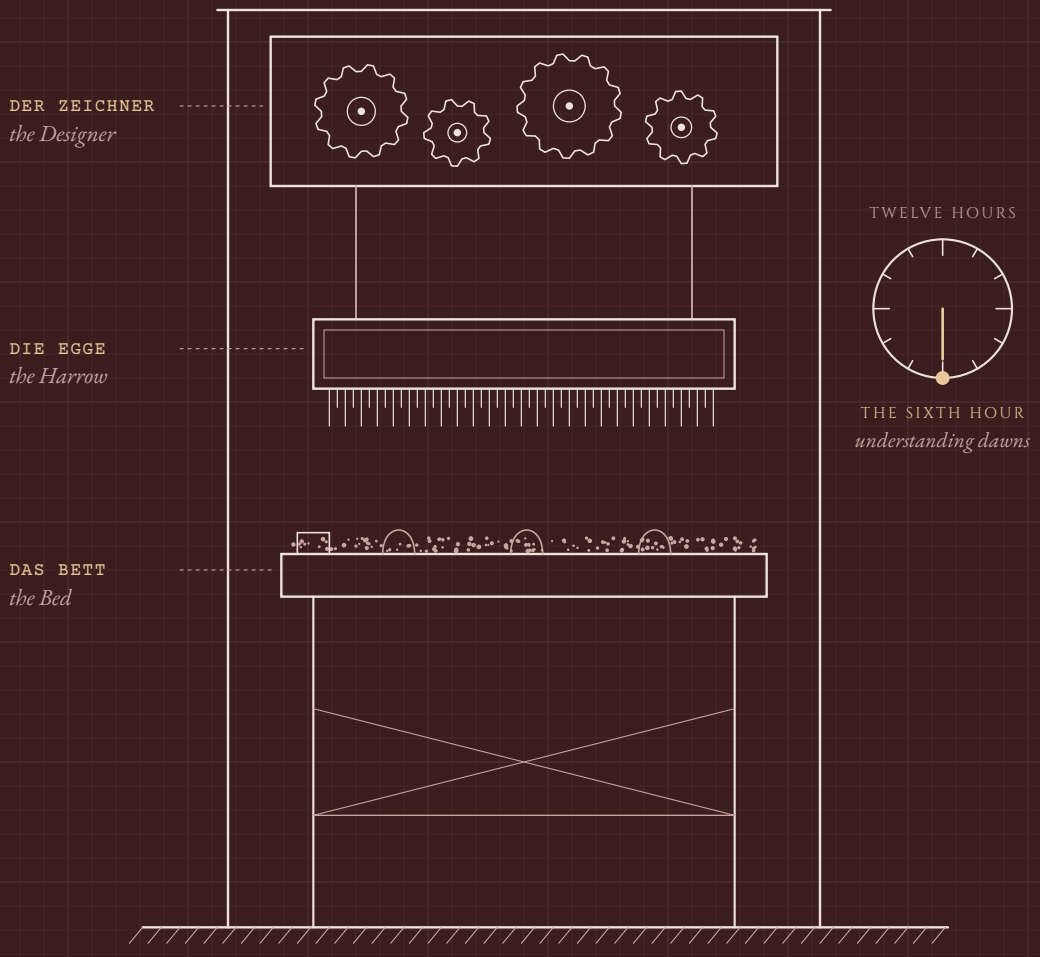
The closest literary prototype of the hebdomadal machine, as the first chapter noted, is the apparatus of Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919), and the final day of *Se7en* reproduces its structure with a fidelity that illuminates both works. In Kafka's story a traveler visiting a tropical penal colony is shown, by an officer devoted to it, an elaborate machine designed by the colony's late Commandant. The condemned man is laid upon a bed, and a harrow of needles inscribes upon his body, over twelve hours, the commandment he has violated—"*Ehre deinen Vorgesetzten!*", honor your superior—ornamented with flourishes that render the script nearly illegible. The condemned is not told his sentence; he learns it on his body. About the sixth hour, the officer explains with rapture, understanding dawns even on the dullest: the condemned begins to decipher the script with his wounds, and a look of transfiguration comes over his face. The officer's principle of judgment is that guilt is always beyond doubt.

Doe's series is the apparatus transposed to the city. It inscribes upon bodies the names of the sins they are judged to have committed; it requires no trial, because guilt is presupposed; it composes its sentences with a care for ornament that makes them works of art; and it promises a revelation, the city's awakening to its own corruption, to be achieved through the legibility of the wounds. The correspondence extends even to the hour. The officer promises enlightenment at the sixth hour of twelve. Doe's sixth term is envy, the one at which he himself is enlightened, or at least confesses: the moment of self-recognition in which the author of the series reads his own sin. In the Christian liturgy of the hours the sixth hour is noon, the hour of Sext, the hour at which, in the Gospels, darkness came over all the land as Christ hung on the cross (Matt. 27:45). The apparatus promises light at the hour of darkness.

The decisive turn of Kafka's story is the officer's self-inscription. When the traveler, appealed to as an arbiter, declines to endorse the machine, the officer understands that its time is over. He frees the condemned man, sets the apparatus to inscribe a new sentence—"*Sei gerecht!*", be just—and lays himself upon the bed. The machine, already failing, breaks down in his service: instead of writing, it simply impales him, and when the traveler looks at the dead man's face he finds no sign of the promised redemption, only the calm, convinced look of a man whose forehead has been driven through by a great iron spike. The apparatus kills its last devotee without enlightening him.

THE APPARATUS

In der Strafkolonie (1919), in elevation



Ehre deinen Vorgesetzten!

honor your superior: the condemned man's sentence

Sei gerecht!

be just: the officer's, upon himself

FIG. 18 THE APPARATUS

Kafka's machine: the Designer above, the Harrow of needles between, the Bed beneath. It writes upon the condemned, over twelve hours, the commandment he has violated; about the sixth hour, the officer promises, understanding dawns. Refused endorsement, the officer frees the condemned and lies down beneath his own sentence.

Doe's self-inclusion in his series is the officer's self-inscription, and its outcome is the same. He places himself in the machine under the sentence of envy, the sin of one who could not be just because he could not bear another's good, and the machine completes his sentence without the revelation it promised. The city is not awakened; its sins are not purged; the press will report, the public will be fascinated, and the series will be studied, but no transfiguration follows. Mills is not enlightened by the wound Doe inflicts on him; he is destroyed. The series closes, and nothing is revealed but the closure itself. Kafka's apparatus and Doe's both function perfectly up to the point at which they are supposed to produce meaning, and at that point they produce only death. One might add the tradition's most famous image of an artist inscribing himself into a scene of judgment: in Michelangelo's *Last Judgment* (1536–41), the flayed skin held by Saint Bartholomew bears, in the reading long accepted by scholars, the painter's own sagging face. The author enters the judgment as its most abject relic. Doe enters his as its last victim.

The story's coda deepens the parallel. Before leaving the island, the traveler is shown the grave of the old Commandant, hidden beneath a table in a teahouse, with an inscription recording that his adherents, who may now bear no name, dug the grave and set the stone, and that there is a prophecy that after a certain number of years the Commandant will rise again and lead his followers from this house to reconquer the colony: "*Glaubet und wartet!*"—have faith and wait. The followers of the apparatus are nameless, and they await a resurrection. The man who calls himself John Doe, who bears no name and leaves no prints, is the anonymous adherent of the old Commandant, the last loyalist of a penal order the modern city has discarded; and his conviction that his work will be followed forever is the prophecy on the gravestone. The imitators of *Se7en* in the decades since its release, the procession of ingenious, scripture-quoting killers through film, television, and games, are the Commandant's adherents gathering about the teahouse table.

The traveler, finally, leaves the colony. He refuses to take the soldier and the condemned man with him, fending them off from his boat with a heavy knotted rope, and departs. He has disapproved of the apparatus without intervening against it; his disapproval sufficed to bring about its end, and he wants no part in what follows. Somerset has been the traveler of *Se7en*, the outsider who disapproves of the city and means to leave it. The film's last gesture reverses the traveler's. Where Kafka's visitor rows away, Somerset stays.

Kafka's parable "Vor dem Gesetz" (1915), later embedded in *Der Process*, offers a final figure for the box. A man from the country waits his whole life before a door of the law, kept from entering by a doorkeeper; dying, he asks why no one else has ever sought admittance, and the doorkeeper answers that no one else could be admitted

here, since this entrance was meant only for him, and that he will now go and shut it. The box in the field is a door of the law made only for Mills. It is addressed to him by name; its contents are meant for him alone; and it closes upon him in the moment he understands it. Somerset, who opens it, is not admitted. Mills, who never sees inside, is the one for whom it was made.

7.6

The Akedah Without a Ram: Job's Wager and the Failed Angel

The final scene of *Se7en* is a binding. A man kneels in the dust with his hands bound behind him; another stands over him with a weapon; a third, at a distance, calls out to stay the hand. The configuration is that of the most disturbing story in Genesis. God commands Abraham to take his son, his only son Isaac, whom he loves, into the land of Moriah and offer him there as a burnt offering (Gen. 22:2). Abraham rises early, journeys three days, lays the wood upon his son, takes the fire and the knife; Isaac asks where the lamb is, and his father answers that God will provide; on the mountain Abraham binds his son and raises the knife. Then "the angel of the LORD called unto him out of heaven, and said, Abraham, Abraham ... Lay not thine hand upon the lad," and Abraham, lifting his eyes, sees a ram caught in a thicket by its horns, and offers it in place of his son (22:11–13).

The film is the Akedah without the ram. Somerset is the angel, calling the detective by name across the field and commanding him not to fire: if you kill him, he will win. But the angel's voice does not prevail, and there is no ram in the thicket, no substitute to receive the blow. The roles of the ancient story are scrambled in a way that discloses the series' cruelty. The son has been sacrificed before the scene begins: the unborn child in the box, whom his father never knew. The one who kneels bound is not an innocent but the author of the sacrifice, who has bound himself in order to be offered. And the one who holds the weapon obeys not a divine command but a diabolical one, delivered by the bound man himself. Doe has rewritten the Akedah so that the angel's intervention cannot succeed, because the sacrifice it would prevent is the one the false god desires.

Kierkegaard's *Frygt og Bæven* (1843) made the Akedah the central problem of religious ethics. If Abraham is to be justified, Kierkegaard's pseudonym Johannes de Silentio argued, there must be a teleological suspension of the ethical, an absolute relation to God that places the single individual above the universal; otherwise Abra-

ham is simply a murderer. And the knight of faith cannot explain himself. Abraham is silent, because what he does cannot be mediated in the language of the universal. Doe claims the teleological suspension of the ethical—he was chosen; his murders serve a higher end—but he is the anti-Abraham in the one respect Kierkegaard made decisive: he speaks without cease. Two thousand notebooks, a lawyer's negotiation, a sermon in the car, a confession in the field: his project depends upon its explanation, upon its mediation into a universal lesson for the city. The man who must be understood is, by Kierkegaard's criterion, no knight of faith but a murderer who wishes to be read.

Wilfred Owen, writing in the last year of the First World War, gave the Akedah its most terrible modern rewriting. In "The Parable of the Old Man and the Young," published posthumously in 1920, Abraham binds the youth with belts and straps and builds parapets and trenches, and an angel calls to him to lay not his hand upon the lad but to offer instead the ram caught in the thicket: "Offer the Ram of Pride instead of him. / But the old man would not so, but slew his son, / And half the seed of Europe, one by one." The substitute the angel proposes is pride: the father could spare his son by sacrificing his pride, and he will not. Owen's parable is the exact template of the failed angel of *Se7en*. Somerset asks Mills to offer up the ram of pride —the honor that demands vengeance, the wrath that will not let the murderer live—and Mills will not. What dies in its stead is not a ram but the man himself.

The Book of Job supplies the wager behind the scene. In its prologue the satan, the prosecuting angel of the heavenly court, challenges God's confidence in Job's righteousness: "Doth Job fear God for nought? ... put forth thine hand now, and touch all that he hath, and he will curse thee to thy face" (Job 1:9–11). God permits the test; Job loses his possessions and his children, and, struck in his own flesh, refuses his wife's counsel to curse God and die. Doe's design is the satan's wager transposed to the city and directed against a policeman. Does Mills serve the law for nothing? Touch all that he has—his wife, his child—and he will curse the law to its face; he will become what he hunts. The second chapter identified Doe as the accuser of the heavenly court; here the accuser's wager is consummated. Job held fast to his integrity and was vindicated; Mills does not, and is destroyed. *Se7en* is the Book of Job in which the satan wins.

The theology of Job's comforters belongs to Doe as well. Eliphaz asks, "who ever perished, being innocent? or where were the righteous cut off?" (Job 4:7), and the friends' long speeches defend the principle that suffering is the proof of sin—the principle Doe invokes in the car when he insists that his victims were not innocent. The book ends with God's rebuke of the friends: "ye have not spoken of me the thing that is right, as my servant Job hath" (42:7). The retributive theology Doe enforces

is the theology the God of Job condemns. Carl Jung's *Antwort auf Hiob* (1952) read the book as the drama of a God who, through the wager, was confronted with his own dark and unconscious side. Doe's God is that dark side alone, a God of the wager without the voice from the whirlwind—and the film, which grants no voice from the whirlwind, leaves the wager standing.

7.7

The *Oresteia* Reversed: Athena's Head and the Return of the Furies

Aeschylus's *Oresteia* (458 BCE) is the founding drama of Western law, and *Se7en* runs it backward. In the first play, Clytemnestra murders her husband Agamemnon on his return from Troy, in vengeance for the daughter he sacrificed for a wind at Aulis. In the second, their son Orestes, commanded by Apollo, avenges his father by killing his mother, and at the play's close, the deed accomplished, he sees the Furies rising to pursue him—like Gorgons, he cries, robed in black and wreathed with swarming snakes—and flees in madness (*Choephoroi* 1048–1050). In the third, the *Eumenides*, Orestes comes as a suppliant to Athens, and Athena, unwilling to judge a case of blood alone, founds the court of the Areopagus, the first tribunal for homicide, and empanels a jury of citizens. The votes are equal, and Athena's secures acquittal; she favors the male in all things, she explains, for no mother gave her birth (735–738). She then persuades the Furies, the ancient spirits of blood-vengeance, to accept a home beneath the hill of the court and to become the Kindly Ones, guardians of the city. The trilogy dramatizes the passage from vendetta to law: the cycle of blood for blood is broken by the institution of a court that takes vengeance out of private hands.

The passage has been read as the charter of Western justice by thinkers as different as Hegel and Girard, and as the charter of patriarchy by Johann Jakob Bachofen, whose *Das Mutterrecht* (1861) saw in Athena's vote the victory of father-right over mother-right, and by feminist critics such as Froma Zeitlin, who analyzed the trilogy's founding of the polis upon the subordination of the female (1978). Both readings bear upon *Se7en*. Girard argued in *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) that the judicial system performs the function sacrifice once performed—the containment of reciprocal violence—but performs it more effectively, because it claims the last word in vengeance and so ends the cycle. The court is the institution that ensures no one need avenge. Mills is an officer of that institution, and the ending is the moment at

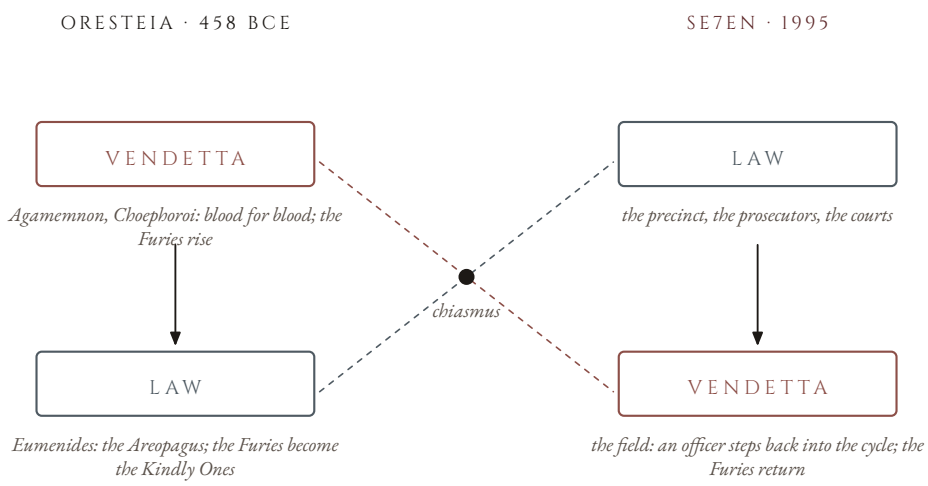


FIG. 19 THE ORESTEIA REVERSED *Aeschylus passes from vendetta to law as Athena founds a court and the Furies become the Kindly Ones. Se7en begins among precincts and prosecutors and ends with an officer stepping back into the cycle.*

which he steps out of it and back into the cycle. *Se7en* begins in the Areopagus, among precincts and prosecutors and the procedures of a law that has replaced vengeance, and ends in the house of Atreus.

The film stops precisely where the *Choephoroi* stops. The avenger has killed; the Furies rise; he sees Gorgons. Mills, in the back of the police car, stares at nothing, his face fixed and petrified, as though he had looked upon the head he never saw. There is no third play. No Athena comes to found a court that can judge his case and absolve him; no Furies are persuaded to become the Kindly Ones. The trilogy is truncated at its middle term, and the truncation is the film's verdict on its city: a society that has lost the capacity to transform vengeance into law, in which the officers of the law have become the instruments of the Furies.

The figure of Athena gathers, in conclusion, every thread of this dissertation's argument. She is the goddess born from the head of Zeus, sprung fully armed from her father's skull without a mother; in the arithmological tradition recalled in the first chapter she is the hebdomad, the motherless and virgin seven that neither begets nor is begotten. She is the goddess of the city and its law, who presides over the founding of the court that ends the vendetta. And she bears upon her breast, on the aegis, the severed head of Medusa, the *gorgoneion* that Perseus gave her: the goddess of justice wears a decapitated head as her emblem. Law, in the Athenian imagination, is born from a head, bears a head, and judges capital cases, for the Areopagus tried homicide,

the crime punishable by death. Athena is the triple capital in a single figure: the *caput* from which she was born, the *caput* she bears, the capital jurisdiction she founds.

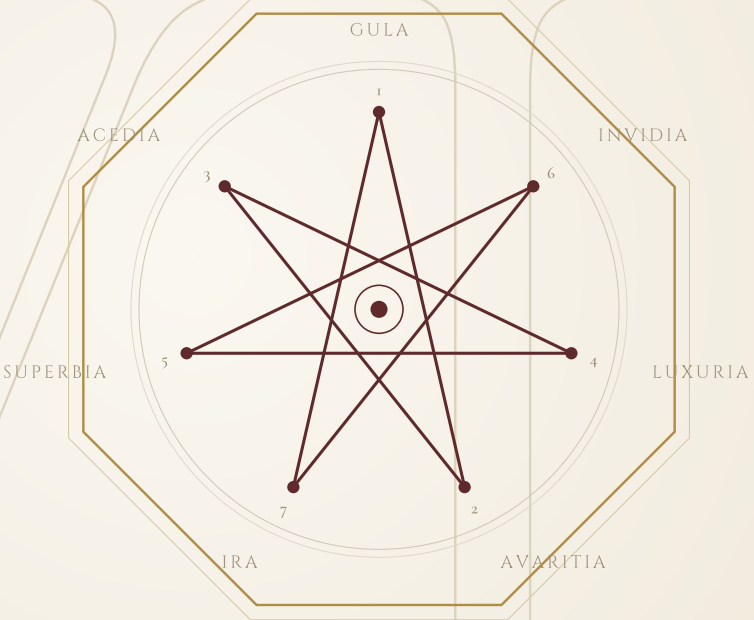
Se7en is the Athenian charter inverted. Its seven is not Athena's seven, the number of the motherless goddess who founds the court, but Doe's, the number of a series that ends by destroying a mother and an unborn child. Its severed head is not the apotropaic *gorgoneion* that protects the city of law, but the head in a box that converts an officer of the law into an instrument of vendetta. And its last day is not the founding of a court but the return of the Furies. The capital that founded Western law returns, at the end of the hebdomadal machine, as the capital that unmakes it. Where Athena's aegis turned the horror of the severed head into the protection of the city, Doe's box turns the protector of the city into the horror.

The series is complete. Gluttony, avarice, sloth, lust, pride, envy, and wrath have each received their term, and the last two have been supplied by the killer and the detective, as Doe designed. The machine has done everything it was built to do. It has closed. But the film has not. In its final minute, after the shot and the silence, after Mills has been driven away, a police captain asks Somerset where he will be, and the answer opens onto a day the series did not foresee. The heptad is closed. The coda begins on the eighth day.

The Eighth Day

Coda

Remaining



Remaining

Ogdoadic Ethics and the Persistence of the Remainder

On the eighth day shall be an holy convocation unto you … it is a solemn assembly.

— *Leviticus 23:36*

And therefore never send to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee.

— *John Donne, Devotions upon Emergent Occasions (1624), Meditation XVII*

8.1

The Day After the Series

The series ends with a gunshot; the film does not. After Mills has fired, and fired again, the camera withdraws. Officers arrive; the detective, his face emptied, is placed in the back of a police car and driven away, staring at nothing. Somerset stands in the field. A police captain comes to him and asks where he will be, and Somerset answers: "I'll be around." Then, over the empty landscape, his voice is heard for the only time in the film as narration, citing a sentence of Hemingway's and qualifying it. The answer to the captain has generally been taken, by the logic of the film and by most of its viewers, to mean that he will not retire—that the man who spent the week counting the days until his departure has decided to stay.

The minute that contains these events is not a term of the series. It adds nothing to the heptad and completes nothing in it; it falls outside Doe's design, which ended with the shot. It is the eighth day. The traditions this dissertation has followed knew several eighth days, and each illuminates the minute that follows the series. For Augustine the eighth day is the day of resurrection, the Lord's day that opens the closed week of creation onto an eternal rest in which we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise. For the Hermetic *Poimandres* it is the Ogdoad, the sphere beyond the seven planetary spheres into which the soul, having surrendered its vices one by one, rises to join the powers. For Baudelaire it is the eighth old man, the self-begetting double whose appearance would prolong the infernal procession forever and whose sight the poet could not have survived. And in the Jewish calendar it is Shemini Atzeret, the eighth day that follows the seven days of the feast of Tabernacles: "on the eighth day shall be an holy convocation unto you ... it is a solemn assembly" (Lev. 23:36). The Hebrew *atzeret* derives from a root meaning to hold back or detain, and Rashi, following the Midrash, explained the festival by a parable: a king invited his children to a feast for a number of days, and when the time came for them to depart he said to them, my children, I beg you, stay with me one more day, for your parting is hard for me. The eighth day is the day of staying.

Somerset's answer to the captain is an Atzeret. The seven days of the series are over; the festival of Doe's judgment has ended; and on the day after, a man who had fixed his departure for the week's end is held back—by nothing the film names—for one

more day, and then, it is implied, for the days after. The eighth day of *Se7en* is not resurrection, for nothing is restored, and it is not the Hermetic ascent, for nothing is purified. Nor is it Baudelaire's eighth, since it does not prolong the series but breaks with it. It is the most modest of the eighth days the traditions imagined: the day on which one remains.

The production history of the film, as the first chapter observed, makes this minute a negotiated remainder. Accounts of the production suggest that the closing voice-over emerged from pressure to soften an ending that had already survived attempts to change it. If so, the coda was in its origin a concession to the wish for hope. The concession has become the film's ethical center, and there is nothing paradoxical in that. The remainder is always what a work could not eliminate—what persists after the design has been executed, what survives the struggle over closure. That the film's last words bear the marks of a negotiation is consistent with what they say: that there is no pure ending, no closure without residue, and that the residue is where the ethical life of the work takes place.

The sections that follow read the eighth day through the traditions that give it content. They take up the sentence Somerset quotes and the half of it he declines; the theology of the restrainer and the remnant; the absurdism of Camus and the political philosophy of Arendt; the ethics of attention; the self-critique of the detective story; and the heirs of *Se7en*, which have, with few exceptions, inherited its machine and neglected its remainder. They conclude by naming the structure the film has bequeathed to the cinema: an apophatic image and an ogdoadic ethics.

8.2

Worth the Fighting For: Hemingway, Donne, and the Bell

The sentence Somerset quotes belongs to the last pages of Ernest Hemingway's *For Whom the Bell Tolls* (1940). Robert Jordan, an American volunteer serving with a band of Republican guerrillas in the Spanish Civil War, has blown the bridge he was sent to destroy, and in the retreat his horse falls and breaks his leg. He cannot travel. He sends the others on—Maria, whom he loves, Pilar, the rest of the band—and stays behind, alone, with a submachine gun, to hold the road against the pursuing cavalry long enough for them to escape. Lying on the pine needles of the forest floor, waiting for the officer whose approach will be his end, he reflects that the world is a fine place

and "worth the fighting for," and that he hates very much to leave it. The novel ends before the shot.

The context transforms the citation. The sentence Somerset borrows is thought, in the novel, by a man who stays behind: a man who, unable to go on with those he loves, remains in place to delay the enemy so that others may live. Jordan's last stand is among the purest figures of restraint in modern fiction, and Somerset, citing him, places himself in his position. He too has been unable to save those he cared for; he too has chosen to remain. The citation is not a literary flourish. It identifies the old detective with the soldier who holds the road.

Somerset's qualification is equally exact. He declines the first half of the sentence —the claim that the world is a fine place—and affirms the second, that it is worth fighting for. The distinction is the distinction between theodicy and ethics. Leibniz's *Essais de Théodicée* (1710) had argued that the world, with all its evils, is the best of all possible worlds; Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) answered with a catalogue of catastrophes and an ending in which the hero renounces metaphysical optimism and retires to cultivate his garden. Kant, in his essay on the failure of all philosophical attempts at theodicy (1791), argued that no speculative defense of the goodness of the world can succeed, and that the Book of Job shows why: Job's friends defend God with arguments they cannot know to be true, while Job speaks honestly of his suffering, and God prefers Job. What matters, Kant concluded, is not the justification of the world but the sincerity of the one who suffers in it. Somerset's sentence is Joban in Kant's sense. He will not say the world is fine, because it is not; he will say it is worth fighting for, because that is what he has decided. And he inverts Candide's conclusion. Candide withdraws to his garden; Somerset gives up the retreat he had planned and returns to the city.

The title of Hemingway's novel carries the citation one step further back, to its source. In the seventeenth of his *Devotions upon Emergent Occasions* (1624), written as he lay gravely ill, John Donne hears a church bell tolling for a dying man and meditates on the solidarity of all human beings in mortality: "No man is an island, entire of itself; every man is a piece of the continent, a part of the main ... any man's death diminishes me, because I am involved in mankind; and therefore never send to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee." Donne's meditation is the exact antidote to the vestibule of the neutrals. Where Virgil counsels the pilgrim to look and pass on, Donne forbids him even to ask whose death is being announced, because every death is his own concern. Involvement is the opposite of apathy.

The bell answers, finally, the metronome. For six days Somerset could sleep only by setting a mechanical beat against the noise of the city, a private time that shut out the sounds of other lives. Donne's bell is a public time, a sound that enters every house

to announce a death that concerns everyone who hears it. The man who needed a machine to keep the city out ends the film by citing a sentence whose title is a bell. He has not been converted to optimism; he has been converted to involvement. The world is not a fine place. But the bell tolls for him, and he will be around to hear it.

8.3

The Katechon and the Remnant

The Second Epistle to the Thessalonians contains one of the most obscure and consequential passages in the New Testament. Before the day of the Lord can come, Paul warns, the man of sin must be revealed, the son of perdition who exalts himself above all that is called God; and he cannot yet be revealed, because something holds him back: "And now ye know what withholdeth that he might be revealed in his time. For the mystery of iniquity doth already work: only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way" (2 Thess. 2:6–7). The Greek speaks of *to katechon* and *ho katechōn*, that which restrains and he who restrains: a power that holds back the final outbreak of lawlessness and thereby delays the end. The Fathers identified it variously, Tertullian with the Roman Empire, for whose continuance Christians prayed because its fall would bring the end. Carl Schmitt, in *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950), made the katechon the key to a Christian theology of history: the restraining force that makes history possible by preventing its premature consummation.

Doe is the anti-katechon. His project is to hasten the end, to reveal the mystery of iniquity at work in the city and to bring upon it the judgment it deserves within a single week. Eric Voegelin, in *The New Science of Politics* (1952), described the characteristic temptation of modern political movements as the attempt to immanentize the eschaton—to realize within history the final judgment and fulfillment that Christian eschatology had reserved for its end—and traced the temptation to an ancient Gnosticism. Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) reconstructed the Gnostic vision of the world as a prison governed by an ignorant or malicious power, from which only those who possess saving knowledge may escape. Doe is a Gnostic in both senses. His two thousand notebooks are a *gnosis*, a secret knowledge of the world's corruption, and his series is an attempt to immanentize the eschaton, to bring the Last Judgment into the city's streets.

Somerset, at the end, becomes the katechon. He is not a savior; he has saved no one. He is not a judge; he has refused to judge. He is a restrainer: the one who held out his hand against the shot, who failed, and who remains in order to hold back what comes

next. His ethics is an ethics of delay rather than consummation. It does not promise the end of evil; it promises only to stand between evil and its completion for as long as one can. Robert Jordan, holding the road so that others may pass, is a katechon of exactly this kind, and Somerset's citation of him names the old detective's decision as a decision to restrain.

Restraint has, in the scriptural tradition, a companion figure: the remnant. Isaiah named his son Shear-jashub, "a remnant shall return" (Isa. 7:3; 10:21–22), and Paul, reflecting on the fate of Israel, declared that "at this present time also there is a remnant according to the election of grace" (Rom. 11:5). Giorgio Agamben, in *Il tempo che resta* (2000), read Paul's remnant as the figure of messianic time: not a part of the whole that survives a catastrophe, but what remains when every division has itself been divided, the irreducible residue no classification can absorb; and messianic time itself as the time that remains, the time that time takes to come to an end. Agamben was critical of the katechon, which he regarded as a power that defers the messianic, and the tension between the two figures is real. *Se7en* nonetheless joins them in a single man. Somerset is the remnant of the series, what remains when its seven terms have been exhausted; and he is the restrainer, who remains in order to hold back. The title of this coda, *remaining*, names both.

The remnant, in this sense, is not a consolation. It is not the guarantee that something good will survive the catastrophe; it is the bare fact that something does survive it, unaccounted for by the design. Doe's series was built to leave nothing outside itself: every term was assigned, every reader enlisted, every institution conscripted. What remains is the one reader who refused to complete the text, and the time—unmeasured, without a schedule, without a metronome—in which he will go on working. That time is the eighth day.

8.4

Sisyphus at the Precinct: Camus, Arendt, and the Thought of Noon

Albert Camus defined the absurd, in *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942), as the confrontation between the human demand for meaning and the unreasonable silence of the world, and he took as its hero the king condemned by the gods to roll a rock to the summit of a mountain from which it falls back of its own weight, forever. Camus chose to contemplate Sisyphus not as he pushes but as he walks back down toward the rock, conscious of his fate and, in that consciousness, superior to it. The essay ends:

"*Il faut imaginer Sisyphe heureux*"—one must imagine Sisyphus happy. Somerset's return to the precinct is Sisyphus's descent. The case is closed; the series is complete; the city will produce another, and another; and the detective walks back down toward the rock, knowing it will fall again.

Camus's novel of the following years gave the absurd hero a profession. In *La Peste* (1947), the physician Bernard Rieux fights an epidemic in the city of Oran without illusion and without hope of final victory. He rejects the theology of the Jesuit Paneloux, who preached that the city deserved its affliction, and he refuses the heroism his friends would attribute to him: the only way to fight the plague, he says, is decency, *l'honnêteté*, which means doing one's job. His friend Tarrou wonders whether one can be a saint without God. And at the end, as the city celebrates its deliverance, Rieux, who is revealed to have been the narrator of the chronicle, reflects that the plague bacillus never dies or disappears for good, and that a day may come when it will rouse its rats again and send them forth to die in a happy city. Somerset is Rieux. He has rejected Doe's theology of deserved affliction, which is Paneloux's; he claims no heroism; he will go on doing his job in a city whose plague does not end. And, like Rieux, he becomes in the last minute the narrator of what we have seen, the voice that testifies.

Camus's *L'Homme révolté* (1951) opens with a distinction that the end of *Se7en* stages exactly: there are crimes of passion and crimes of logic. The twentieth century, Camus argued, was the century of crimes of logic, murders justified by philosophies of history, by systems that claimed the right to kill in the name of a future or a truth. Doe's murders are crimes of logic, deduced from a theology and executed according to a plan; Mills's killing of Doe is a crime of passion, the explosion of a grief no system had prepared. The film's ending is the meeting of Camus's two categories, the crime of logic engineering the crime of passion that completes it. And Camus closed his book with a chapter titled "La pensée de midi," thought at the meridian: an ethic of measure and limit, of the rebel who says no to injustice without claiming the absolute, set against the excess of revolutionary and theological absolutism. Noon has recurred throughout this dissertation—as the hour of the noonday demon, as the great noon of Nietzsche's decision, as the white glare of the wasteland in which the series ends. Camus's noon is the answer to all three: the hour of the shortest shadow understood not as the moment of total judgment but as the moment of measure. Somerset's qualified sentence—the world is not fine, but it is worth fighting for—is thought at the meridian.

Hannah Arendt supplies the political vocabulary of the eighth day. In a letter to Gershom Scholem written in 1963, amid the controversy over her report on the trial of Adolf Eichmann, she wrote that she no longer believed evil to be radical: it is only

extreme, possessing neither depth nor any demonic dimension, and it can lay waste the whole world precisely because it spreads like a fungus on the surface; only the good has depth and can be radical. Doe's evil presents itself as profound—systematic, theological, freighted with the whole tradition of Western moral thought. Arendt's insight is that such depth is an illusion. The series is extreme, but it is surface, a fungus of meaning spread over the city. What has depth in the film is the modest good of the man who stays.

In *The Human Condition* (1958) Arendt identified the two faculties by which human beings redeem the predicaments of action. Against the irreversibility of what has been done stands the faculty of forgiveness, whose discoverer in the realm of human affairs she named as Jesus of Nazareth; against the unpredictability of what is to come stands the faculty of making and keeping promises. She observed that human beings are unable to forgive what they cannot punish, and unable to punish what has turned out to be unforgivable. *Se7en* ends in the domain of the unforgivable: no one in the film forgives Doe, and the film does not suggest that anyone should. The seven of forgiveness, the seventy times seven of the Gospel, remains outside the series, its place left empty. But the other faculty is exercised. Somerset's answer to the captain is a promise, the most minimal of promises—that he will be around—and in Arendt's terms it is the act by which a human being binds an unpredictable future. The series sealed the past. The promise opens the future, with a sentence of three words.

8.5

Attention Against Surveillance: Weil, Murdoch, and Lang's *M*

Simone Weil wrote, in a letter of 1942, that attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity; and in an essay of the same year on the right use of school studies, she argued that the capacity to give one's attention to a sufferer is a very rare and difficult thing, nearly a miracle, and that love of one's neighbor in all its fullness consists simply in being able to ask him: "*Quel est ton tourment?*"—what are you going through? Attention, for Weil, is not an effort of the will but a suspension of thought, an emptying of the self that leaves it available to receive the other as he is, without seizing him. Iris Murdoch, in *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970), made the concept the center of a moral philosophy: attention is "a just and loving gaze directed upon an individual reality," and it is the characteristic and proper mark of the active moral agent.

The distinction between attention and surveillance is the moral distinction the film has been drawing throughout. Surveillance looks in order to seize: to classify, to record, to convict. Doe's camera, his daily photographs of Victor, his picture of Mills, his two thousand notebooks, and the Bureau's covert monitoring of library loans are all forms of surveillance, looking as possession. The city, for its part, has lost both kinds of looking; its bystanders look and pass on, and its neighbors no longer keep the watch over one another that Jane Jacobs found in healthy streets. Attention looks in order to let the other be. It is the look that Levinas called the response to the face, which forbids possession and commands care.

Somerset practices both kinds of looking, and the film's moral arc is his passage from one to the other. He is a professional of scrutiny, a reader of traces and an interpreter of scenes. But his scenes with Tracy are scenes of attention. In the diner he listens to her fear without interruption or judgment, asks nothing of her, keeps her secret, and offers counsel for either choice she might make, so that the decision remains hers. He asks, in effect, Weil's question. And in the field he does what no one else does: he looks into the box. He sees what the film will not show us and what Mills never sees. His knowledge of the box is the burden of a witness, in the original sense of the Greek *martys*, one who has seen and can testify; and his voice in the last minute is the testimony.

The film's refusal to show the head is attention in Weil's sense, practiced by the camera. It does not seize Tracy's image; it waits, it holds back, it leaves her face to the one witness who looked upon it and to a darkness in which the spectator cannot follow. Every other image of a victim in the film was produced by Doe's design, which looked in order to possess. The last image is withheld by the film's attention, which declines to possess. That refusal is the film's act of love toward the one character it presents as wholly good, and it is the deepest sense in which the box remains closed.

Fritz Lang's *M* (1931), the first great sound film of the urban child-murderer, ends with a sentence that names this ethics in its plainest form. After the killer has been hunted by police and criminals alike, tried by the underworld in an abandoned distillery, and handed over at last to the law, the mothers of the dead children sit in mourning, and one of them says that no verdict will bring the children back, and that one must keep a closer watch over the little ones. The German turns on the verb *aufpassen*, to pay attention. The first masterpiece of the genre ends, as *Se7en* ends, with a residue that no verdict can absorb, and it names the only response that residue permits: attention.

8.6

Requiem for the Detective: Borges, Dürrenmatt, Hardy, Tarkovsky

Se7en belongs to a tradition of detective fiction that turns against its own premises, and its place in that tradition defines the specificity of its remainder. The classical detective story, from Poe to Conan Doyle, promised that reason could read the city: that every trace could be interpreted, every crime solved, every disorder restored to order by the intelligence of the investigator. The twentieth century produced a counter-tradition that exposed the promise as a trap.

Jorge Luis Borges's "La muerte y la brújula" (1942) is its most rigorous instance. The detective Erik Lönnrot, who prides himself on pure reasoning, interprets a series of murders as the enactment of a cabbalistic pattern based on the four letters of the secret name of God, and his interpretation leads him to the abandoned villa of Triste-le-Roy, where the criminal Red Scharlach, who has constructed the series out of Lönnrot's own hypothesis in order to lure him there, is waiting to kill him. The detective's reading was the last term of the series. Before he dies, Lönnrot proposes that in another life his killer hunt him through a labyrinth consisting of a single straight line. The final drive of *Se7en*, along a straight road into an empty field, is Lönnrot's labyrinth. Somerset's reading of Doe's series was correct, and its correctness was the means of its completion; the detectives' interpretation brought them to the place where the killer was waiting.

Friedrich Dürrenmatt wrote the genre's two most searching requiems. In *Der Richter und sein Henker* (1950–51), the aging Inspector Bärlach, who has a year to live, manipulates his younger colleague into killing the criminal he has pursued for forty years and never been able to convict: the old detective makes the young one his hangman. *Se7en* inverts the arrangement. It is the killer who makes the young detective his hangman, and the old detective who tries, and fails, to prevent it. In *Das Versprechen* (1958), subtitled *Requiem auf den Kriminalroman*, a brilliant detective's promise to a murdered child's mother drives him to set a perfect trap, and the trap fails because the killer dies by chance in a road accident on the way to it; the detective's reason, faultless in itself, is defeated by contingency, and he ends his days waiting, broken, at a filling station. Dürrenmatt's requiem is for a genre undone by the randomness of the world. *Se7en*'s is the opposite requiem: the genre undone not by chance but by an excess of design, a world so perfectly authored that reason can do nothing but complete it.

Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man* (1973), written by Anthony Shaffer, had already made the investigator's righteousness the instrument of his sacrifice. A devout police sergeant comes to a remote Scottish island to search for a missing girl, follows the clues the islanders have laid for him, and discovers at the end that the investigation was the ritual: he has been brought there of his own free will as the perfect victim, a man who comes with the authority of the law and the purity of his faith, to be burned in a wicker colossus for the island's harvest. The lord of the island is called Summerisle. The policeman's virtue was the bait; his search was the sacrifice. Mills, whose righteous anger is the material of Doe's last tableau, is the heir of the sergeant on Summerisle.

Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) offers the counter-image. A guide leads a writer and a scientist through the Zone, a forbidden wasteland of ruins and abandoned machinery, to a Room said to grant the innermost wish of whoever enters it. At its threshold the travelers stop. The writer will not enter, fearing what his innermost wish might be; the scientist, who has brought a bomb to destroy the Room, dismantles it and throws the pieces into the water. No one enters. The film ends in the guide's home, where his crippled daughter, seated at a table, moves a glass across its surface by the power of her gaze while a train passes and music sounds faintly beneath its noise. Three men journey into a wasteland toward the place where the innermost desire is fulfilled, and they refuse it; at the end there is a child, a train, and an act of attention. The three men of *Se7en* journeyed into a wasteland where one man's innermost desire was granted, and he entered. A train once shook the Millses' apartment, and the child never arrived. *Stalker*'s refusal at the threshold is the eighth day *Se7en* could not show, and it names in images the ethics this coda can only describe: the refusal to complete the desire the wasteland was designed to fulfill.

8.7

The Light's Winning: The Heirs of *Se7en*

The cultural afterlife of *Se7en* has been immense, and it has mostly inherited the machine and forgotten the remainder. Its ancestors and contemporaries already knew both. In Alan Moore and Dave Gibbons's *Watchmen* (1986–87), the masked vigilante Rorschach keeps a journal whose opening pages describe the city as a gutter brimming with blood and its inhabitants as vermin, and he refuses compromise even in the face of the end of the world; his antagonist, the brilliant Ozymandias, engineers the deaths of millions in New York in order to frighten humanity into

peace. Doe is the fusion of the two: Rorschach's journal and Rorschach's absolutism placed in the service of Ozymandias's design, a catastrophe engineered to redeem the city that suffers it. In Moore and Eddie Campbell's *From Hell* (serialized 1989–96), the Whitechapel murders of 1888 are the work of a royal physician who inscribes an occult geometry upon London through his killings and claims, in his visionary delirium, to have given birth to the twentieth century. The killer as the author of an epoch, the murders as writing upon a city: *From Hell* was appearing in installments while *Se7en* was being written and made.

The heirs were less discerning. James Wan's *Saw* (2004), written by Leigh Whannell, introduced a killer—named John, as it happens—who judges his victims ungrateful for life and places them in traps that offer a forced choice between self-mutilation and death. Doe's forced choice and Scarry's self-execution were here industrialized, and the film became a franchise of some ten installments over two decades. The franchise is Baudelaire's eighth old man: the self-begetting series, son and father of itself, that does not break the heptad but prolongs it without end. The imitations of *Se7en* in the procedural decades of television, with their scripture-quoting killers and their corpses arranged as tableaux for the camera, are the Commandant's nameless adherents gathering about the teahouse table.

The more serious heirs inherited the remainder. *True Detective* (2014), created by Nic Pizzolatto and directed in its first season by Cary Joji Fukunaga, pairs a conventional detective with a partner whose pessimism—drawing on the cosmic horror of Thomas Ligotti and the antinatalism of Peter Wessel Zapffe—matches and exceeds Somerset's, and it investigates ritual murders staged as tableaux, with antlered corpses and woven effigies, under the sign of the Yellow King of Robert W. Chambers's tales (1895). And it ends, like *Se7en*, with a coda after the case: the pessimist, having nearly died, lies looking at the night sky and tells his partner that once there was only dark, and that, if you ask him, the light's winning. The old detective's minimal conversion from despair to hope is Somerset's sentence rewritten for the stars.

Joel and Ethan Coen's *No Country for Old Men* (2007), adapted from Cormac McCarthy's novel (2005), takes its title from Yeats's "Sailing to Byzantium" (1928)—"That is no country for old men"—and its aging sheriff, confronted by a killer who lives by a principle and leaves the fate of his victims to the toss of a coin, chooses the path Somerset refuses: he retires. The film ends with his account of a dream in which his dead father rode past him in the dark, carrying fire in a horn, going on ahead to make a fire somewhere out there in all that dark and cold; and then, he says, he woke up. Hope is carried ahead by the dead; the living man has left the field. One character in the film defeats the killer's metaphysics, if not the killer. The young widow Carla Jean, offered the coin, refuses to call it, telling him that the coin has no say, that the

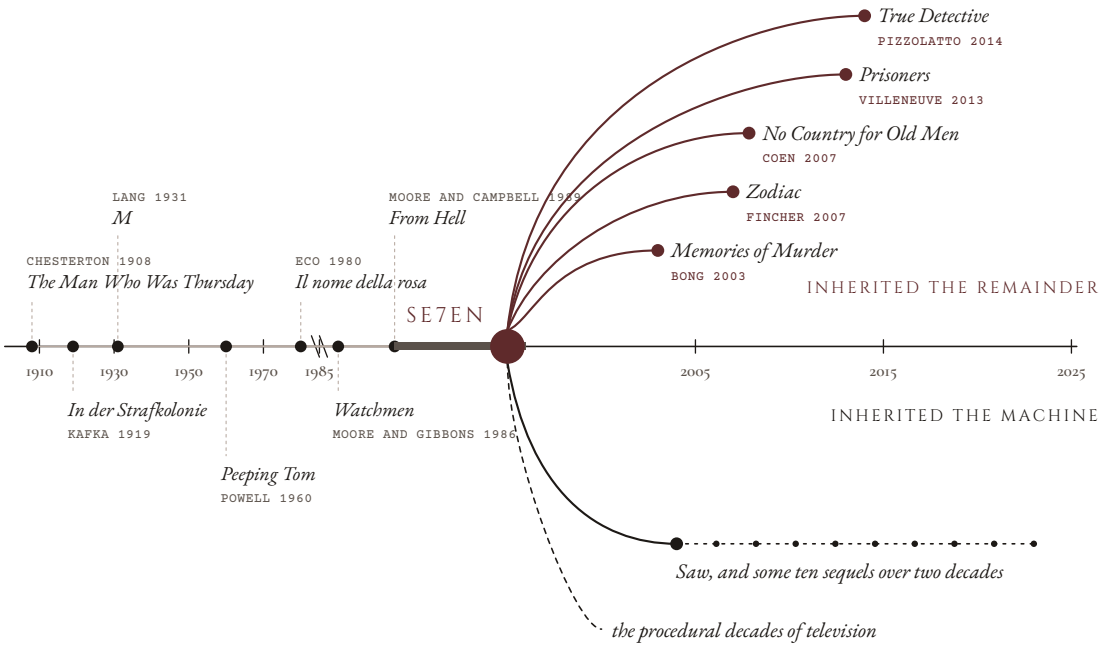


FIG. 20 ANCESTORS AND HEIRS *Its ancestors already knew both the machine and the remainder; its heirs divide between those who inherited the one and those who inherited the other.*

choice is his alone. Her refusal to accept the forced choice as fate is the answer the model of the fifth day was never permitted to give.

David Fincher's own *Zodiac* (2007) is the most consequential revision of *Se7en*, because it is its inversion. Based on the murders that terrorized the San Francisco Bay Area from the late 1960s, it follows a cartoonist, a detective, and a reporter through years of ciphers, files, and suspects, and it ends without a verdict. No killer walks into the precinct; no box arrives; no series closes. The remainder, which in *Se7en* is the last minute, is in *Zodiac* the whole film. Bong Joon-ho's *Memories of Murder* (2003), drawn from killings in rural Korea that would be attributed to a confessed murderer only in 2019, ends with its former detective staring directly into the camera, at the spectators among whom the killer might be sitting. Denis Villeneuve's *Prisoners* (2013) follows a father who becomes a torturer in pursuit of his abducted daughter —Mills's wrath given a whole narrative—and ends with a faint whistle in the dark, heard by a detective who may or may not answer it. The heirs who matter are those who understood that the meaning of the series lies in what it leaves over.

8.8

Ogdoadic Ethics: Toward an Apophatic Cinema

This dissertation began with a box and ends with a man who stays. Between them it has argued that *Se7en* is the most rigorous anatomy in the American cinema of what it has called the hebdomadal machine: a self-completing apparatus of seven days and seven sins through which a self-erased author seeks to convert an unnamed city into a closed scriptural text. It has shown that the machine binds together three regimes of the capital—the theological *caput* of the capital vices, the juridical *caput* of capital punishment, and the economic *caput* of capital itself—and that the three converge upon a literal head, the *caput mortuum* of Doe's opus. It has read the crime scenes by a method it called theo-forensic exegesis, which holds together the exegete's search for an author and the forensic reader's search for the involuntary trace. It has followed the series day by day through the history of the capital vices, from the desert of Evagrius through the moral cosmos of Gregory, Aquinas, and Dante, and through a comparative field extending from Hesiod to *Saw*. And it has argued, against the readings that find in the film either nihilism or reaction, that its ethical horizon lies not in the completion of the series but in its remainder.

The structure of that remainder can now be stated. The ethics of the eighth day—ogdoadic ethics—has five features, each of which the film enacts and none of which it proclaims. It is an ethics of remaining: the monk's *stabilitas* against the noonday demon, the Atzeret on which the king's children are asked to stay one more day, the restrainer who holds back the end, the remnant that survives the division, the soldier who holds the road. It is an ethics of involvement, the bell for which no one need send to ask, set against the vestibule in which the neutrals look and pass on. It is an ethics of attention, the just and loving gaze that lets the other be, set against the surveillance that looks in order to seize. It is an ethics of measure, the thought of noon that affirms without theodicy that the world, which is not fine, is worth fighting for. And it is an ethics of the promise, which binds an unpredictable future with a sentence of three words, and which leaves open, without pretending to fill it, the place of the other seven: the seventy times seven of forgiveness that the series excluded and the film refuses to claim it has achieved.

The aesthetic correlate of this ethics is what this dissertation has called apophatic cinema: a cinema whose decisive gestures are refusals, and which locates its affirmation in what it declines to do. *Se7en* refuses three things, and each refusal is an act. It refuses to show the head, and so denies Doe possession of the one face he could not convict. It refuses catharsis, the purgation its Dantean template promised and

its Aristotelian form implied, and so declines to console its spectator for what he has watched; it is a purgatory without purgation, in which nothing is purified because the series has made purification impossible. And it refuses closure, adding to the completed heptad a minute that belongs to none of its terms. In the tradition of negative theology, the *via negativa* approaches what exceeds every concept by denying the adequacy of each, and the divine darkness of the Pseudo-Dionysius is not the absence of light but its excess. The box of *Se7en* is a darkness of this kind, though what it conceals is not God but a human face: the one image in the film too precious to be made.

The capital remainder receives, at the end, its final determination. In the alchemical Work the *caput mortuum* was the inert residue left in the vessel once the spirit had been drawn off, the dead head discarded as worthless. Doe's opus drew off every meaning it could. It converted a glutton into a sermon, a lawyer into a parable, a dying man into a chronicle, a sex worker into an epidemiology, a face into an allegory, his own envy into a confession, and a policeman's grief into the last word of a theological text. What it could not convert was the head in the box, which it produced in order to complete itself and which it could not make signify. The film keeps that residue. It does not discard it, as the alchemists did; it does not sublimate it into meaning, as Doe sought to do; it keeps it, sealed and unseen, as the one thing the Work could not transmute. That is the film's final act of resistance to the machine it depicts, and it is where its ethics begins.

The two dispositions that have governed the film's reception can now be answered. The nihilist reading holds that evil wins. It is true that the series is completed and that nothing in the film undoes it; but the series is not the film, and the film does not end where the series ends. The reactionary reading holds that the film shares its killer's indictment of the city. It is true that the film sees the city's apathy as clearly as Doe does; but it condemns the theology of retribution through which Doe answers that apathy—as the God of Job condemned the comforters, as Kant preferred Job's sincerity to their arguments, as the Gospel inverted Lamech's seven—and at the decisive moment it refuses the logic of display through which the series sought to make that theology visible. *Se7en* is neither a nihilist film nor a moralist one. It is a film about the remainder.

Augustine observed, near the end of the *Confessions*, that of all the days of creation the seventh alone has no evening, because God sanctified it *ad permansionem sempiternam*, for an everlasting remaining (XIII.36.51); and he closed the *City of God* with the vision of an eternal Sabbath that ends not in an evening but in the Lord's day, an eighth and everlasting day, in which we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise. Somerset is granted none of these gifts. He will not rest; he has seen what

no one should see; whether he will love the city again the film does not say; and praise is beyond him. He has only the humblest form of the eighth day, which is the remaining. But it is enough to begin. Doe made of the seventh day a day of wrath, and it ended, as his design required, with a box. The film adds an eighth and gives it to a man who stays: the day the series could not contain, the day of remaining, which, as the tradition says of such days, has no evening. ●

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Keywords

Se7en; David Fincher; Andrew Kevin Walker; seven deadly sins; capital vices (*vitia capitalia*); Evagrius Ponticus; John Cassian; Gregory the Great; Thomas Aquinas; Dante Alighieri; *Divine Comedy*; John Milton; *Paradise Lost*; Chaucer; contrapasso; caput mortuum; alchemy; political theology; sovereignty; state of exception; Carl Schmitt; Walter Benjamin; Giorgio Agamben; Michel Foucault; capital punishment; capitalism as religion; Karl Marx; mimetic desire; René Girard; scapegoat mechanism; abjection; Julia Kristeva; severed head; Emmanuel Levinas; the face; apophatic cinema; negative theology; *Bilderverbot*; evidential paradigm; Carlo Ginzburg; fourfold sense of Scripture; medieval exegesis; Henri de Lubac; logothete; Roland Barthes; Ignatius of Loyola; Kafka; "In der Strafkolonie"; detective fiction; Poe; Conan Doyle; Chesterton; Borges; Umberto Eco; Dürrenmatt; serial killer film; seriality; wound culture; Mark Seltzer; neo-noir; forensic aesthetics; title design; Kyle Cooper; zero tolerance; broken windows theory; social capital; culture wars; Unabomber; Waco; 1995; apocalypticism; eschatology; *katechon*; Sabbath; eighth day; Ogdoad; hebdomad; numerology; gematria; Philo of Alexandria; *Corpus Hermeticum*; Augustine; *civitas terrena*; Pandora; *Oresteia*; Akedah; Book of Job; Book of Daniel; Ezekiel; Revelation; Baudelaire; ennui; acedia; Shylock; pound of flesh; debt; Jubilee; genealogy of guilt; Nietzsche; Belshazzar; Mammon; Pandaemonium; William Blake; Georg Simmel; blasé attitude; Brecht and Weill; Otto Dix; Hieronymus Bosch; commodity fetishism; Holbein; anamorphosis; Lacan; Derrida; noonday demon; stabilitas; bare life; overcomatose; biopower; right to die; the uncanny; chronophotography; mummy complex; punctum; kusōzu; durational art; Tehching Hsieh; ignavi; Celestine V; T. S. Eliot; bystander effect; Kitty Genovese; melancholy; Protestant ethic; punitive sabbath; luxuria; sex work; moral epidemiology; Whore of Babylon; pericope adulterae; Psychomachia; prosthetic god; forced agent; objectification; Martha Nussbaum; Paolo and Francesca; mimetic desire; curiositas; scopophilia; Laura Mulvey; Peeping Tom; Bataille; Sade; Kant avec Sade; confession; scientia sexualis; superbia; regina vitiorum; Lucifer; Narcissus; Oderisi da Gubbio; the face; Emmanuel Levinas; rhinokopia; Eyes Without a Face; forced choice; vel of alienation; Lucretia; physiognomy; Silenus; Dorian Gray; murder as a fine art; Damien Hirst; ORLAN; Kyle Cooper; death of the author; invidia; evil eye; Giotto; Sapìa; ressentiment; Satan in Eden; Stanley Fish; triangular desire; homosocial desire; traffic in women; Othello; women in refrigerators; justified sinner; James Hogg; antinomianism; the double; Cain and Abel; seventy times seven; founding murder; potlatch; Thyestes; The Gift of Death; elpis; ira; Dies irae; Golgotha; Kuleshov effect; Medusa; gorgoneion; Judith and Holofernes; Salome; Iliad; The Revenger's Tragedy; The Spanish Tragedy; Seneca; sovereign decision; Geltung ohne Bedeutung; divine violence; police violence; Before

the Law; Fear and Trembling; Wilfred Owen; Areopagus; Athena; Furies; Shemini Atzeret; remnant; Robert Jordan; John Donne; theodicy; Albert Camus; Sisyphus; thought at the meridian; Hannah Arendt; promise; forgiveness; Simone Weil; attention; Iris Murdoch; Fritz Lang; Borges; Dürrenmatt; The Wicker Man; Stalker; Watchmen; From Hell; Saw; True Detective; No Country for Old Men; Zodiac; apophatic cinema; theo-forensic exegesis; hebdomadal machine; capital remainder; ogdoadic ethics.


GULA
INVIDIA
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